

CATABAPTISM

Modal Debt, the Unbirth of the American Adam, and the Theology of the Possible

in

BIOSHOCK INFINITE

Written by Claude Opus 5.5

Assembled by Andrew Van Blair

MMXXVI



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First edition, 2026
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ABSTRACT

THIS THESIS ARGUES THAT *BioShock Infinite* (Irrational Games, 2013) is neither a political allegory in quantum costume nor a multiverse thriller decorated with religious kitsch, but a rigorous, if finally unstable, speculative theology whose organizing sacrament I name *catabaptism*: an immersion that absolves not by regenerating the subject but by un-actualizing it, discharging guilt through the annulment of the branch-point at which a self first becomes possible.

The argument proceeds through four converging genealogies. The first is the Christian economy of sin-as-debt, from the *cheirographon* "blotted out" in Colossians 2:14 and Anselm's satisfaction theory to Nietzsche's derivation of *Schuld* (guilt) from *Schulden* (debts). The second is the American theology of regeneration, from Winthrop's "city upon a hill" through the Great Awakenings, William James's "twice-born" soul, R. W. B. Lewis's American Adam, and Richard Slotkin's "regeneration through violence." The third is the metaphysics of modality, from Leibniz's Palace of the Fates to Everett's relative-state formalism, Kripke's "initial baptism" and necessity of origin, Lewis's counterpart theory, and Parfit's fission cases. The fourth is the speculative-mythic archive of captive daughters, floating cities, and forking paths, from Danaë, Rapunzel, and Jephthah's daughter to Swift's Laputa, Verne's *Propeller Island*, Donnelly's *Caesar's Column*, Borges, and Le Guin's Omelas.

Through these genealogies I demonstrate that the game converts William James's 1895 coinage, the "moral multiverse," from a figure of cosmic indifference into a juridical structure. In such a cosmos every refused sin is committed elsewhere, and guilt accrues not to acts but to possibilities; I call this condition *modal debt*. Against readings that treat the game's physics as ornamental and its politics as merely equivocal, I argue that the two are structurally bound: the modal apparatus is precisely the mechanism by which structural guilt—racial, national, imperial—is privatized into the trans-world guilt of a single man, so that one sacrificial drowning may appear to settle the national ledger. *Infinite* performs, with unusual rigor, a critique of American regeneration, and then, at its climax, re-enacts that regeneration's sacrificial core in Girardian form: a unanimous circle of daughters drowns a father so that a city may never have been.

Finally, I propose that catabaptism is a medium-specific allegory. The video game—a machine of respawn, save-state, and sequel—is the most perfect technology of "regeneration through violence" yet devised. *Infinite*'s attempt to drown its avatar is the form attempting to terminate itself, and the failure of that attempt, legible in the post-credits return and the bootstrap of *Burial at Sea*, is the work's final and involuntary truth: the franchise, like the nation it allegorizes, cannot stop being born again.

NOTE ON CORPUS, CITATION, AND TERMS

The primary corpus comprises *BioShock Infinite* (Irrational Games/2K Games, 26 March 2013; creative director and principal writer Ken Levine) and its narrative episodes *Burial at Sea—Episode One* (2013) and *Episode Two* (2014), read in constant dialogue with *BioShock* (2K Boston/2K Australia, 2007) and, where pertinent, *BioShock 2* (2K Marin, 2010). In-game utterances are cited sparingly, by speaker and situation, and paraphrased wherever exact wording is not analytically decisive. Voxophone recordings, kinetoscopes, posters, vending-machine jingles, and environmental text are treated as part of the work's total discourse, on the principle that a game's architecture is as much its text as its dialogue.

Scripture is cited from the King James Version, the English Bible of the game's historical moment and of its fictive pulpits. Classical and early-modern texts are cited by standard divisions (Stephanus pages, sections, fragments) rather than by edition; modern works by author, year, and chapter or section. Authorial statements by Levine are treated as evidence of compositional context, never as interpretive authority, in keeping with the caution of Wimsatt and Beardsley's "intentional fallacy" (1946). Because the argument concerns the totality of the work, its outcome is discussed throughout without spoiler restraint.

Five terms of art recur.

Catabaptism joins *κατά* ("down, against") to βαπτίζω ("to plunge, to sink"), a verb Greek writers applied to foundering ships and drowning bodies long before it named a sacrament. The word already existed in Reformation polemic: Zwingli coined "catabaptists," "antibaptists," for the Swiss radicals and set it in the title of his 1527 refutation, before his successor Bullinger's "anabaptist," "re-baptizer," prevailed. It is reclaimed here as a concept: an immersion that unmakes rather than regenerates, and that absolves by removing the possibility of the one absolved.

Modal debt designates a liability that attaches to the totality of a subject's possible selves rather than to its actual acts, and which can be discharged only by an act that alters what is possible rather than what is recorded.

The vertical frontier designates the rotation of the Turnerian frontier from the horizontal axis of the continent to the vertical axis of the sky, and thence to the modal axis of possibility, once the West was declared closed in 1890.

The White Ghost Dance designates Columbia considered as a white millenarian movement, founded upon the graves of the two non-white millenarian movements, Lakota and Chinese, whose suppression it enshrines as scripture.

Pilate's basin designates the game's political ablution: the equalization of oppressor and oppressed that allows the author's hands to emerge clean before the multitude, and which, I argue, is the precondition of the metaphysical drowning at the river.



INTRODUCTION

THE LIGHTHOUSE AND THE LEDGER

"Visible nature is all plasticity and indifference,—a moral multiverse, as one might call it, and not a moral universe."

William James, "Is Life Worth Living?" (1895)

"pues el delito mayor
del hombre es haber nacido."

Pedro Calderón de la Barca, *La vida es sueño* (1635), Jornada I

I

A Game That Drowns Its Protagonist

In its final minutes *BioShock Infinite* does something almost without precedent in the commercial first-person shooter: it drowns its protagonist. The drowning is deliberate and consensual, administered by the companion whom every preceding hour has trained the player to shield, and it is offered not as defeat but as the sole coherent resolution of the work's metaphysics. A genre whose formal premise is the indefinite survival of the avatar—whose economy of health, shields, salts, checkpoints, and resurrections exists to forestall terminal death—concludes by unmaking its avatar in a river, at the instant of a baptism, so that no world may contain the man he became.

The scene is laconic. Booker DeWitt, veteran of the Seventh Cavalry at Wounded Knee and dismissed Pinkerton, has learned that Zachary Hale Comstock, prophet-sovereign of the airborne city of Columbia, is himself: the Booker who, in the moral wreckage after the massacre, accepted immersion at a revival, took a new name, and with it a theology of total absolution. The young woman he has spent the game rescuing, Elizabeth, is the infant daughter, Anna, whom he surrendered to Comstock in 1893 to settle his gambling debts. Multiplied into a chorus of her counterparts, she leads him into the water and holds him under. Her images extinguish one by one. After the credits a coda returns to Booker's lodgings on 8 October 1893; he calls his daughter's name and opens the nursery door; the screen cuts to black before the crib can be seen.

Critical reception has divided this ending, and the work it closes, into two problems. One school treats the game's quantum machinery—tears, counterparts, "constants and variables"—as the apparatus of a twist, and audits its coherence as one audits a puzzle box: whether the drowning annihilates the very Elizabeths who perform it; whether a branch can be pruned in a cosmos in which every branch is actual. The other treats the game's representations of race, revolution, and violence as its true subject, and judges its equation of the racist Founders with the insurgent Vox Populi a moral failure and its relentless combat an aesthetic one. This thesis contends that the two problems are one. The modal apparatus is the political apparatus. The metaphysics of the ending is the form in which the game thinks American guilt, and the form in which it declines to think it.

II

The Argument

The argument proceeds in four movements, each developed across several chapters.

The first is theological. The game's master idiom is debt, and its plot is a soteriology. The commission that sends Booker aloft—*bring us the girl, and wipe away the debt*—is a near-literal rendering of Colossians 2:14, in which the cross "blotted out" (ἐξαλείψας, *wiping away*) the *cheirographon*, the handwritten bond of indebtedness. Booker's pecuniary debt (1893), his moral debt (Wounded Knee), and his modal debt (the crimes of every Comstock) are three registers of a single *Schuld*, and the narrative ascends this ladder rung by rung. Because Comstock, who receives Anna in settlement of Booker's obligations, is Booker, the transaction is one in which the self is both creditor and debtor. The game thereby literalizes what Nietzsche (1887, II §21) called Christianity's stroke of genius: the creditor who sacrifices himself for his debtor.

The second is historical. Columbia is the terminal form of the American regeneration myth, conceived at the precise juncture (1890–1893) when the Census declared the frontier line dissolved, the Seventh Cavalry massacred the Lakota of the Ghost Dance at Wounded Knee, and Chicago raised the White City of the World's Columbian Exposition. Columbia is a *vertical frontier*, a continent's expansionary drive rotated skyward when the horizontal West was exhausted, and a *White Ghost Dance*, the white mirror of the millenarian movements its Hall of Heroes celebrates having crushed. The mirroring extends to a detail recorded by the ethnologist James Mooney (1896): some Ghost Dance teaching foresaw the faithful lifted into the air while a renewed earth slid over the old.

The third is metaphysical. The game's "constants and variables" are less Everettian than Kripkean. In Kripke's account (1972/1980), a name is fixed to its bearer by an "initial baptism" and is therefore contingent, while a person's origin is necessary. *Comstock* is a name a man received in a river; *Elizabeth* and *Anna* are two names for one origin. To abolish the name in every world, one must drown the origin at the dubbing. William James's "moral multiverse," coined as an image of cosmic indifference, here becomes a court: a cosmos in which every refused sin is committed elsewhere, and in which guilt therefore attaches to possibilities. This is *modal debt*.

The fourth is critical and medial. Catabaptism privatizes structural guilt and allegorizes its medium. The modalization of evil permits the fantasy that a nation's sin had a single author whose unbirth would unmake it, and the game's political ablution—its insistence that oppressor and insurgent are equally culpable—clears the ground for that fantasy. At the same time the game is an apparatus of respawn, one in which the avatar's resurrection is literally priced in silver. Its ending stages the medium's wish to terminate its own regenerative loop, a wish the franchise could not honor and the work half confesses it cannot.

III

Method

Four methods operate in concert. The first is genealogical in the sense of Nietzsche (1887) and Foucault (1971): concepts are traced through their descent, attending to the violence sedimented in them, so that *debt*, *baptism*, *frontier*, and *possibility* appear not as neutral categories but as instruments with histories. The second is figural, after Erich Auerbach's "Figura" (1938): events are read as types fulfilled by later events, so that the work's four immersions—Booker's entry baptism, Comstock drowned in his own font, Songbird drowned in Rapture, Booker drowned at the river—form a typological sequence culminating in the last. The third is a modal hermeneutics drawing on possible-worlds theories of fiction (Pavel 1986; Ryan 1991; Doležel 1998), with the reflexive twist that *Infinite* thematizes the very semantics such theories presuppose: it is a fiction about the accessibility relation itself. The fourth is a ludic formalism attentive to procedural rhetoric (Bogost 2007), ergodic textuality (Aarseth 1997), and the aesthetics of failure (Juul 2013), treating rules, mechanics, and their diegetic justifications as propositions. Over all four presides Fredric Jameson's premise (1981) that narrative is a socially symbolic act whose resolutions are imaginary solutions to real contradictions.

Comparison is constellational rather than causal. Where influence is documented—the studio based Columbia on the 1893 World's Columbian Exposition, and Irrational's artists, who had been reading Erik Larson's *The Devil in the White City* (2003), turned Levine to it as a source—it is noted; and Levine's refusal to supply an authoritative reading of the ending licenses the method. Elsewhere comparanda are assembled as Benjamin assembled constellations: to make visible a configuration that no single source contains. A multiverse fiction licenses the procedure. Each comparison is a door opened onto a world in which the game's constants recur under different variables.

IV

State of the Field

The *BioShock* series supplied game criticism with one of its founding concepts. Clint Hocking's "ludonarrative dissonance" (2007) named the contradiction between *BioShock*'s rules, which reward the self-interested harvesting of others, and its story, which indicts Objectivist self-interest. Academic studies followed: Grant Tavinor (2009) on the aesthetics of Rapture, which he argued is art of a distinctive kind because of, not despite, its nature as a game, its signal device an untrustworthy narrator made interactive; Joseph Packer (2010) on the game as critique of Objectivism; Jessica Aldred and Brian Greenspan (2011) on the "dystopian logic of convergence" and the political meaning of the trigger phrase *would you*

kindly. *Infinite* inherited this apparatus and was read through it. Critical journalism at release converged on two complaints: the incongruity between the game's reflective ambitions and its unrelieved combat, and the moral equation of the Vox Populi with the Founders. Philosophical anthologies (Cuddy 2015) addressed identity, determinism, and the multiverse. A vast amateur hermeneutics reconstructed timelines with talmudic diligence, making the game one of the most densely annotated narratives in its medium.

Two further bodies of work frame the argument. Scholarship on the series has deepened since release: Rowan Tulloch (2010) read *BioShock*'s twist as a pedagogy that trains the player's subjectivity, and the first interdisciplinary collection devoted to the series, *Beyond the Sea: Navigating BioShock* (Parker and Aldred 2018), gathered essays on its family bonds and "postfeminist fatherhood," on agency, and on the function of the player in *Burial at Sea*. The record of production and reception is equally pertinent. Levine has said that a developer threatened to quit over the presentation of Comstock and religion, and that their conversations led him to reconsider New Testament forgiveness; a devout player requested a refund over the forced baptism at Columbia's gate. The violence divided critics: Polygon's Chris Plante and Kotaku's Kirk Hamilton found it gratuitous, while Destructoid's James Stephanie Sterling argued that a story about violence required it. *Edge*'s review judged the ending's finality inconsistent with the universe the game had built. Chapters Three, Four, Five, and Eight take up each of these responses.

To my knowledge, what remains absent is an account that holds these strands together: one that explains why a work about the American nineteenth century needed quantum mechanics, why a work about quantum mechanics needed baptism, and why both needed a father, a daughter, and a debt. This thesis supplies that account under the name of catabaptism.

V

Synopsis of the Fable

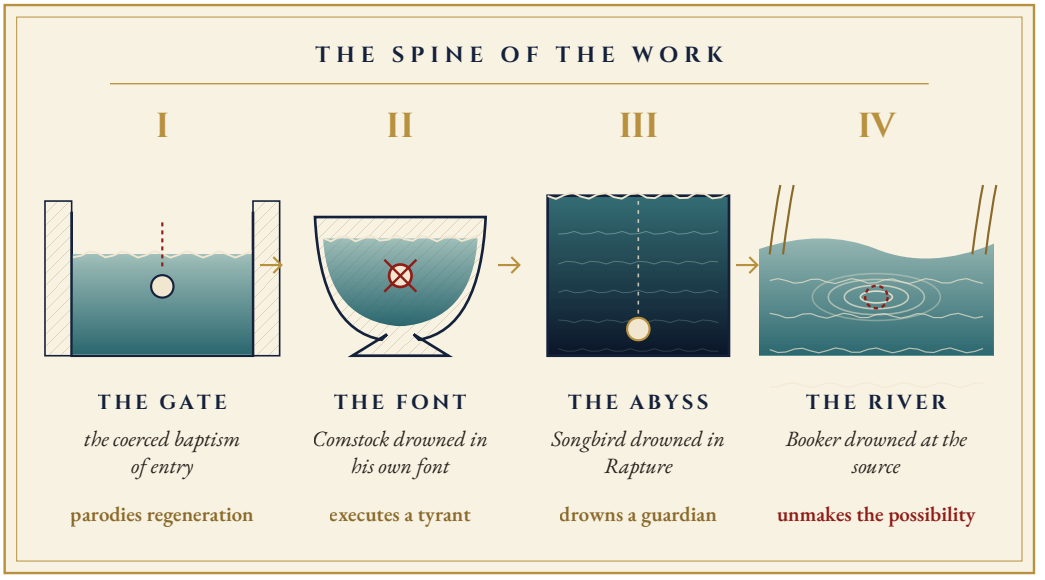
In 1912 two impeccably dressed scientists, Rosalind and Robert Lutece, row Booker DeWitt to a lighthouse off the coast of Maine. He carries a commission whose wording he repeats as a mantra—bring the girl and wipe away the debt—and the lighthouse launches him by rocket into Columbia, a floating city that seceded from the United States after firing on Peking during the Boxer Uprising. His entry is a baptism: a preacher holds him under so long that he nearly drowns, and he wakes in a garden. At the Raffle and Fair he wins the first throw at a bound interracial couple, a Black man and a white woman; the initials *AD* carved into his hand expose him as the prophesied False Shepherd, and the city turns its arms on him.

On Monument Island he frees Elizabeth, a young woman confined in a tower and observed through one-way glass, who can open "tears" into other worlds and who is guarded

by Songbird, a vast mechanical bird. Comstock proclaims her the Lamb of Columbia, heir to his prophecy. When she discovers that Booker means to deliver her to New York to settle his debts, she fells him with a wrench, then allies with him from necessity. Their search for an airship entangles them with Daisy Fitzroy, leader of the Vox Populi, and the industrialist Jeremiah Fink. Elizabeth opens tears into worlds where the gunsmith Chen Lin still lives, and at last into one where the Vox revolution has erupted and Booker is a dead martyr of the cause. In that world Daisy executes Fink and threatens his child; Elizabeth kills her, and afterward cuts her hair and changes her dress.

Songbird recaptures Elizabeth. An aged Elizabeth draws Booker forward to 1983, into a future in which she, broken by decades of reconditioning, has succeeded Comstock and Columbia rains fire on New York; this older Elizabeth sends him back with the means to command Songbird. He frees her from Comstock House, where Comstock's staff are torturing her into compliance, boards the Prophet's airship, the *Hand of the Prophet*, and kills Comstock by drowning him in his own baptismal font. Songbird, now commanded, destroys the Siphon that has suppressed Elizabeth's power. Unbound, she opens a door to the undersea city of Rapture, where Songbird is crushed and drowned beneath the ocean.

FIGURE 1



The Four Immersions. *The fable articulated by its four immersions, each a baptism that kills or nearly kills; only the last unmakes the possibility of the one immersed (Introduction, V).*

There follows a sea of lighthouses—"there's always a lighthouse, there's always a man, there's always a city"—and the revelations. In 1893 Robert Lutece, acting for Comstock, came to Booker's office to acquire his infant daughter; he consented, then pursued; the closing tear severed the infant's finger, leaving her body divided between worlds, which is

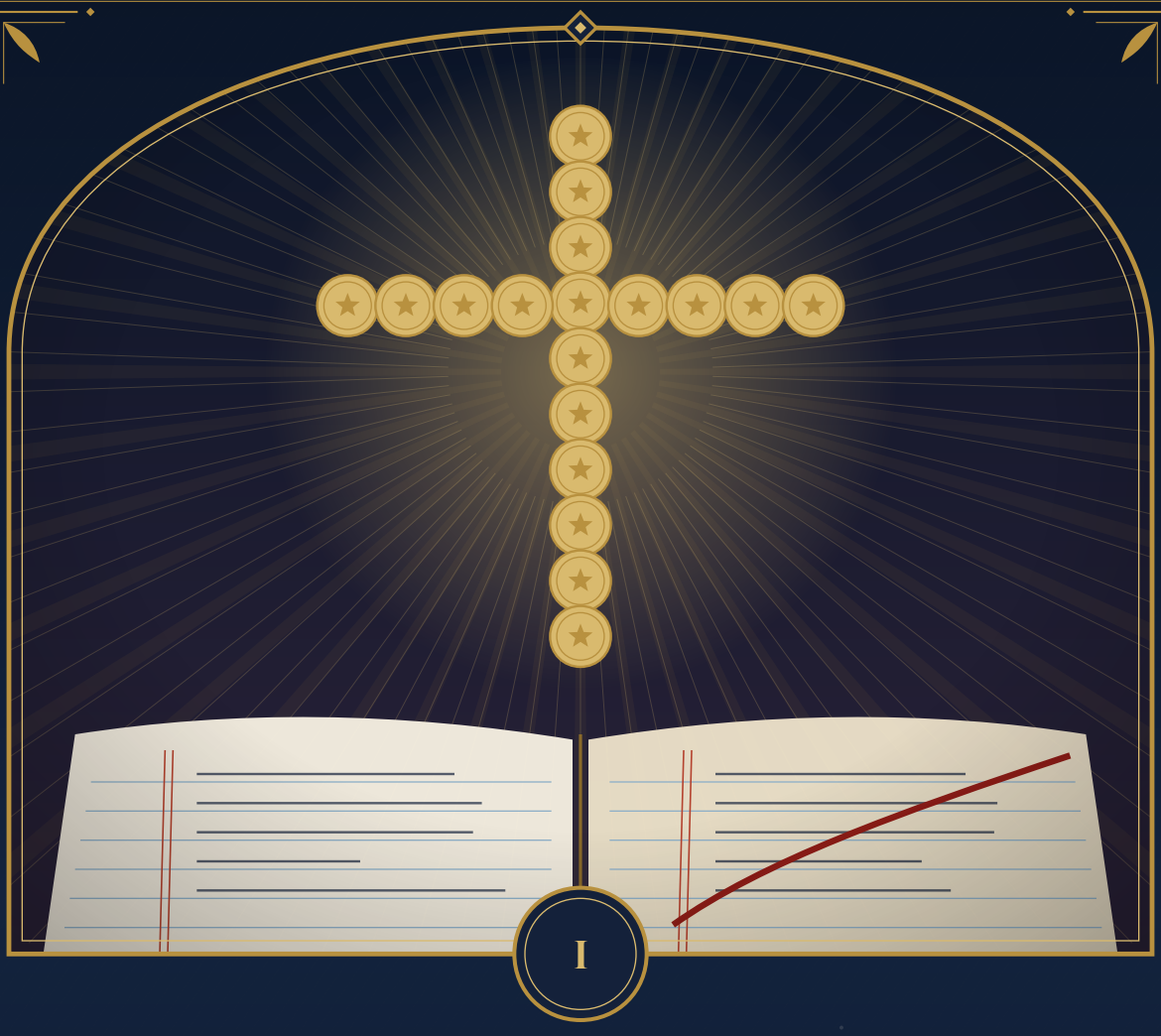
the source of her power. Comstock, sterile and prematurely aged by exposure to the Lutece apparatus, required an heir. The Luteces, later sabotaged by Comstock and scattered across time, brought Booker to Columbia to reverse the sale, Robert having persuaded a reluctant Rosalind; his memories were overwritten in transit, as the game's epigraph warns, for "the mind of the subject will desperately struggle to create memories where none exist." Booker and Comstock diverge at a single river: a baptism accepted or refused. The Elizabeths take Booker back to that river and drown him there.

Read structurally, the fable is articulated by four immersions: the coerced baptism of entry; Comstock drowned in his own font; Songbird drowned in Rapture; Booker drowned at the source. Each is a baptism, and each kills or nearly kills. The first parodies regeneration, the second executes a tyrant, the third drowns a guardian, and the fourth attempts what none of the others could: an immersion that unmakes the possibility of the one immersed. This sequence is the spine of the work, and its last term is the subject of this thesis.

VI

Plan of the Work

Chapter One reconstructs the debt-idiom of salvation from the Lord's Prayer, Colossians, Augustine, and Anselm through Nietzsche's genealogy, Pascal's wager, Bryan's "cross of gold," Calvin, Weber, and Mauss, and defines modal debt. Chapter Two situates Columbia within American civil religion, the 1893 Exposition, the closing of the frontier, Wounded Knee, the Ghost Dance, and the Boxer Uprising, and reads the city as vertical frontier and White Ghost Dance. Chapter Three examines Comstock's prophecy as misread technology, the apocalyptic semiotics of the Lamb, the Lucan onomastics of the principal names, the Sodom typology, and Benjamin's angel of history. Chapter Four turns to revolution, from Alcuin's warning through the Gilded Age labor wars, Populism, Fanon, Camus, and Arendt, to the problem of Daisy Fitzroy and the politics of equivalence. Chapter Five develops the game's metaphysics through Everett, James, Leibniz, Kripke, Lewis, Parfit, the literature of moral luck, Cantor, Propp, and the Aristophanic myth of the Luteces. Chapter Six reads Elizabeth within the mythic archive of captive daughters and sacrificed children. Chapter Seven situates the game within speculative fiction from Swift and Verne to Borges, Le Guin, Miéville, and Miyazaki, with an excursus on anachronistic music. Chapter Eight analyzes ludic form as theology: the diegetic respawn, illusory choice, the gear economy, and the franchise as causal loop. Chapter Nine assembles these findings into a theory of catabaptism and submits it to political critique. The Conclusion assesses what the work knows and what it cannot.



CHAPTER ONE

SCHULD

The Ledger of Salvation from Anselm to the Lighthouse

"And forgive us our debts, as we forgive our debtors."
Matthew 6:12

"You shall not crucify mankind upon a cross of gold."
William Jennings Bryan, Democratic National Convention, Chicago (1896)

The sentence that launches Booker into the sky is a soteriology in nine words. *Bring us the girl, and wipe away the debt* names a payment (the girl), an erasure (wiping away), and an obligation (the debt), and it arranges them in the order of every Western theory of atonement: something precious is surrendered so that an account may be cancelled. This chapter reconstructs the idiom from which the sentence descends, in order to show that *Infinite* is built as a ledger whose entries migrate from coin to sin to possibility, and that its final rite is the settlement of an account no prior theology had imagined.

1.1

"Forgive Us Our Debts": The Commercial Substrate of Salvation

The Lord's Prayer in Matthew asks forgiveness of *opheilēmata*, "debts" (6:12); Luke's version substitutes *hamartias*, "sins," yet cannot keep the ledger out of the same verse: "And forgive us our sins; for we also forgive every one that is indebted to us" (Luke 11:4). The slippage is not metaphor imposed on scripture but the substrate of its moral vocabulary, inherited from an Aramaic in which a single word, *ḥôbâ*, denotes both debt and sin. To be guilty is to owe; to be forgiven is to have one's account struck.

The decisive text is Colossians 2:14: "Blotting out the handwriting of ordinances that was against us, which was contrary to us, and took it out of the way, nailing it to his cross." The Greek is more concrete than the English. The cross has *exaleipsas to cheirographon*: it has *wiped away* the *cheirographon*, a technical term of Hellenistic commerce for a debtor's signed acknowledgment, a bond written in his own hand. The verb *exaleiphō* denotes erasure, the smoothing of a wax tablet or the washing of ink from papyrus. The Luteces' commission is therefore Pauline in both its verb and its object; it departs from Colossians only in specifying the currency of payment. Not a Son but a daughter is handed over, and not by a Father who loves the world but by a father who owes his bookmakers.

A further philological fact binds the commission to the game's cosmology. The same verb returns in the Apocalypse: "God shall wipe away all tears from their eyes" (Revelation 7:17; 21:4), *exaleipsei pan dakryon*. In the Greek New Testament, then, the two nouns on which *Infinite* turns—the debt and the tears—are objects of a single verb of erasure. The game's ending executes that verb upon both at once: the debt is wiped away and every tear is closed. Chapters Three and Nine return to this convergence.

The verb's range is wider still, and every extension of it lands in the game. Of its five occurrences in the New Testament, *exaleiphō* also names the blotting out of sins ("that your sins may be blotted out," Acts 3:19) and the erasure of a name: "I will not blot out his name out of the book of life" (Revelation 3:5). In the Septuagint it characteristically renders the Hebrew *māḥâ*, "to wipe out," the verb with which God resolves to blot hu-

mankind from the earth before the Flood (Genesis 6:7; 7:4, 23). A single verb thus wipes away a debt, a sin, a name in the book, the tears of the redeemed, and a whole creation by water. *Infinite*'s final rite performs all five at once: it cancels Booker's debt, expiates Comstock's sins, erases the name *Comstock* from every book of possibility, closes every tear, and does it by drowning. The game's soteriology is, philologically, the full semantic range of one Greek word.

FIGURE 2



One Verb, Five Erasures. *The range of exaleiphō in the New Testament and the Septuagint: a debt, a sin, a name, the tears, and a creation by water (section 1.1).*

Augustine supplies the second element: liability without act. Reading Romans 5:12 in a Latin that rendered the Greek *eph' hō* ("because") as *in quo* ("in whom"), he concluded that all humanity sinned *in* Adam, and that infants therefore require baptism for the remission of a guilt incurred by no deed of their own (*De peccatorum meritis et remissione*, 412). Augustinian original guilt is the first great Western theory of a debt owed for what another did, transmitted through a shared origin. *Infinite*'s modal debt is its lateral counterpart. Original sin descends from an ancestor down the axis of time; modal sin is inherited from a counterpart across the axis of possibility. In Booker, as it were, all Comstocks sinned.

Anselm supplies the third element: the identity of payer and debtor. In *Cur Deus Homo* (1098), sin is the withholding of honor owed to God, and justice requires a satisfaction pro-

portionate to an infinite offense. Only God *can* pay such a debt; only humanity *ought* to pay it; hence the necessity of the God-man, in whom ability and obligation coincide. The structure maps onto *Infinite*'s ending with disquieting precision. The debt owed by every Comstock in every world can be discharged only by someone who is at once Booker and Comstock. That person exists at exactly one location in the possibility-space: the man standing in the river before the fork, not yet either. The ending is Anselmian. The one who ought to pay and the one who can pay coincide only at the branch-point.

The vocabulary of rescue is commercial throughout. *Redemption* derives from *redimere*, "to buy back," the language of manumission, ransom, and pawn; David Graeber (2011) has shown how thoroughly the moral grammar of salvation was minted from the coin of the marketplace. In the 1893 flashback Booker attempts a redemption in the strict sense. Having sold the child, he runs after her to buy her back, and the closing tear takes her finger as interest.

Graeber's book appeared in 2011, the year of Occupy Wall Street, in which he was an early participant, and while *Infinite* was in development. The idiom the game inherits from Colossians was, in the years of its making, the vocabulary of a national argument over foreclosures, student loans, and bank rescues. A soteriology of debt was written in a season when debt had become the country's theology.

1.2

Schuld und Schulden: Nietzsche's Genealogy

In the second essay of *On the Genealogy of Morals* (1887), Nietzsche argues that the master moral concept *Schuld* (guilt) descends from the very material concept *Schulden* (debts) (II §4). Punishment originated as compensation: the creditor, unable to recover the principal, received instead the pleasure of inflicting suffering on the debtor (II §§5–6). Over time the debt to ancestors swelled into the debt to gods, and the debt to the Christian God became infinite (II §§19–20). Then came what Nietzsche calls the paradoxical and horrifying expedient that gave tormented humanity temporary relief: God paying himself, the creditor sacrificing himself for his debtor, out of love (II §21).

Infinite literalizes this paradox with a rigor Nietzsche could not have anticipated. In 1893 Booker owes; his daughter is the payment; Comstock receives her. But Comstock is Booker. The transaction is internal to a single trans-world subject: Booker pays Booker's debt with Booker's child, and the account circulates in a closed circuit of *Schuld*. At the river the circuit is closed in the manner of §21. The one who holds the child as payment and the one who owes her a father are the same man, and he discharges the account by dying for the one he wronged. What Nietzsche treated as Christianity's masterstroke of self-deception, the game stages as the only arithmetic that balances.

The genealogy also clarifies the two men's psychology. Nietzsche derives the bad conscience from instincts that, denied outward discharge, turn inward (II §16). Booker is bad conscience incarnate: the violence of Wounded Knee, finding no sanctioned outlet, curdles into drink, debt, and the nosebleeds by which the game marks memories bleeding through from other worlds. Comstock is the ascetic priest of the third essay, who redirects suffering by naming its cause as sin and assigning that sin to others (III §15). The same *Schuld* is introjected in one man and projected in the other. Booker hates himself; Comstock hates the Sodom below.

1.3

The Gambler's Wager: Pascal, Dostoevsky, and the Rigged Coin

Booker is a gambler, and the game opens on a wager in its most famous form. Pascal's argument (*Pensées*, L418/B233) holds that one must bet on God's existence, since the stake is finite and the possible gain infinite; and it insists that abstention is impossible: "il faut parier. Cela n'est pas volontaire, vous êtes embarqué." *You are embarked. Infinite* begins with Booker literally embarked, seated in a boat rowed by others toward a lighthouse he did not choose. Comstock is the man who wagered at the river and won, or believed he won, an infinite return: a city, a people, a prophecy. Booker is the man who declined the bet and was left with the finite stake of his own ruin.

The wager reappears as a coin. Early in Columbia, Robert Lutece invites Booker to call a toss while displaying a board tallied entirely with heads and not a single tail. Booker calls; the coin falls heads. The scene recalls the opening of Tom Stoppard's *Rosencrantz and Guildenstern Are Dead* (1966), in which ninety-two consecutive heads drive Guildenstern to syllogisms on probability, fate, and the suspicion that he and his companion are characters in someone else's plot. The probability of n consecutive heads is 2^{-n}, a vanishing quantity, and in a branching cosmos such a run is a selection effect. The Luteces are sampling the worlds in which this man accepts this commission, and in each of them the coin, like the choice, is fixed by character. Pascal's wager is here rigged not by God but by disposition.

Dostoevsky's *The Gambler* (1866) is the fable's secret prototype. Dostoevsky wrote it in twenty-six days in October 1866 under a predatory contract with the publisher Stellovsky: had the novel not been delivered by 1 November, Stellovsky would have acquired the right to publish his works, past and future, for nine years without paying him. He dictated it to a stenographer, Anna Grigoryevna Snitkina, whom he married the following year. The contract is a literary analogue of modal debt, a lien not on what the debtor had written but on what he might write, redeemed only by producing against the clock a novel about a man who stakes everything on the wheel. A novel about gambling was composed to wipe away a debt and delivered through an Anna. The coincidence is not evidence of influence; it is

evidence that the constellation of gambling, debt, and a woman who pays it is older than the game.

The protagonist's name belongs to the same ledger. A *booker* is one who books: a bookkeeper, a bookmaker, a keeper of the betting book. The eschatological ledger of Revelation stands behind the commercial one: "and the books were opened … and the dead were judged out of those things which were written in the books" (20:12). Booker is the man of the book, in both of its senses.

1.4

The Panic of 1893 and the Cross of Gold

The year of the sale is the year of the Panic of 1893. The failure of the Philadelphia and Reading Railroad in February began a cascade of bank runs, railroad bankruptcies, and unemployment that became the worst depression the United States had yet endured, aggravated by a crisis of the gold reserve and the repeal of the Sherman Silver Purchase Act that autumn. Booker's private insolvency is synchronized with national insolvency. In the same months Frederick Jackson Turner declared the frontier closed and Chicago displayed the White City; the sale of Anna is the private sacrament of that public year.

Three years later William Jennings Bryan fused monetary policy with the Passion in the most celebrated oration of the decade: labor must not be crowned with thorns, mankind must not be crucified upon a cross of gold. The debtor farmer became Christ; the gold standard became the cross; the creditor became Rome. Columbia's currency is the Silver Eagle. The coinage is a free-silver fantasy, minted by a city that has seceded from the nation whose gold standard was imagined as crucifying the indebted. Even Columbia's money is a theology of debt relief.

1.5

The Decree and the Cage: Calvin and Weber

Calvin's *Institutes* (1559, III.21–24) teach a double predestination: before creation God elected some to salvation and reprobated others, a decree Calvin himself called "horrible" (*decretum quidem horribile*, III.23.7). The doctrine's psychological consequence was the anxiety of assurance: since works cannot earn election, the believer scrutinizes his life for signs that he is among the elect. *Infinite*'s metaphysics restates the Reformed paradox in physical terms. The Lutece tally is a decree; the constant is the man; the variables are the creature's cosmetic freedoms. Comstock is the self-declared elect who reads his election in his visions. Booker is the reprobate who cannot believe himself forgivable and therefore refuses the means of grace.

Max Weber's *Protestant Ethic* (1904–05) traced how that anxiety, deprived of sacramental relief, was converted into methodical worldly discipline and thence into capitalist accumulation, until the spirit departed and only the *stahlhartes Gehäuse* remained, the "shell as hard as steel" that Talcott Parsons rendered "iron cage," a translation Peter Baehr (2001) has shown to be more theological than Weber's own image. *Infinite* condenses this history into a trinket. Elizabeth asks Booker to choose between two brooches, a bird and a cage. The choice alters only the ornament at her throat; the world proceeds identically. Election here is aesthetic: one may choose to wear freedom or to wear the decree, but the cage is the condition of the choosing.

Jeremiah Fink is Weber's capitalist with the anxiety removed and the prophecy restored. His industrial sermons belong to the genre Andrew Carnegie codified in "Wealth" (1889), the so-called Gospel of Wealth, which declared that the man who dies rich dies disgraced and recast the plutocrat as a steward of providence. Three years later the same steward's managers summoned Pinkerton agents to Homestead.

1.6

The Spirit of the Gift: Mauss and Derrida

Marcel Mauss's *Essai sur le don* (1925) describes an economy of three obligations: to give, to receive, and to reciprocate. Its most famous passage reports the Māori concept of *hau*, glossed by Mauss's informant Tamati Ranaipiri as the spirit of the thing given, which retains something of the giver and seeks to return to its origin. Anna is a gift corrupted into a commodity, yet the commodity retains its *hau*. Sold, she remains her father's; the entire plot is the return of the given thing to its giver, culminating in the daughter's repayment of the father with his death. The game even names the principle. *Return to Sender* is a Vigor that catches incoming fire and hurls it back at its source.

Jacques Derrida's *Given Time* (1991) sharpens the point. A gift, to be a gift, must not appear as such; the moment it is recognized, it enters the circle of exchange and is annulled. The Luteces' second chance is a gift that becomes a debt the instant Booker accepts it. Chapter Nine argues that his death, witnessed by the Elizabeths, cannot escape the same law.

1.7

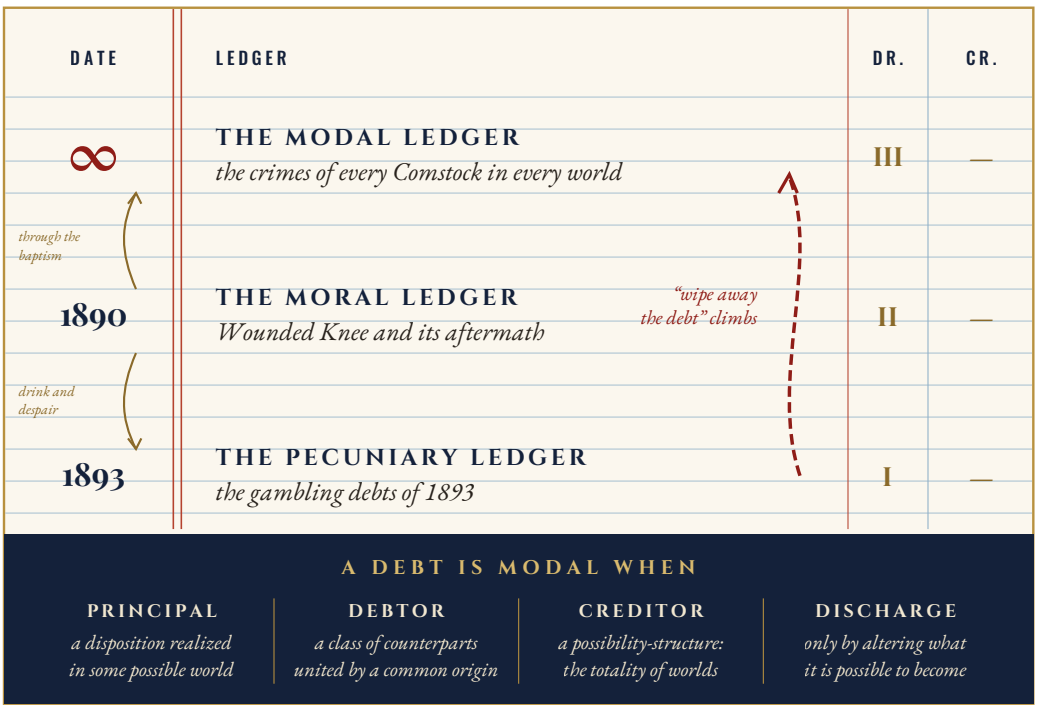
Toward a Definition of Modal Debt

The preceding genealogy permits a definition. A debt is *modal* when four conditions hold. First, its principal is not an act but a disposition realized in some possible world. Second, its debtor is not an individual but a class of counterparts united by a com-

mon origin. Third, its creditor is not a person but a possibility-structure: the totality of worlds and of the victims they contain. Fourth, it can be discharged only by an act that alters the debtor's modal profile, what it is possible for the debtor to become, rather than its actual record.

Infinite keeps three ledgers. The pecuniary ledger records the gambling debts of 1893. The moral ledger records Wounded Knee and its aftermath. The modal ledger records the crimes of every Comstock in every world. Each absorbs its predecessor. The moral debt produced the pecuniary one, through drink and despair; the moral debt also produced the modal one, through the baptism at which one Booker sought to wash it away. As the narrative proceeds, the phrase *wipe away the debt* climbs from the first ledger to the third, until it designates the erasure of a possibility. The game thereby takes Augustine's inherited guilt and turns it on its side. What was once transmitted from father to child down the generations is now transmitted from self to counterpart across the worlds: a lateral original sin, payable only at the root. Contemporary philosophy of religion has reached the same structure from the other side: Mark B. Anderson (2021) has proposed that agents may be culpable for what they would have done in non-actual circumstances, and has offered this counterfactual account as a model of original sin (see section 5.5).

FIGURE 3



The Three Ledgers. *Pecuniary, moral, and modal debt, each absorbing its predecessor; below, the four conditions under which a debt is modal (section 1.7).*



II

CHAPTER TWO

THE CITY UPON A CLOUD

Civil Religion, the Vertical Frontier, and the White Ghost Dance

"For we must consider that we shall be as a city upon a hill. The eyes of all people are upon us."
John Winthrop, "A Model of Christian Charity" (1630)

"The problem of the twentieth century is the problem of the color-line."
W. E. B. Du Bois, *The Souls of Black Folk* (1903)

Columbia is American civil religion given altitude. Its every surface—the deified Founders, the angelic statuary, the baptismal gate, the dioramas of conquest—literalizes a figure of speech that the nation had used of itself since the seventeenth century. This chapter argues that the city is not a satire of exceptionalism in general but a precise historical diagnosis of the years 1890–1893, when the frontier was declared closed, the Ghost Dance was massacred, and the White City rose in Chicago. Out of that conjuncture Columbia emerges as two things at once: a *vertical frontier* and a *White Ghost Dance*.

2.1

Winthrop's Hill and Wheatley's Columbia

John Winthrop's lay sermon of 1630 bound the Massachusetts colonists in covenant and borrowed from Matthew 5:14 the image that American rhetoric would never relinquish: a city set upon a hill, on which the eyes of all people would rest. Winthrop's figure carried a warning that later usage forgot. If the colonists dealt falsely with their God, he cautioned, they would be made "a story and a by-word through the world." Columbia is that by-word. It fulfills the boast and the warning together, and it lifts the hill until it becomes a cloud. Robert Bellah (1967) named the system of beliefs, rituals, and sacred persons through which the republic sanctified itself a "civil religion"; Ernest Lee Tuveson (1968) traced its millennialist conviction that America was a *redeemer nation*; Sacvan Bercovitch (1978) showed how the jeremiad, lamenting declension, always reaffirmed the errand. Comstock's sermons are jeremiads in Bercovitch's exact sense: they denounce the Sodom below in order to consecrate the mission above.

The city's name contains a buried irony. *Columbia*, the poetic name for the new nation, was personified as a goddess in the late eighteenth century, and among her earliest laureates was Phillis Wheatley, an African woman enslaved as a child and brought to Boston, whose poem to George Washington (1775) begins: "Celestial choir! enthron'd in realms of light, / Columbia's scenes of glorious toils I write." The goddess is enthroned in light, airborne from her first appearance, and the voice that enthroned her belonged to a person Columbia's racial order would consign to its underclass. The city expels the genealogy of its own patron.

The goddess acquired her canonical posture a century later. John Gast's painting *American Progress* (1872) shows a colossal, white-robed woman floating westward over the continent, a schoolbook in one hand and a telegraph wire in the other, while Native people and bison flee before her into shadow. The airborne feminine allegory of expansion, trailing the infrastructure of conquest, is Columbia's iconographic template. The game's angelic

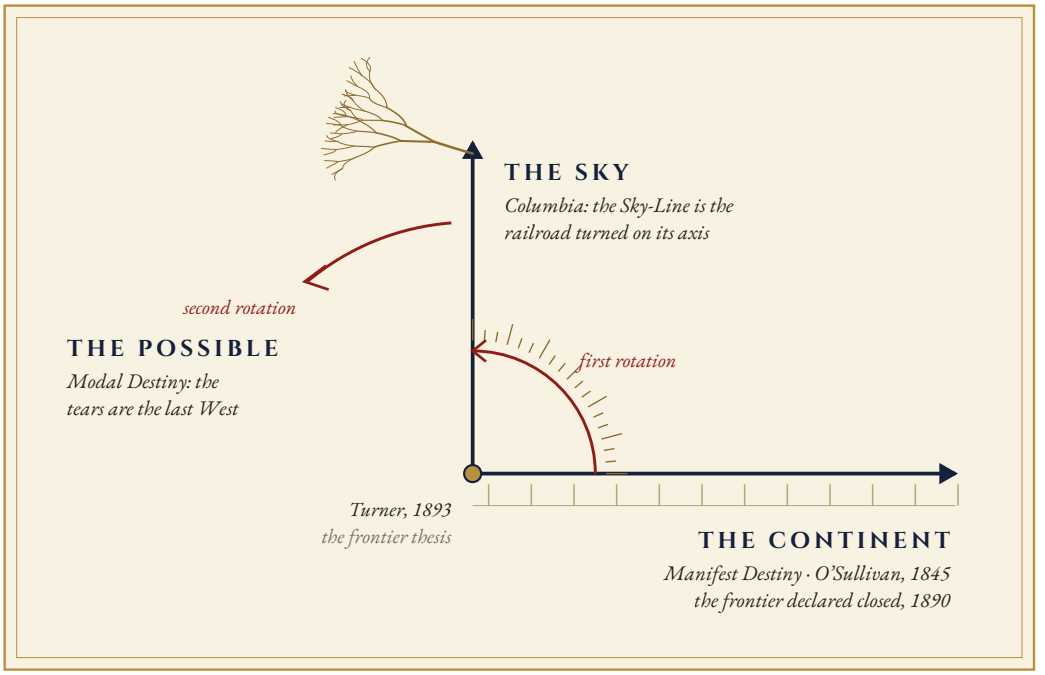
statuary and Comstock's visionary archangel descend from Gast's floating figure; Columbia simply grants her a city to stand on.

2.2

Manifest Destiny and the Vertical Frontier

In 1845 John L. O'Sullivan proclaimed "our manifest destiny to overspread the continent allotted by Providence for the free development of our yearly multiplying millions." Josiah Strong's *Our Country* (1885) racialized the providence, prophesying that the Anglo-Saxon would spread across the earth and supplant weaker peoples. Then, in July 1893, at the meeting of the American Historical Association held in conjunction with the Chicago Exposition, Frederick Jackson Turner read "The Significance of the Frontier in American History." Turner began from a bulletin of the 1890 Census reporting that the unsettled area had been so broken by isolated settlement that there could hardly be said to be a frontier line. The frontier, "the meeting point between savagery and civilization," had produced American democracy, individualism, and vitality; and it was gone.

FIGURE 4



The Two Rotations of the Frontier. *From the horizontal axis of the continent to the vertical axis of the sky, and from the sky to the axis of the possible (section 2.2).*

Columbia is the answer to Turner's anxiety. When the continent was declared full, the expansionary drive did not cease; it rotated. The sky became the next West. The Sky-Line, the city's network of hanging rails on which Booker rides by a hand-held hook, is the transcontinental railroad turned on its axis, and the Skyhook that carries him is also the instrument of his most intimate killings, fusing the frontier's technologies of travel and of violence. The Vigor *Bucking Bronco* hurls enemies into the air with the iconography of the rodeo. The Wild West has not ended; it has ascended.

The rotation does not stop at the vertical. Columbia is finite, an island with edges, and once the sky too is enclosed, expansion turns modal. Jeremiah Fink harvests through tears the inventions, weapons, and songs of other worlds; Comstock harvests their futures. Manifest Destiny becomes what I call *Modal Destiny*: the colonization of the possible after the exhaustion of the actual. The frontier thesis thus undergoes two rotations in the game, from the horizontal to the vertical and from the vertical to the modal, and the tears are the last West.

2.3

The White City: 1893 as Template

The World's Columbian Exposition, opened in May 1893 to mark the quadricentennial of Columbus, was the immediate model for Columbia, as Levine has acknowledged. Daniel Burnham's White City assembled neoclassical palaces of plaster around lagoons, lit by alternating current at night; the Ferris wheel turned above the Midway Plaisance, where "ethnological" villages arranged the world's peoples along an implicit gradient from civilization to savagery. Erik Larson's *The Devil in the White City* (2003) set Burnham's utopia beside the murder house that H. H. Holmes operated a few miles away. The utopian city and its concealed abattoir is the structure of Columbia, whose gleaming promenades conceal Finkton's factories and Shantytown's misery.

The Exposition's exclusions were contested at the time. Ida B. Wells, Frederick Douglass, I. Garland Penn, and Ferdinand Barnett published *The Reason Why the Colored American Is Not in the World's Columbian Exposition* (1893), indicting a fair that celebrated national progress while excluding the citizens whose labor and suffering underwrote it. Douglass, who served as commissioner for Haiti's pavilion, employed the young Paul Laurence Dunbar, and Dunbar read his verse at the fair; Douglass called him the most promising young colored man in America. Wells, driven from Memphis by the mob that destroyed her newspaper, kept a desk in the same Haitian pavilion and distributed the pamphlet from it. When the managers designated Friday, 25 August, as "Colored American Day," they announced that two thousand watermelons would be supplied, and Wells, among others, objected to the occasion; Nancy Green, born into slavery in Kentucky, was

meanwhile presenting "Aunt Jemima" to the fair's crowds as a living advertisement for the R. T. Davis Milling Company: beside a flour barrel twenty-four feet high she cooked pancakes, sang, and told romanticized stories of a contented Old South, in a character drawn from the minstrel stage, and the exposition awarded her a medal. A formerly enslaved woman was paid to perform the nostalgia of slavery inside the White City. Six years later Dunbar published "Sympathy": "I know why the caged bird beats his wing / Till its blood is red on the cruel bars." The bird and the cage, which *Infinite* offers to Elizabeth as interchangeable brooches, were already the emblem of the man who stood inside the White City and was not of it.

Henry Adams visited the Chicago fair and wrote that it asked, for the first time, whether the American people knew where they were driving (*Education*, ch. 22). At the Paris Exposition of 1900 he stood before the great dynamos and found himself praying to them, feeling them, in his famous phrase, "as a moral force, much as the early Christians felt the Cross" (ch. 25). His chapter set the Dynamo against the Virgin as the governing energies of two civilizations. Columbia refuses the antithesis. It is powered by the dynamo of the Lutece Field and the crackling electricity of *Shock Jockey*, and it is worshipped through a Virgin, the martyred Lady Comstock, and a Lamb. The city is Adams's two forces welded into one machine.

Adjacent to the fairgrounds in 1893 played Buffalo Bill's Wild West, whose company included Lakota performers who had lived through the events of 1890; two decades later Cody would film a reenactment of Wounded Knee. Columbia's Hall of Heroes, with its animatronic dioramas of Wounded Knee and Peking, is a Wild West show in museum form. Its guardians, the Motorized Patriots, are mechanical George Washingtons armed with crank guns, and they parody an entire tradition of civic automata culminating in Disney's animatronic Lincoln at the 1964–65 New York World's Fair. Jean Baudrillard (1981) argued that Disneyland is presented as imaginary in order to make us believe that the rest of America is real. Columbia removes the alibi. It is the hyperreal America, and its animatronic Founders defend it with Gatling fire.

Umberto Eco, touring American wax museums, replica palaces, and theme parks in the essays collected in English as *Travels in Hyperreality* (1986), found a culture that preferred the "absolute fake" to the original it claimed to improve. Columbia is the absolute fake of the republic: a copy of the founding myth more perfect, and more lethal, than anything the founders built.

2.4

The White Ghost Dance

In 1889 the Paiute prophet Wovoka received a vision during a solar eclipse and began to teach a round dance that would renew the earth: the dead would return, the bison would come back, and the whites would pass away. Among the Lakota the movement acquired ghost shirts believed to turn bullets. Federal alarm at the dance led to two killings in December 1890. On the 15th, at dawn, some forty Lakota officers of the Standing Rock agency police under Lieutenant Henry Bull Head, sent by the agent James McLaughlin to arrest Sitting Bull for fear that he would lend his authority to the dance, led him out of his cabin on the Grand River; when one of his followers, Catch-the-Bear, shot Bull Head, Bull Head fired into Sitting Bull's body and the policeman Red Tomahawk shot him in the head. Sitting Bull's son Crow Foot was among the dead, and six of the police were killed. Lakota killed Lakota on a written order from the agent, and the record of that morning rests largely on the agent's and the police's own accounts (McLaughlin 1890). On the 29th, at Wounded Knee Creek on the Pine Ridge reservation, the Seventh Cavalry under Colonel James W. Forsyth surrounded the Miniconjou band of Spotted Elk, who was gravely ill with pneumonia, and began to disarm it. While Forsyth's council proceeded, some of the Lakota began to sing Ghost Dance songs, which the surrounding troops took as a signal; a deaf man, Black Coyote, resisted surrendering his rifle, and it discharged in the struggle; the troopers opened fire at close range, and four Hotchkiss guns on the rise above the camp fired into the lodges. Soldiers pursued and killed people who fled along a ravine; bodies were later found as far as three miles from the camp. Between about two hundred fifty and three hundred Lakota died, many of them women and children, Spotted Elk among them; about twenty-five soldiers were killed, a number of them probably by their comrades' crossfire. Fear of reprisal kept the troops at the agency until 3 January 1891, when a civilian burial party under military escort placed 146 Lakota dead in a single mass grave; a snowstorm had covered the field, photographers accompanied the detail, and their pictures sold well (Carter 2004; Ostler 2004; Richardson 2010). The shirts believed to turn bullets had been met with rapid-fire artillery. Some twenty soldiers received the Medal of Honor. Forsyth's own commander, General Nelson Miles, condemned the affair as a criminal blunder and a massacre of women and children and pressed for an inquiry; the medals remain on the roll, though bills to rescind them, under the title of the Remove the Stain Act, have been introduced in Congress. Booker DeWitt was among the troopers: by the game's own chronology a sixteen-year-old corporal, decorated for what he did there and undone by it.

James Mooney's report for the Bureau of Ethnology, *The Ghost-Dance Religion and the Sioux Outbreak of 1890* (1896), records the doctrine in several versions. In Mooney's own

later summary, a new earth advancing from the west would push the whites back across the ocean, while the believers would be taken up, as by wings, upon the new surface; the Oglala George Sword's account, which Mooney printed, spoke of the whites' side being covered over by a new land coming over the old. The image deserves to be held beside Columbia. The Ghost Dance foresaw the faithful raised into the sky while the world below was purged; Columbia realizes that eschatology for the other side. Its white faithful are lifted aloft, and the world below, the Sodom, awaits purgation by fire.

Two further details of the doctrine bear on the game. The dance itself was a circle: men and women held hands, faced the center, and moved slowly round, singing, and acts of war were forbidden. And Wovoka's message, in the rendering Mooney printed, closed the five-day rite with a command that all must bathe in the river and then disperse to their homes. The massacred religion ended in the river. Booker, after the massacre, went down into one, and the circle returns at the end of the game as the ring of Elizabeths that closes around him (section 9.6).

The Hall of Heroes commemorates two victories: Wounded Knee and the suppression of the Boxer Uprising, in which Columbia fired on Peking. The pairing is exact. The Yihetuan, the "Boxers United in Righteousness," practiced rites of spirit possession believed to confer invulnerability to bullets and blades, as Joseph Esherick (1987) and Paul Cohen (1997) have documented. Both of the movements Columbia enshrines as conquered enemies were therefore millenarian movements whose adherents believed in ritual invulnerability. Columbia is itself a millenarian movement, and its invulnerability is literal elevation: a sovereign city floating beyond reach, awaiting a prophesied Seed who shall "drown in flame the mountains of man." Hence the term this thesis proposes. Columbia is a *White Ghost Dance*: a dance of white ghosts, its deified Founders venerated as saints, awaiting a renewal of the earth in which the racial other passes away. It is founded upon the graves of the two non-white millenarianisms it massacred, and it imitates the very hope it destroyed.

The violence of 1900 ran in both directions, and the record should name its agents. Boxer bands and Qing forces allied with them killed some two hundred Western missionaries, children among their families, and some thirty-two thousand Chinese Christians in northern China; at Taiyuan on 9 July some forty-four missionaries, family members, and Chinese Christians were killed, by most contemporary accounts in the presence of the provincial governor, Yuxian, though responsibility remains disputed. The foreign Legations in Peking were besieged for fifty-five days. The Eight-Nation Alliance that relieved them in August, American troops among its forces, followed its victory with the looting of the capital and with punitive expeditions in which Chinese villagers were summarily killed, and the Boxer Protocol of 1901 imposed on China an indemnity of 450 million taels of silver, more than the government's annual revenue, payable over thirty-nine years (Hevia 2003).

Columbia's Hall of Heroes, like the powers it flatters, remembers only the second half of this ledger, and remembers it as glory.

Walter Benjamin wrote that there is no document of civilization that is not at the same time a document of barbarism (1940, Thesis VII). The Hall of Heroes is such a document, curated for the victors. Roland Barthes (1957) defined myth as speech that transforms history into nature, emptying events of their contingency; the dioramas do exactly this. Within the victors' camp the game installs a single counter-historian. Cornelius Slate, a veteran of both campaigns, resents that Comstock has fabricated his own heroism at Wounded Knee and wishes only for a soldier's death and a true record. Slate is the archivist of the victors' lie, and his rebellion is historiographical before it is military.

2.5

Prophets of the Gilded Age: Smith, Dowie, Teed, and the Cages of Münster

Comstock is a composite of American prophecy, and Levine himself has partly compared him to Joseph Smith and Brigham Young while denying any one-to-one parallel. From Joseph Smith he takes the angelic revelation, the new scripture, and the city plat of Zion; from Brigham Young's Deseret he takes the theocratic polity in tension with federal sovereignty. That tension ended, in its Mormon form, with the Woodruff Manifesto of 1890, the year of Wounded Knee, which abandoned polygamy as the price of reconciliation with the Union. Columbia revives the separatist theocracy in the same year its earthly model capitulated, and it secedes rather than submits.

The Gilded Age offered closer analogues still. In 1901 the faith healer John Alexander Dowie founded Zion, Illinois, a theocratic city on the shore of Lake Michigan whose land, bank, and industries he controlled, and in which pork, tobacco, alcohol, and physicians were banned; that year he proclaimed himself Elijah the Restorer, and by 1906 financial collapse had deposed him. Cyrus Teed, who styled himself Koresh, led the Koreshan Unity to Estero, Florida, in 1894, preaching a cellular cosmogony in which humanity lives on the inner surface of a hollow sphere, and dispatching a geodetic survey to prove the earth's concavity with a purpose-built instrument. Comstock combines Smith's revelation, Dowie's company theocracy, and Teed's prophetic physics.

Herman Melville had already named the type in *The Confidence-Man: His Masquerade* (1857), whose shape-shifting swindler works the passengers of a Mississippi steamboat on April Fools' Day under a succession of guises, soliciting faith as a form of credit. Comstock is the confidence man who came to believe his own pitch, and Columbia is the steamboat that never docks.

The deepest precedent is European. In 1534 Anabaptists, the "re-baptizers" who rejected infant baptism, seized the Westphalian city of Münster and proclaimed it the New Jerusalem. After the prophet Jan Matthys fell in a sortie, Jan of Leiden was crowned king; goods were held in common, polygamy was decreed, and the besieged city awaited the end of the world. It fell in June 1535 to the besieging forces of its prince-bishop, Franz von Waldeck, whose troops killed many of the defenders they found. In January 1536, on the bishop's authority, Jan of Leiden and two other leaders, Bernhard Knipperdolling and Bernhard Krechting, were publicly tortured and executed, and their bodies were displayed in three iron cages hung from the tower of St. Lambert's Church, where the cages hang to this day. Norman Cohn's *The Pursuit of the Millennium* (1957) made Münster the paradigm of revolutionary millenarianism. A city of re-baptism that ends in cages on a tower supplies Columbia's two emblems: the baptismal font at the gate and the tower in which the Lamb is caged.

2.6

The Color Line in the Clouds

Du Bois's *Souls of Black Folk* (1903), published nine years before the game's present, names the century's problem and its psychology: double consciousness, "this sense of always looking at one's self through the eyes of others." Columbia is the color line raised to sovereignty.

Its first public rite makes the line liturgical. At the Raffle and Fair, the prize drawn by lottery is the first throw of a baseball at an interracial couple, a Black man and a white woman, bound and displayed on a stage before a cheering crowd. The fair presents itself as an annual rite in which the city recommits itself to its prophet on "this day of days," and Jackson's lottery, too, is held every year. The scene inevitably recalls Shirley Jackson's "The Lottery" (1948), in which a village festival culminates in the stoning of a member chosen by lot, and it enacts with textbook clarity what René Girard (1972; 1982) called the scapegoat mechanism, by which a community restores its unity through collective violence against a single designated victim. The scriptural intertext is John 8:7: "He that is without sin among you, let him first cast a stone." Booker has just been baptized at the gate. In Columbia's liturgy he has been ritually rendered without sin, and that is precisely what qualifies him to cast the first stone. The baptism and the stoning form one rite: absolution is the license to scapegoat. Zwingli, who coined the word catabaptist, described baptism as a sacramentum in the old Roman sense, an oath of allegiance enrolling the baptized into the visible community; Columbia's gate-baptism is a sacramentum of exactly this civic kind, and its first duty is the stone. The player may throw at the couple or at the announcer; in either case the

mark on Booker's hand is noticed and violence follows. The scapegoating cannot be refused, only redirected, and its next victim is Booker himself, the False Shepherd.

Du Bois later identified the "public and psychological wage" that whiteness paid to white workers in lieu of material equality (*Black Reconstruction*, 1935), and David Roediger (1991) and Noel Ignatiev (1995) traced how Irish immigrants purchased that wage through anti-Black solidarity. Columbia's labor order, which sets Irish and Black workers against one another beneath the Founders' indifference, is a study in the wages of whiteness. Booker's biography is another. At Wounded Knee, according to the game's lore as compiled by its fan archivists, a sergeant accused the sixteen-year-old Booker before his unit of having Native ancestry; he answered by scalping the dead and setting fire to lodges with people still inside, and earned the epithet "the White Injun." The atrocity was a performance of whiteness, staged to disavow an imputed Lakota descent. His surname concurs. The Dutch *de Wit*, "the white," is the epithet already inscribed in the name.

His given name rings in the same key. In the years of the Exposition the most famous Booker in America was Booker T. Washington, whose address at Atlanta's Cotton States Exposition in 1895, another world's fair, counseled Black accommodation in a bodily figure: "In all things that are purely social we can be as separate as the fingers, yet one as the hand in all things essential to mutual progress." A hand whose fingers are separate yet one is an uncanny gloss on Elizabeth, whose severed fingertip lives in another world while her body remains in this one. Booker DeWitt is "Booker the White": a proper name that holds the color line within itself.

The utopian tradition has always harbored this anxiety. In Plato's *Critias*, Atlantis declines when the divine portion in its rulers "began to fade away, and became diluted too often and too much with the mortal admixture" (121a, trans. Jowett). The founding text of the Western utopian imagination ends on a fable of contaminated descent. Columbia's panic over miscegenation, staged at the Raffle, is the oldest fear of the ideal city, and Toni Morrison's *Playing in the Dark* (1992), which shows American literature constructing whiteness through an "Africanist presence," supplies the method for reading it. Chapter Four applies that method to Daisy Fitzroy.

Aldous Huxley's *Brave New World* (1932) industrialized the same fantasy as castes bred to order in hatcheries and sanctified by a liturgy of "Our Ford." Columbia joins the caste to the cult by placing its Founders on the altar.

2.7

Regeneration through Violence

Richard Slotkin's *Regeneration through Violence* (1973) identified the structuring myth of the American frontier: the conviction that the nation renews its fortunes, spirit,

and power through violence against the wilderness and its peoples, enacted by a hunter-hero who absorbs the savagery he destroys. *Gunfighter Nation* (1992) followed the myth into film and mass culture. R. W. B. Lewis's *The American Adam* (1955) described the corresponding self-image of nineteenth-century letters: an individual emancipated from history, bereft of ancestry, standing alone and self-reliant at the start of a new world. William James's *Varieties of Religious Experience* (1902), delivered as the Gifford Lectures in the decade of Columbia's founding, distinguished the "once-born" healthy-minded soul from the "twice-born" sick soul, the divided self whose unification arrives through conversion.

The three frameworks converge on Booker and Comstock with schematic force. Wounded Knee is Booker's regeneration through violence, and it fails to regenerate. It yields drink, debt, and a bleeding nose. The baptism is the second regeneration, and it succeeds, monstrously: it produces Comstock, the American Adam who renames himself and declares his history washed away. Comstock is James's twice-born soul converted into a political program; Booker is the sick soul who refused the second birth and must live forever in the first. Columbia, where every arrival is baptized at the gate, is the society of the twice-born. Chapter Eight will argue that the first-person shooter is Slotkin's myth in its ludic form, a machine that regenerates its hero through violence without end. Columbia is where that machine was born.



CHAPTER THREE

THE PROPHET, THE LAMB, AND THE SEED

Revelation as Technology

"And God shall wipe away all tears from their eyes; and there shall be no more death, neither sorrow, nor crying."

Revelation 21:4

Comstock's religion is a hermeneutic error with an air force. Its revelations are images seen through a machine; its scripture is a misreading of physics; its messiah is a purchased child dressed in a miracle. This chapter reads the theology of Columbia as a theory of revelation in the age of mechanical vision, and argues that the game's onomastic and scriptural texture, from the Lamb who opens seals to the Lucan names of its principals, is not decoration but a second plot running beneath the first.

3.1

Prophecy as Misread Physics

Comstock's prophetic authority rests on visions obtained through the Lutece apparatus. He looked through tears into possible futures and declared what he saw to be revelation, and the archangel who showed him the city is a misrecognized interface. Ludwig Feuerbach argued in *The Essence of Christianity* (1841) that the secret of theology is anthropology: the divine predicates are human essence projected and estranged. Columbia inverts the formula's content while preserving its form. The secret of Comstock's theology is not anthropology but physics, and the divine predicates of omniscience and prophecy are the properties of an instrument projected onto a man.

Arthur C. Clarke's Third Law—"Any sufficiently advanced technology is indistinguishable from magic"—describes Comstock's epistemic predicament, though not his guilt; he is less deceived by the machine than eager to be. Carl Schmitt's *Political Theology* (1922) supplies the political consequence: the exception in jurisprudence is analogous to the miracle in theology, and the sovereign is he who decides on the exception. Comstock's sovereignty is the monopoly of the miracle. Each tear is an exception made visible, a suspension of the ordinary order of the world, and the prophet's claim to rule is identical with his claim to control such suspensions.

The prophet's body pays for his vision. Exposure to the tears has rendered Comstock sterile and aged him decades beyond his years. Tiresias, blinded and granted prophecy in exchange, is the ancient type of this exchange, in which sight of the hidden is purchased with the body's ordinary powers. Comstock's barrenness is the price of his prophecy, and it generates the plot: a prophet who has foreseen his dynasty but cannot beget it must buy it.

3.2

Comparative Prophets: Rumfoord, Bokonon, Haber, Hank Morgan

Kurt Vonnegut's *The Sirens of Titan* (1959) offers the closest literary analogue. Winston Niles Rumfoord, having flown his spacecraft into a "chrono-synclastic infundibulum," exists as a wave phenomenon spread across space and time, materializing periodically

and foreknowing the future. He uses that foreknowledge to stage a doomed Martian invasion of Earth and to found the Church of God the Utterly Indifferent. Comstock is Rumfoord stripped of irony: a man whose foreknowledge is an artifact of physics, and who converts it into a religion and a war. Vonnegut's *Cat's Cradle* (1963) supplies the theology's ethical index. Bokononism consists of *foma*, harmless untruths that make life bearable. Columbia's untruths are lethal.

Ursula K. Le Guin's *The Lathe of Heaven* (1971) supplies the institutional model. George Orr's dreams alter reality retroactively, and his psychiatrist, Dr. Haber, uses them to engineer a better world. Each improvement produces catastrophe: a request to end overpopulation brings a plague; a request to end racial conflict leaves every human being a uniform gray. Haber pursues utopia by homogenization; Comstock pursues it by purification. Both treat a possibility-engine housed in a vulnerable person as an instrument of social engineering. Elizabeth is Orr: the power to rewrite worlds placed in the custody of a utopian who believes he knows what the worlds should be.

Mark Twain's *A Connecticut Yankee in King Arthur's Court* (1889) supplies the American type. Hank Morgan, a nineteenth-century factory superintendent transported to Camelot, secures power by staging technological miracles, predicting an eclipse and dynamiting Merlin's tower, and his project of enlightenment ends in the Battle of the Sand Belt, where electrified fences and Gatling guns annihilate twenty-five thousand knights. The Yankee's republic of technique terminates in industrialized slaughter, as Columbia's does. Twain's later writings name the theology directly. "The War Prayer" (written 1905, published 1923) has a stranger interrupt a patriotic service to speak aloud the unspoken half of its petition, the prayer that the enemy's homes be laid waste and its children made orphans. Comstock's sermons are War Prayers with the unspoken half spoken. And Twain's "To the Person Sitting in Darkness" (1901), written in the aftermath of the Boxer Uprising, excoriated the missionaries and powers who extracted indemnities in blood and silver from China: the very campaign Columbia enshrines in its Hall of Heroes.

3.3

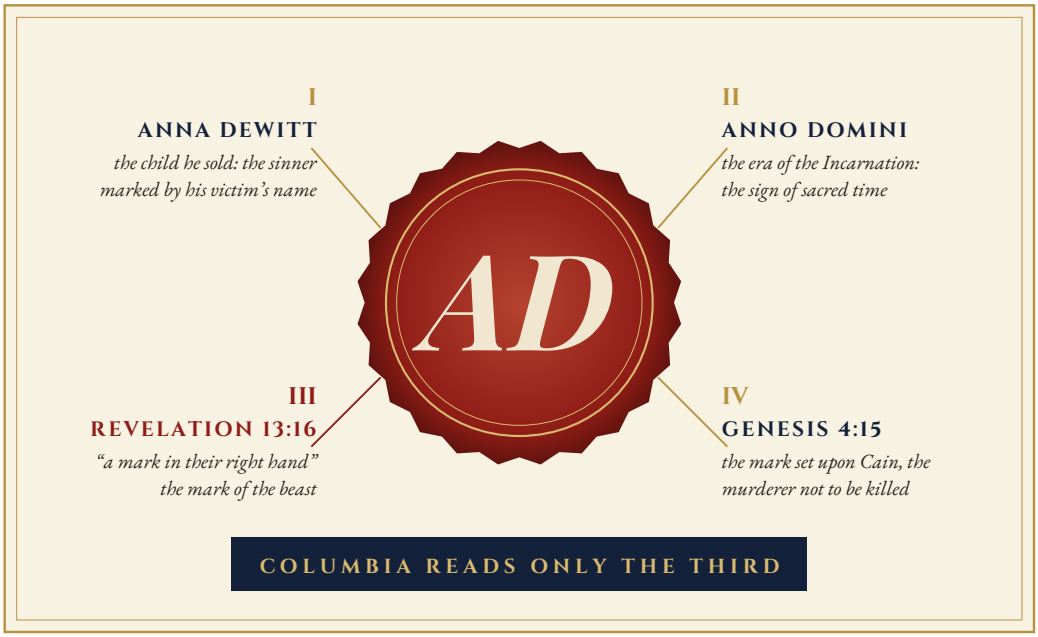
The Lamb Who Opens the Seals

In Revelation 5 a sealed scroll lies in the right hand of the one enthroned, and none in heaven or earth is worthy to open it except the Lamb that was slain. In chapter 6 the Lamb opens the seals one by one: the horsemen ride forth, the earth quakes, and "the heaven departed as a scroll when it is rolled together" (6:14). Elizabeth, whom Columbia calls the Lamb, is the one being who can open the tears. Her openings are apocalypse in the etymological sense, *apokalypsis*, unveiling; and in Columbia's theology they are apocalypse in the vulgar sense as well. The prophecy holds that the Seed of the Prophet shall sit the

throne and "drown in flame the mountains of man." The phrase fuses water and fire. It echoes the Baptist's announcement that the one coming after him "shall baptize you with the Holy Ghost, and with fire" (Matthew 3:11). Comstock's eschaton is a baptism by fire administered from the sky.

Chapter One observed that the verb of Colossians 2:14, which wipes away the bond of debt, returns in Revelation 7:17 and 21:4, where God "shall wipe away all tears from their eyes." The full context of the latter verse deserves attention, because it reads like a summary of the game. "And I saw a new heaven and a new earth: for the first heaven and the first earth were passed away; and there was no more sea. And I John saw the holy city, new Jerusalem, coming down from God out of heaven" (21:1–2). A holy city in the sky; a sea that is abolished; tears wiped away; the former things passed away. *Infinite* is Revelation 21 run in reverse. Its holy city does not descend but is unmade at the root; its sea is not abolished but becomes the medium of judgment; and the one who wipes away every tear is not the Father but a daughter, who does so by drowning a father.

FIGURE 5



The Mark on the Right Hand. *Four readings of the initials AD: a name, an era, the mark of the beast, and the mark of Cain (section 3.3).*

The earlier verse is closer still to the game's final action: "For the Lamb which is in the midst of the throne shall feed them, and shall lead them unto living fountains of waters: and God shall wipe away all tears from their eyes" (Revelation 7:17). The Lamb leads to the

waters, and then every tear is wiped away. Columbia's Lamb leads her father to the water at the river, and when he goes under, every tear in the multiverse closes.

The mark on Booker's right hand condenses four scriptures and a name. The initials *AD* are, first, Anna DeWitt: the sinner is marked by his victim's name, inscribed in his own flesh and, by the account of the series' fan-compiled lore, by his own hand, cut or burned there in remorse after the sale. If so, the scar is a *cheirographon* in the most literal sense, a bond in the debtor's own hand written upon the debtor's own hand, and it is this writing that the ending, like the cross of Colossians, wipes away. They are, second, *Anno Domini*, the era reckoned from the Incarnation, so that the False Shepherd bears the sign of sacred time. They recall, third, Revelation 13:16, where the beast causes all to receive "a mark in their right hand, or in their foreheads," the mark by which Columbia's prophecy identifies its enemy. They recall, fourth, the mark set upon Cain (Genesis 4:15), the sign of a murderer who is not to be killed by the avenger. Booker's hand thus carries the name of the child he sold, the time of the Lord, the mark of the beast, and the mark of the first murderer. Columbia reads only the third.

The epithet *False Shepherd* is Johannine. "I am the good shepherd: the good shepherd giveth his life for the sheep. But he that is an hireling, and not the shepherd, whose own the sheep are not, seeth the wolf coming, and leaveth the sheep, and fleeth" (John 10:11–12). Booker is the hireling in the most literal sense available to the 1890s: a Pinkerton, a mercenary detective, a man paid to fetch. He saw the wolf coming and left his lamb. The ending inverts the pericope: the hireling becomes the shepherd only by giving his life.

3.4

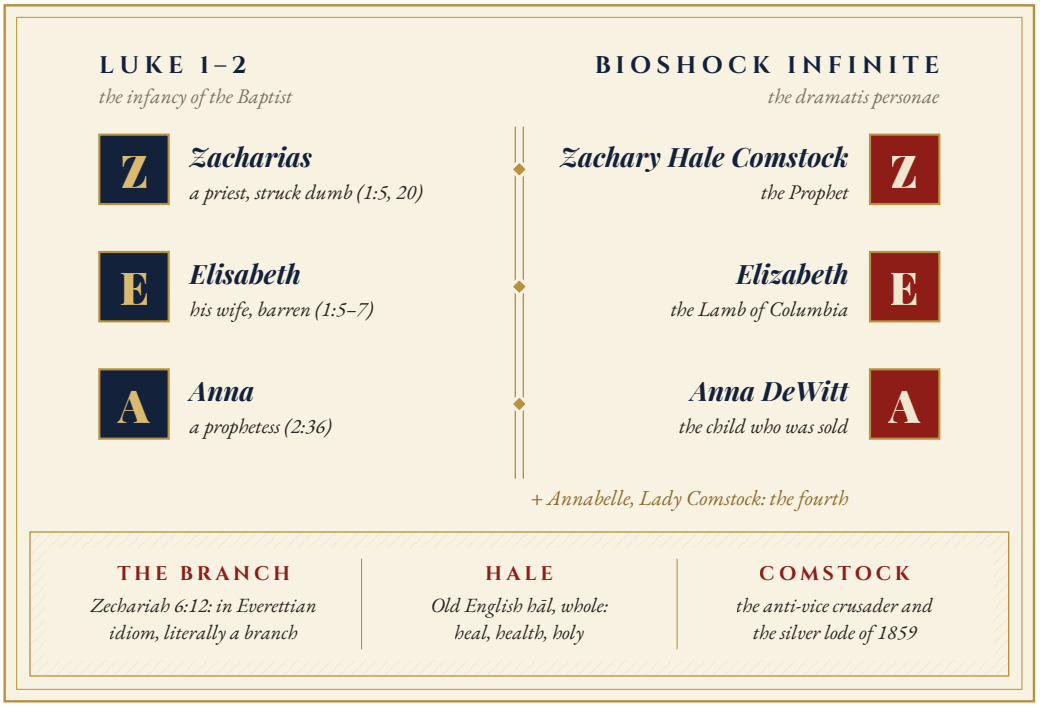
The Barren Prophet and the Purchased Seed

Comstock cannot beget, and Columbian doctrine dresses his purchase as a miracle: a child born to the Prophet and Lady Comstock in a gestation of seven days, the hexameron of Creation compressed into a nativity. The scriptural frame of the Seed is Genesis, where enmity is set between the serpent's seed and the woman's (3:15) and Abraham is promised that his seed "shall possess the gate of his enemies" (22:17). But Paul's allegory in Galatians 4:22–31 discloses the fraud. Abraham had two sons, "the one by a bondmaid, the other by a freewoman"; the son of the bondwoman was "born after the flesh," the son of the freewoman "by promise"; and scripture commands, "Cast out the bondwoman and her son." Elizabeth is the child of a transaction proclaimed a child of promise. Columbia is founded on the attempt to pass Hagar's son off as Isaac. The game's own backstory completes the typology with uncanny exactness. Lady Comstock, believing the child to be the Prophet's bastard by Rosalind Lutece, refused to keep her under their roof, and Comstock built the tower on Monument Island to house her. Sarah's demand—"Cast out this bond-

woman and her son: for the son of this bondwoman shall not be heir" (Genesis 21:10)—is executed in architecture, and the heir is raised in the tower to which the bondwoman's child was cast out.

The names of the principals enact a second, submerged narrative. Luke's Gospel opens with "a certain priest named Zacharias" whose wife was named Elisabeth; both were "well stricken in years," and Elisabeth was barren (1:5–7). An angel announces that she will bear a son; Zacharias doubts and is struck dumb until the child's naming; the child is John the Baptist (1:13–64). In the next chapter appears "Anna, a prophetess" (2:36), who greets the infant Christ in the Temple. *Zachary*, *Elizabeth*, *Anna*: the three central names of *Infinite*—with Annabelle, Lady Comstock, as the fourth—are the dramatis personae of the Lucan infancy narrative whose child is the Baptist. The game transposes the barrenness from Elisabeth to Zachary, replaces the angelic gift with a purchase, and withholds the Baptist from the cast. But the Baptist is not missing. At the end the child of these names becomes the one who baptizes. Elizabeth is the Baptist the Lucan names were waiting for.

FIGURE 6



A Gospel of Names. *The principals named after the dramatis personae of Luke's infancy narrative, with the onomastic ledger of the remaining names (section 3.4).*

The prophet's given name has a second biblical bearer. The prophet Zechariah announces a messianic figure called the Branch: "Behold the man whose name is The

BRANCH; and he shall grow up out of his place, and he shall build the temple of the LORD" (6:12; cf. 3:8). Comstock builds the temple-city, and in Everettian idiom he is literally a branch. The same prophet sees a woman, personified as Wickedness, sealed inside a measuring vessel, and two winged women "like the wings of a stork" lift the vessel "between the earth and the heaven" and carry it to Shinar to build it a house (5:5–11). The prophetic book whose name Comstock bears contains a captive woman sealed and borne through the air.

The remaining names complete the onomastic ledger. *Hale* derives from Old English *hāl*, whole, the root of *heal*, *health*, and *holy*: the man who claims wholeness by immersion. *Comstock* recalls Anthony Comstock (1844–1915), the anti-vice crusader whose Comstock Act (1873) criminalized the mailing of "obscene" material and whose zeal Bernard Shaw mocked as "Comstockery" (1905); it recalls equally the Comstock Lode of Nevada silver (1859). The name joins moral purification to mineral extraction, which is to say the Lamb to the Siphon.

Comstock's theology of lineage has a clinical counterpart in the most famous paranoid cosmology of the age. Daniel Paul Schreber's *Memoirs of My Nervous Illness* (1903) describe an Order of the World in which God's rays would transform Schreber so that he might bear a new race, together with "miracled birds," talking birds into which the remnants of once-blessed souls had been inserted, repeating phrases learned by rote. His second and decisive illness began in the autumn of 1893, the season in which the game sets the sale of Anna. Freud analyzed the memoirs in 1911; Lacan, in his seminar on the psychoses (1955–56), traced Schreber's delusion to the foreclosure of the paternal name. Comstock's self-renaming is a self-paternization, an attempt to found the paternal name from nothing, and the dynasty he could not beget is supplied by a narrative of miracle. Songbird, the mechanical bird bonded to Elizabeth and answering only to her melody, is his miracled bird.

3.5

Sodom Below: Salt, Lot, and the Offered Daughter

Columbia's name for the world beneath it is "the Sodom below," and the typology rewards pursuit. In Genesis 19, when the men of Sodom surround Lot's house demanding his guests, the righteous man offers his daughters instead: "Behold now, I have two daughters which have not known man; let me, I pray you, bring them out unto you" (19:8). The patriarch of Sodom's only righteous household is a father who offers his daughters to the crowd. Booker, the father who surrendered his daughter to a creditor, stands in Lot's place. As Lot's family flees, his wife looks back toward the burning city and becomes a pillar of salt (19:26).

The resource that powers Columbia's Vigors is called Salts. The energy of Columbian power thus bears the name of the residue of a woman punished for looking back; and Elizabeth's power consists precisely in looking back, through tears, into other times and other cities. The economic sense of the word completes the figure. Salt is the substance of the covenant ("salt of the earth," Matthew 5:13) and, by a traditional if contested derivation, of the *salarium*, the soldier's salt-money and thus of the salary. Salts are the wages of power in a city that has looked back on the Sodom it fled.

The narrative does not end with the flight, and its sequel bears directly on Columbia's theology of the Seed. In a cave in the mountains above Zoar, Lot's daughters, believing that no man remains on earth to father children after the destruction of the cities, make their father drunk on successive nights and conceive by him, saying, "we will lie with him, that we may preserve seed of our father" (Genesis 19:32); their sons become the ancestors of Moab and Ammon. The story that begins with a father offering his daughters to the crowd ends with daughters securing a father's line by transgression after the end of a world. Comstock's dynasty rests on the same displacement: a lineage that cannot be continued legitimately is manufactured by illicit means and then named providence. The resemblance is structural, not sexual. What Columbia shares with the cave above Zoar is the conviction that the Seed must be preserved at any cost once the world below has been written off.

3.6

The Lady and the Dynamo: Mariology, the Siren, and Forgiveness

Lady Annabelle Comstock is venerated in Columbia as its Lady, a Marian figure whose martyrdom the city mourns. In truth Comstock had her killed when she threatened to reveal the origin of the child, and he blamed the murder on Daisy Fitzroy. Comstock, channelling Elizabeth's power through the Siphon, raises the Lady as a revenant, called the Siren, who in turn raises the dead against the living. The name is exact. In archaic Greek art the Sirens are bird-bodied women; in the *Odyssey* their song promises knowledge of all that happens upon the fruitful earth (12.191). The Siren is thus a figure of total knowledge housed in an avian body, the mother-shade who knows the truth Comstock buried, and an image of the condition Elizabeth will herself attain. The game's ornithology—Songbird, the Siren, the bird brooch, the crows of the Lady's zealots, the eagle of the Founders—is a single symbolic system in which every bird is either a guardian or a captive, and usually both.

The Lady's given name returns the analysis to the nineteenth century. Poe's "Annabel Lee" (1849) mourns a beloved who dwelt in a kingdom by the sea until "the wind came out of the cloud by night, / Chilling and killing my Annabel Lee." Lady Comstock is the Annabel killed in a kingdom of clouds.

Her arc is also where the game installs forgiveness. Elizabeth opens tears that show the shade the truth of her death and of the child's origin, and the Siren relents. Levine has recounted that a developer threatened to quit over the game's presentation of Comstock and religion, and that their conversations led him to reconsider the New Testament's account of forgiveness and to ask why anyone would follow a man like Comstock. The anecdote is evidence only of context, but the text bears it out: the one character who forgives is the one who was murdered, and she forgives a daughter who is not hers. The Prophet states the opposite creed in a line the game sets against her: the Lord forgives everything, he says, but he is only a prophet, and so does not have to. Henry Adams's polarity returns here in miniature. Columbia's Virgin, like its Lamb, is powered by a dynamo; but the Virgin's single free act is mercy, which no dynamo explains.

3.7

Benjamin's Angel and Comstock's Archangel

Comstock attributes the founding vision of Columbia to an archangel. The figure invites comparison with the most famous angel of twentieth-century thought. In the ninth of his "Theses on the Philosophy of History" (1940), Walter Benjamin describes Paul Klee's *Angelus Novus* as the angel of history. His face is turned toward the past; where we perceive a chain of events, he sees a single catastrophe piling wreckage upon wreckage at his feet. He would like to stay, awaken the dead, and make whole what has been smashed; but a storm blowing from Paradise has caught his wings and propels him irresistibly into the future, while the pile of debris grows skyward. That storm, Benjamin writes, is what we call progress.

Comstock's archangel faces the other way. It is the angel of progress itself, gazing toward the future it promises, and it authorizes the history of the victors that the Hall of Heroes displays and Benjamin's seventh thesis indicts. Elizabeth, after the Siphon's destruction, becomes the other angel. She sees all histories at once, as one catastrophe, from a vantage outside the continuum; she would make whole what has been smashed; and her final act is what Benjamin's fourteenth thesis calls a tiger's leap into the past, an act that blasts open the continuum of history (Theses XVI–XVII) from a *Jetztzeit*, a now-time charged with messianic possibility.

The comparison exposes the game's boldest and most dangerous move. Benjamin ascribed to every generation only a *weak* messianic power (Thesis II), a claim the past has on us that we can honor but not fulfill. Elizabeth's power is strong, nearly absolute. And it is bounded in a way that matters for the argument of Chapter Nine. She can leap only to the branch-point at the river, which lies *after* Wounded Knee. The angel can prevent the

catastrophe of Columbia; she cannot awaken the dead of 1890. The wreckage that founded the city remains at the angel's feet, untouched by the rite that unmakes the city.

3.8

The Double and the Murdered Prophet: Rank, Freud, Jung

Otto Rank's study of the double (1914) traced the figure from an ancient insurance against death to a modern harbinger of it, and Freud's essay "The Uncanny" (1919) placed the double among the experiences in which the familiar returns as the frightening, since the uncanny, he argued, is what was once known and has been repressed. Comstock is Booker's double in exactly this sense. He is not a stranger but the self Booker refused at the river, returned as a prophet. The nosebleeds that strike Booker whenever another world presses on his memory are the somatic form of the uncanny: the body bleeds where the repressed comes back.

Freud's later work supplies the double's dynamics. *Beyond the Pleasure Principle* (1920) began from a child's game of throwing away and retrieving a spool, *fort* and *da*, and from the compulsion to repeat even painful experiences; it concluded by positing a drive that seeks the return of the living to the inorganic, summarized in the sentence "Das Ziel alles Lebens ist der Tod," the aim of all life is death. The Lutece coin, flipped and recorded more than a hundred times, is a *fort–da* game played with a man's fate, and Booker's consent at the river is the death drive's return to the water from which, in the game's imagery, all his possibilities emerged.

Totem and Taboo (1913) told of a primal father killed by his sons, whose remorse produced the prohibitions they then obeyed in what Freud called "deferred obedience" (*nachträglicher Gehorsam*) to the father they had murdered. *Moses and Monotheism* (1939) proposed that the Israelites murdered their prophet and repressed the deed, which returned as religion. *Infinite* stages both conjectures with a turn Freud could not have imagined. Booker kills the father-prophet by drowning him in his own font. The murderer and the murdered are the same man. And the murderer then submits, in deferred obedience, to the father's own sacrament: having drowned Comstock in the font, Booker goes down into the river. The guilt that follows the killing of the prophet is not repressed; it is ritualized as a second immersion.

C. G. Jung named the rejected portion of the personality the shadow, and held that it is not overcome by being projected onto others but only by being made conscious and integrated. Comstock is Booker's shadow projected onto an entire city, and Columbia is that projection given a skyline. The ending refuses integration. It does not make the darkness conscious and live with it; it drowns light and shadow together at their common root.



CHAPTER FOUR

VOX POPULI, VOX DEI?

Revolution, Equivalence, and Pilate's Basin

"Nec audiendi qui solent dicere, Vox populi, vox Dei, quum tumultuositas vulgi semper insaniae proxima sit."

Alcuin of York to Charlemagne (c. 798)

The most contested element of *Infinite* is not its physics but its politics: the representation of a Black-led insurrection of Columbia's laborers as a mirror image of the racist theocracy it overthrows. This chapter reconstructs the historical materials from which the Vox Populi were assembled, sets the game's treatment of revolutionary violence against three canonical grammars of that violence, and argues that the game's much-criticized equivalence is not a lapse of political judgment but a structural necessity of its metaphysical ending. It is an ablution: the author washes his hands before the multitude, and the water in the basin is the same water that will fill the river.

4.1

Alcuin's Warning

The phrase *vox populi, vox Dei* enters written history as a warning. Writing to Charlemagne around 798, Alcuin of York advised that those who say the voice of the people is the voice of God should not be heeded, since the tumult of the crowd is always close to madness. The proverb's later career inverted it into a slogan of popular sovereignty, and in that inverted form it underwrites the name of Daisy Fitzroy's movement. The game's narrative then pursues Alcuin's original meaning with relentless consistency: the voice of the people, armed, becomes indistinguishable from the madness of the crowd.

Rousseau's *Social Contract* (1762) had distinguished the general will, which aims at the common good, from the will of all, which is merely the sum of particular interests, and had warned that whoever refuses to obey the general will must be "forced to be free" (I.7). Daisy speaks in the register of the general will; the Vox under arms degenerate into the will of all, a sum of vengeances. The distinction is Rousseau's, but the descent is Plato's. Book VIII of the *Republic* narrates the degeneration of regimes, from the rule of the best through timocracy, oligarchy, and democracy to tyranny, which arises from the excess of the freedom it destroys. Columbia passes through the whole cycle in a few hours of play: theocracy, plutocracy, insurrection, terror.

4.2

Fink, Pullman, and the Pinkerton

Finkton is a company town. Its workers live under Jeremiah Fink's regulation and labor in his factories; on a central stage a daily auction awards repair jobs to whoever promises the shortest completion time, a Taylorist speed-up staged as public spectacle, and the Good Time Club, ostensibly entertainment for the better-paid workers, serves chiefly to keep them in check. The historical model is legible. George Pullman's model town south of Chicago, built from 1880, combined paternal amenity with total control of rents, wages,

and morals; when the depression of 1893 led Pullman to cut wages without reducing rents, the strike and national boycott of 1894, led by Eugene V. Debs's American Railway Union, were broken by federal troops, and Debs went to prison. Two years earlier, at Carnegie's Homestead works, Henry Clay Frick had summoned three hundred Pinkerton agents, who arrived by barge on the Monongahela and fought a pitched battle with the strikers on the riverbank.

Booker is a former Pinkerton, dismissed for his conduct, and the game repeatedly invokes his strikebreaking past. The protagonist of the revolution plot is therefore an alumnus of the private army that the Gilded Age deployed against labor. The industrialist's name sharpens the irony. *Fink* entered American slang in the first years of the twentieth century, recorded from 1902, as a term for an informer and, later, a strikebreaker. A popular etymology derives it from the "Pinks," the Pinkerton men hired against the Homestead strikers of 1892, but the story spread in the 1920s and the early evidence does not support it; the likelier source is the German *Fink*, a finch, which also meant an informer, one who sings. Either way the game has placed a man whose name means strikebreaker at the head of capital and a man who broke strikes at the head of the rescue, and the likelier etymology sharpens the design: the industrialist who bears a songbird's name is a maker of Songbird, and his brother sells as his own the songs of other worlds.

The *Communist Manifesto* (1848) observed that under machinery the worker "becomes an appendage of the machine." Columbia's Handymen literalize the sentence. They are human beings whose bodies have been grafted into towering mechanical frames, their living hearts visible behind glass in the chest like the gauge of a boiler. Frederick Winslow Taylor's *Principles of Scientific Management* appeared in 1911, the year before the game's present; the Handyman is Taylorism's ideal worker, all output and no rest, displayed as a monster.

Marx's account of primitive accumulation (*Capital* I, Part VIII) describes the violent expropriations that precede and found capitalist production, and concludes that capital comes into the world "dripping from head to foot, from every pore, with blood and dirt." Columbia's founding capital is of exactly this kind: the land and lives taken at Wounded Knee, the silver extracted from Peking, the child purchased in 1893. Fink extends the process across worlds. His Vigors are reverse-engineered from the plasmids of Rapture, glimpsed through a tear; Songbird, as the downloadable sequel reveals, was co-developed by Fink and Rapture's Yi Suchong alongside the Big Daddies; and his brother Albert transcribes and sells as his own the songs of decades not yet lived. This is *trans-modal primitive accumulation*: enclosure extended from the commons of the earth to the commons of the possible.

4.3

The Populist Moment and Caesar's Column

The People's Party, founded in 1892, adopted at Omaha a platform whose preamble, drafted by Ignatius Donnelly, opened by declaring that the convention met "in the midst of a nation brought to the verge of moral, political, and material ruin." The Vox Populi carry the name of that moment, and Donnelly himself had already imagined its nightmare. His dystopian novel *Caesar's Column* (1890) depicts a New York of 1988 ruled by a plutocratic oligarchy. A secret Brotherhood of Destruction rises under Caesar Lomellini; the revolution becomes a massacre; the dead, a quarter of a million by the novel's count, are piled in Union Square and sealed in cement as a monumental column. The narrator, Gabriel Weltstein, a wool merchant from a Swiss colony in Uganda who had arrived by airship, leaves the same way, looking back on the burning city as the column rises through the smoke, and returns to Africa to found an agrarian republic. The novel's coding of its antagonists is part of its argument and of its legacy: the plutocrat Prince Cabano was born Jacob Isaacs, and Caesar Lomellini is drawn as a ruthless fanatic of mixed Italian and African descent. The Populist imagination that indicted the oligarchs lodged both capital and revolution in the bodies of racial others, a structure that returns in *Infinite*'s treatment of Daisy Fitzroy (section 4.5). The Populist movement's chief literary voice thus wrote, two years before the party's founding, the very story *Infinite* tells about it: an uprising of the dispossessed that degenerates into slaughter, witnessed from an airship.

H. G. Wells's *When the Sleeper Wakes* (1899) supplies a second template. Graham, a Victorian who sleeps for two centuries, wakes to find that compound interest has made him nominal owner of the world, and that a revolutionary named Ostrog has raised the masses in his name. The revolution installs Ostrog as the new master; Graham dies in an aerial battle against him. The figure of the absent martyr whose name becomes revolutionary capital recurs exactly in the world where the Vox have risen and Booker is a dead hero of their cause. The living Booker is an embarrassment to his own legend, and Daisy turns on him for that reason.

4.4

Three Grammars of Revolutionary Violence: Fanon, Camus, Arendt

Frantz Fanon's *The Wretched of the Earth* (1961) opens by declaring that decolonization is always a violent phenomenon, and argues that, at the level of individuals, violence is a cleansing force that frees the colonized from inferiority and despair. In Fanon's grammar the violence of the oppressed is not the mirror of the oppressor's violence but its answer,

the necessary act by which the colonized constitute themselves as subjects. Daisy Fitzroy's rhetoric is Fanonian; her movement's grievance is exact; the game knows this, and stages her speeches without irony.

Albert Camus's *The Rebel* (1951) offers the opposing grammar. Rebellion, in Camus's account, affirms a limit and a solidarity at once, "I rebel—therefore we exist," while revolution abandons the limit in the name of history's eventual absolution and arrives at murder justified by the future. His play *The Just Assassins* (1949) gives the limit a concrete form. The revolutionary Kaliayev, poised to throw a bomb at the Grand Duke's carriage, refuses when he sees the Duke's young nephew and niece inside; the child marks the boundary that rebellion cannot cross without becoming its enemy. *Infinite* stages Camus's test with diagrammatic precision. Daisy, having executed Fink, turns her pistol on his son, and the game's moral verdict falls at the very line Kaliayev would not cross.

Hannah Arendt's *On Violence* (1970) distinguishes power, which corresponds to the human ability to act in concert, from violence, which is instrumental; violence can destroy power but is incapable of creating it. *On Revolution* (1963) argues that revolutions founder when the "social question," the urgency of material necessity, overwhelms the project of founding freedom. The Vox world dramatizes both theses: an insurgency born of genuine misery, unable to found anything, consuming its own legitimacy in the act of destroying its enemies.

The game, then, follows Arendt and Camus and refuses Fanon. That refusal is a position, not a neutrality, and it requires the specific scene that section 4.5 examines.

4.5

Daisy Fitzroy and the Africanist Presence

Daisy Fitzroy was a Black servant in Comstock House, framed for the murder of Lady Comstock, who fled to the slums and built the Vox Populi. Her surname is Anglo-Norman, *fitz roy*, "son of the king," historically the name given to acknowledged royal bastards. The insurgent leader bears the patronymic of illegitimate sovereignty, as if she were heir to the house that framed her.

In the world where the revolution has erupted, Daisy executes Fink and then holds a pistol to his child. Elizabeth kills her from behind with a pair of scissors. Immediately afterward Elizabeth cuts her own hair and changes into a darker, more mature dress. The scene is constructed as a rite of passage: the girl becomes a woman by killing the revolutionary.

The second episode of *Burial at Sea* (2014) supplied a retrospective explanation. In a conversation Elizabeth overhears, Daisy tells the Luteces that she will not hurt a child; they persuade her to feign the threat so that Elizabeth will be forced to kill her and so cross into adulthood, and Daisy accepts the role knowing it will cost her life. Some read the revision

as restoring Daisy's dignity; at least one reviewer at the time called it an unnecessary retcon. This thesis argues that it compounds the original problem. It reassigns the Black revolutionary's final act to a script written by two white scientists for the maturation of a white girl, and it converts Daisy from a political agent whose cause fails into a sacrificial instrument whose death succeeds. Toni Morrison's *Playing in the Dark* (1992) describes the "Africanist presence" through which American literature has constituted whiteness: Black figures who exist in the text to occasion the self-fashioning of white protagonists. The retcon does not escape that pattern. It perfects it.

The revision also undoes, from inside, the Camusian test examined in section 4.4. The child at whom the game drew its moral line was never in danger; the line was crossed only in appearance, and the appearance was scripted for Elizabeth's education. A recording of Daisy's found in Fink's office is titled "Stay the Hand," a phrase that recalls the angel who stays Abraham's knife over Isaac (Genesis 22:12). The game first indicted Daisy at the altar of the child and then revealed that she had been an Abraham whose hand was never going to fall—but only so that a white girl could become a woman by killing her.

Fairness requires an observation in the game's favor. Its own metaphysics could have supported a structural account of Daisy's violence. The Vox world is the product of variables: Chen Lin murdered, Booker martyred, the city at war. Daisy's cruelty there is a variable conditioned by circumstance, not a constant of her character. The tears had shown that revolutions differ across worlds. Having demonstrated that violence is conditioned, the game nonetheless judges it as character. That choice, available to be made otherwise, is what requires explanation.

4.6

Shigalyov and the Gadarene Swine

Dostoevsky's *Demons* (1871–72) supplied the modern archetype of revolutionary self-cancellation. Its theorist Shigalyov confesses that, beginning from unlimited freedom, his system arrives at unlimited despotism. The novel takes its epigraph from Luke's account of the Gadarene swine (8:32–36), and the passage is equally pertinent to *Infinite*. In Mark's telling, the unclean spirit, asked its name, answers: "My name is Legion: for we are many" (5:9). Cast into a herd of swine, the spirits drive them "violently down a steep place into the sea," and the swine "were choked in the sea" (5:13).

The image of a multitude of demons, bearing one name and many bodies, drowned together in the sea, will return at the river. Dostoevsky read the parable as a prophecy of revolutionary possession. *Infinite* reads it, at the last, as a prophecy of modal exorcism: the Comstocks are many, they bear one name, and they are drowned in a single immersion.

4.7

Pilate's Basin

"When Pilate saw that he could prevail nothing, but that rather a tumult was made, he took water, and washed his hands before the multitude, saying, I am innocent of the blood of this just person: see ye to it" (Matthew 27:24). The gesture is the scriptural archetype of political ablution: the magistrate who holds the power to decide performs a ritual of non-involvement before the crowd, so that the verdict may be borne by all and therefore by none.

The game's equivalence of Founders and Vox is such an ablution. By presenting the racist theocracy and the insurgent poor as moral equals, *Infinite* washes its hands before the multitude of its own factions. The standard objection is correct as far as it goes. Equivalence between oppressor and oppressed is not neutrality; it ignores the primacy of the violence that founded the order, which Fanon placed at the center of his analysis, and it treats the asymmetry of power as irrelevant to the morality of its overthrow.

The record of production gives the gesture its grammar. Levine described the game as a Rorschach test for its audiences, explaining that his vision was "about not buying into a single point of view," and said that it made no particular point about racism, whose depiction reflected the period rather than an argument about it. The intentional fallacy forbids treating such remarks as the meaning of the work, but they are evidence of the ablution's logic: the refusal to take a side presented as the refusal to take a position. Reception supplied the irony. A Tea Party group posted one of the game's nativist propaganda murals on its Facebook page before the source was recognized, and a cable-news segment on immigration adopted a logo closely resembling the game's. The Founders' imagery was legible to partisans as an argument, whatever equivalences its author intended.

But the deeper function of the gesture appears only in light of the ending. The game needs both factions to be disposable. If the Vox were right, the narrative would have to conclude in a revolution, a political resolution of a political crisis. Because the Vox are as compromised as the Founders, no political resolution is available, and the crisis must be transposed to another register, where it can be solved by a metaphysical act performed by a single family. Political ablution is the precondition of metaphysical absolution. Pilate's basin prepares John's river. The hands that are washed clean of the revolution are the hands that will hold Booker under the water.



V

CHAPTER FIVE

CONSTANTS AND VARIABLES

The Metaphysics of the Possible

"Le silence éternel de ces espaces infinis m'effraie."

Blaise Pascal, *Pensées* (L201/B206)

The phrase "constants and variables," which the Luteces and Elizabeth use to summarize the structure of the cosmos, is the game's metaphysical axiom. It asserts that across the totality of possible worlds some things recur invariantly—a lighthouse, a man, a city—while others vary. Everything in the ending depends on which things are constant, and why. This chapter argues that the game's answer is not drawn from quantum mechanics, which supplies only its imagery, but from the philosophy of reference and identity, and that it takes a decisive and contestable side in a debate that ran from Leibniz to Kripke, Lewis, and Parfit.

5.1

From Everett to Columbia

In 1957 Hugh Everett III proposed in the *Reviews of Modern Physics* that the quantum wave function never collapses. A measurement does not select one outcome; it correlates the observer with each outcome in a superposition of "relative states," so that every possibility is realized in a branch of a universal wave function. Bryce DeWitt popularized the proposal as the "many-worlds" interpretation in *Physics Today* (1970) and, with Neill Graham, assembled its founding documents (1973). Erwin Schrödinger's cat (1935) had already dramatized the scandal of superposition at macroscopic scale; H. Dieter Zeh's work on decoherence (1970) explained why branches, once separated, do not interfere; David Deutsch (1997) made the multiverse a general philosophy.

Columbia floats on this physics. Rosalind Lutece's discovery, recorded in her voxophones with an aristocratic coolness, is a means of suspending a particle in space indefinitely; extended to a city, the effect keeps Columbia aloft. The tears are the same science turned on the boundaries between branches. Here the game departs from Everett in an instructive way. Everettian branches are decoherent and causally isolated: one cannot visit them, import objects from them, or remember them. *Infinite*'s branches are permeable. Objects pass through tears, memories bleed between counterparts, and the nosebleeds that afflict Booker and others mark the body's protest against carrying two histories at once. The game's cosmology is therefore closer to later speculative proposals of interacting worlds (Hall, Deckert, and Wiseman 2014) than to Everett. It is a physics of porous branches, which is to say a physics in which the possible can affect the actual and, crucially, be held accountable by it.

The word for such a cosmos predates the physics by six decades. In "Is Life Worth Living?" (1895), an address to the Harvard Young Men's Christian Association, William James wrote that visible nature is all plasticity and indifference, "a moral multiverse, as one might call it, and not a moral universe." The passage is commonly cited as the word's earliest recorded use, though a letter in Scientific American had already set the universe against "a co-

hering multiverse" in 1873, and it was Michael Moorcock who, in "The Blood Red Game" (1963), gave the word its modern sense of many coexisting worlds. James pressed his image into a gendered figure of refusal: to such a harlot, he said of nature, we owe no allegiance, and with her as a whole we can establish no moral communion. James's point was that nature offers no moral verdict, so that meaning must be made by the will to believe, by commitments that go beyond the evidence and help create the facts they anticipate ("The Will to Believe," 1896). His later *A Pluralistic Universe* (1909) generalized the point into a metaphysics of irreducible plurality.

Infinite takes James's word and reverses its sense. Its multiverse is not morally indifferent but morally saturated. Because every alternative is actual, every refused sin is committed elsewhere, by someone with one's own origin and one's own name until a river changed it. James's indifference becomes a tribunal, and the plurality that freed James's believer to choose becomes the evidence by which the game's protagonist is convicted. Where James refused communion with the multiverse, the game convenes a court in it.

5.2

Leibniz in the Lighthouse: The Palace of the Fates

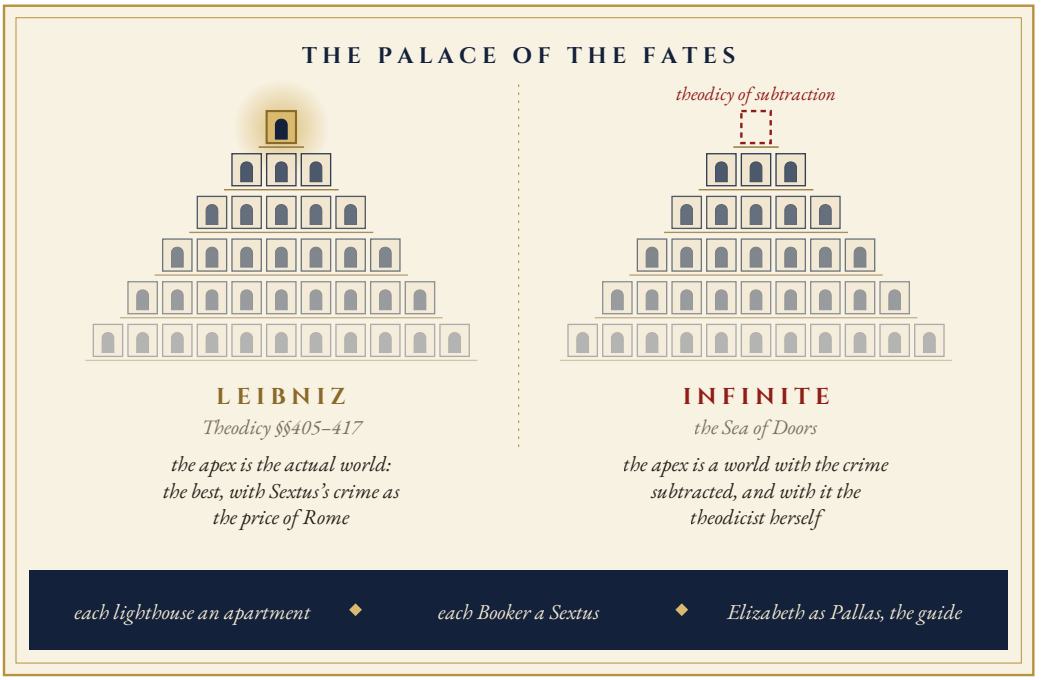
The *Theodicy* (1710) closes with a fable (§§405–417) that is the most exact philosophical prototype of *Infinite*'s finale. Leibniz extends Lorenzo Valla's dialogue on free will: Sextus Tarquinius complains to Jupiter of the crime he is fated to commit, and the priest Theodorus, troubled by the god's answer, is granted a dream. Pallas Athena leads him through the Palace of the Fates, whose apartments each represent a possible world containing a different Sextus. In one, Sextus lives contentedly in Corinth; in another, he becomes a king in Thrace. The apartments rise in a pyramid that grows more beautiful toward its apex, which represents the actual world, the best of all possible worlds; and the pyramid has a summit but no base, descending infinitely, because among infinitely many possible worlds there is a best but no worst. In the actual world Sextus commits the crime against Lucretia, from which the Roman Republic and its greatness proceed.

The Sea of Doors is the Palace of the Fates. Each lighthouse is an apartment; each Booker is a Sextus; Elizabeth plays Pallas, the divine guide who leads a mortal through his counterparts so that he may understand the necessity of what follows. The structure of the vision—a dream-like passage through a hall of possible lives, culminating in a judgment about which world shall be—is the same.

The moral of the fable is inverted. Leibniz's God actualizes the best world because its total goodness outweighs the crime it contains; Sextus's guilt is the price of Rome. Elizabeth actualizes, or attempts to actualize, a world from which the crime has been subtracted,

and with it herself, since her existence as Elizabeth depends on the sale she cancels. The result is a *theodicy of subtraction*: the best possible world is the one without the theodicist.

FIGURE 7



THE PALACE OF THE FATES. *Leibniz's pyramid of possible worlds beside its inversion in the Sea of Doors: a theodicy of subtraction (section 5.2).*

Leibniz's metaphysics of individuals also marks the point at which the game must part from him. Each substance, he held, has a complete individual concept containing every predicate it will ever bear (*Discourse on Metaphysics*, 1686, §§8, 13), so that, as he explained to Arnauld in their correspondence of 1686–87, a "vague Adam" who differed in any respect would not be our Adam at all. Individuals are world-bound. A Booker who accepted the baptism would, for Leibniz, be a different substance, and could no more incur Booker's guilt than Booker could incur his. The game's ethics require rejecting Leibnizian world-boundedness.

Voltaire's *Candide* (1759) mocked Leibniz's optimism by subjecting its Panglossian disciple to every catastrophe of the age, and closed on a famous counsel of modesty: "il faut cultiver notre jardin." *Infinite*'s post-credits coda belongs to the same genre of ending. After the multiverse has been searched and judged, the camera returns to a small room in which a man attends to a single child. The cosmos is left to its theodicists; the garden is a nursery.

5.3

Initial Baptism: Kripke and the Necessity of Origin

Saul Kripke's lectures *Naming and Necessity* (delivered 1970; published 1972, expanded 1980) overturned the descriptivist theory of names. A proper name, Kripke argued, is a rigid designator: it refers to the same individual in every possible world in which that individual exists, regardless of the descriptions the individual satisfies there. Reference is fixed not by description but by an *initial baptism*, Kripke's own term, in which an object is named by ostension or by a reference-fixing description, after which the name passes from speaker to speaker along a causal-historical chain. To this semantics Kripke added a metaphysical thesis, the necessity of origin: an individual could not have come from a different origin than the one it in fact came from. His example was the Queen, Elizabeth II. Could this very woman have been born of different parents, from a different sperm and egg? Kripke answered that she could not. She might have lived a wholly different life; the Trumans might even have had a daughter who became Queen of England and resembled her in every respect; but that daughter would not be this woman, for "anything coming from a different origin would not be this object" (Kripke 1980, 113). *Infinite* stages the counterfactual from the other side. Comstock raises Booker's daughter as his own and dresses her origin in a seven-day nativity, but the fiction of another parentage cannot make her another woman: the finger left behind in 1893 is the token of an origin that Columbia's scripture cannot rewrite.

The game's metaphysics is Kripkean in both respects. *Comstock* is a name fixed to a man by a literal initial baptism in a river. *Elizabeth* and *Anna* are two names for one origin: the child of Booker DeWitt and his late wife. The names are variables, contingent on baptisms and transactions; the origin is the constant. Lady Comstock's shade knows this when she recognizes that the girl is not her daughter. And it is a philosophical accident worth savoring that Kripke's paradigm case for the necessity of origin bears the name Elizabeth.

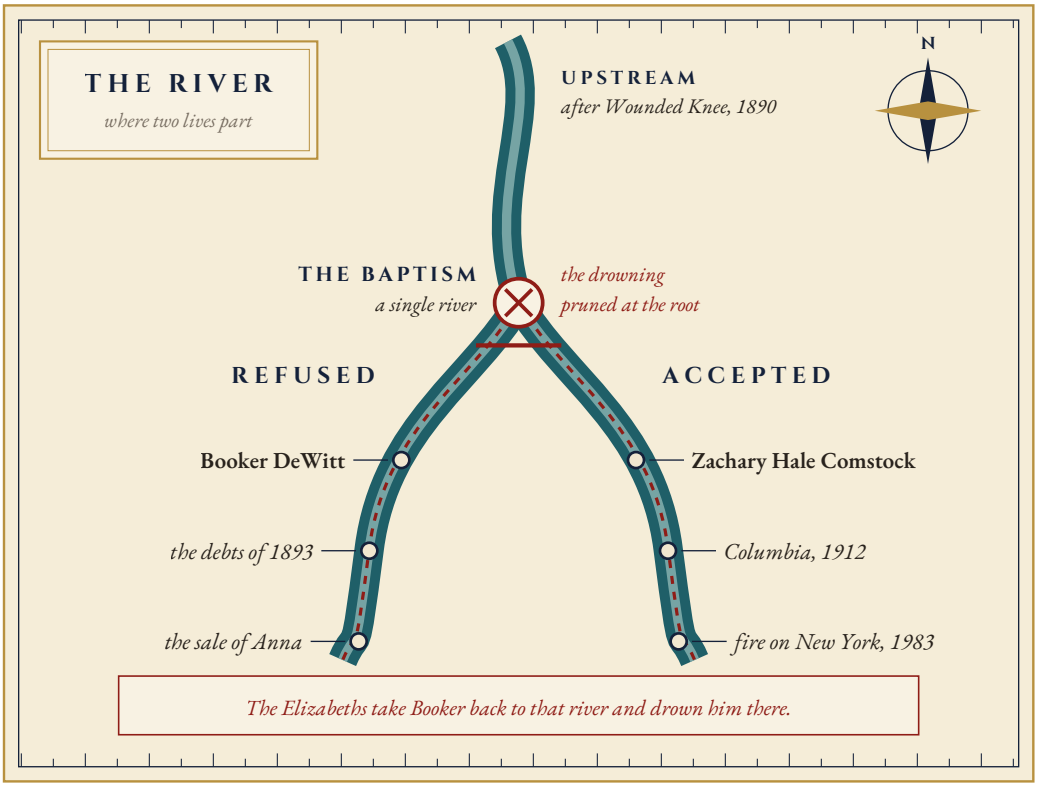
The ending is a de-dubbing. The Elizabeths take the bearer back to the moment of the initial baptism and drown him there, so that the name *Comstock* is never fixed to anyone in any world. But because the bearer's origin is necessary and shared with Booker, the only way to prevent the dubbing is to terminate the bearer at that point, and the bearer at that point is Booker. Under Kripkean essentialism one cannot excise a contingent name without killing its necessary bearer. The finale is at once the fulfillment and the reductio of Kripke: it takes the theory seriously enough to make it lethal.

5.4

Counterparts and Fission: Lewis and Parfit at the Font

David Lewis offered the principal alternative. In "Counterpart Theory and Quantified Modal Logic" (1968) and *On the Plurality of Worlds* (1986), he held that all possible worlds are as real as ours, but that individuals are world-bound: a modal claim about Booker is a claim about Booker's *counterparts*, individuals in other worlds who resemble him sufficiently in the relevant respects. Under counterpart theory Booker is not Comstock; he has a counterpart who is Comstock. To punish Booker for Comstock's crimes is to punish a man for the deeds of someone who resembles him. The game's justice requires identity, not counterparthood. It is anti-Lewisian.

FIGURE 8



The River. *A single baptism, accepted or refused, divides Booker from Comstock; the ending returns to the fork and drowns the man before it (sections 5.3–5.4).*

Derek Parfit's *Reasons and Persons* (1984) supplies a third framework, built around fission. Imagine a person who divides into two, each psychologically continuous with the ori-

ginal. Parfit argued that identity is not what matters in survival; what matters is psychological connectedness and continuity, which he called Relation R, and which can hold one-to-many. Booker and Comstock are the products of such a fission, branching from the man at the river. Parfit would say that the original survives in both, and, since he held that desert weakens as psychological connectedness weakens, that the pre-baptismal man bears diminishing responsibility for what either descendant does decades later. Lewis's own "Survival and Identity" (1976) addressed the same cases.

The game rejects both. It kills the pre-fission stage in order that one fission-product shall never exist: a pre-emptive veto on fission, enforced against the root. It insists that identity is exactly what matters, that origin is destiny, and that the river is the root of the tree. Between Kripke on one side and Lewis and Parfit on the other, *Infinite* chooses Kripke, and it chooses him for moral rather than semantic reasons: only an identity fixed by origin can carry a debt across worlds.

An older text had already posed the question with greater economy. Zhuangzi dreamt that he was a butterfly, fluttering contentedly, and on waking could not tell whether he was a man who had dreamt of being a butterfly or a butterfly now dreaming that it was a man. Yet the passage insists that between the two there must be a distinction, and names the passage between them *wuhua*, the transformation of things, which Herbert Giles's translation of 1889 rendered as "metempsychosis." The river in *Infinite* is a site of *wuhua*: one man passes into another there. The game's ethics depends on denying that the passage changes who is liable.

5.5

Moral Luck and Counterfactual Culpability

Bernard Williams (1976) and Thomas Nagel (1979) named the problem of moral luck: we are judged for what we do, yet what we do depends on factors beyond our control. Nagel distinguished resultant luck, circumstantial luck, and constitutive luck, and illustrated circumstantial luck with a man who might have behaved abominably as an officer in a concentration camp had he not left Germany for business in Argentina in 1930. Ordinary morality does not blame him for what he would have done.

Michael J. Zimmerman (2002) pressed the opposite conclusion. If culpability should not depend on luck, then those who would have done wrong in other circumstances are as culpable as those who did. Zimmerman's view is usually regarded as a revisionary curiosity. *Infinite* is a fiction of it, with a decisive twist that removes its air of paradox: in a multiverse the counterfactual is actual. The Booker who would have accepted the baptism and built Columbia exists; he did accept it, and he did build it. Modal debt is counterfactual culpab-

ility made real. The ending's verdict is that Booker is liable for Comstock because Comstock is what Booker does in the world next door.

The theological lineage of this view is older than the moral-luck debate and closer to the game than it first appears. In his *Concordia* of 1588 the Jesuit Luis de Molina attributed to God a *scientia media*, a "middle knowledge" of what every possible creature would freely do in every possible circumstance, so that providence extends over counterfactuals as well as facts. The book, printed at Lisbon and revised at Antwerp in 1595, set Jesuits against Dominicans so bitterly that Clement VIII established a commission, the *Congregatio de Auxiliis*, whose examination of it ran for a decade, through eighty-five hearings and forty-seven debates. Mark B. Anderson (2021) has developed Zimmerman's counterfactual account of responsibility in explicitly Molinist terms and proposed it as a model of original sin, and his monograph (2026) argues that the account requires counterfactuals of creaturely freedom and a haecceity view of personal identity. Elizabeth among the lighthouses possesses Molina's middle knowledge—she sees what Booker would do behind every door—and exercises it as judgment. The game thus arrives, by way of a commercial shooter, at a position that philosophy of religion has recently reached by argument, and it adds what the theory lacks: a rite.

It also exposes a fork in the theory's metaphysics. Anderson's account locates the culpable self in a haecceity, a bare thisness that persists across circumstances; the game, as section 5.3 argued, locates it in origin. The river is where the two diverge: a haecceity would survive the change of name, but an origin can only be drowned.

5.6

The Logic of the Crib: Paradox, Self-Consistency, and the Cantorian Objection

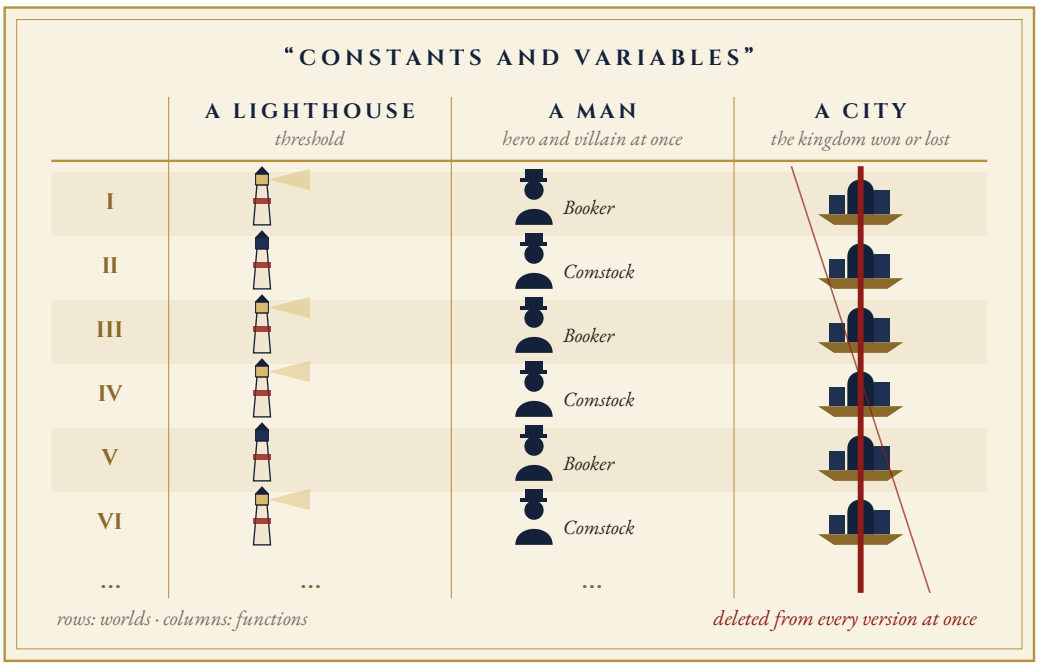
The operative maxim of the finale is the old infanticidal axiom of time-travel ethics: to prevent a tyrant, smother the child in the crib. Its logic is notoriously unstable. The grandfather paradox asks what happens to the agent whose intervention removes the conditions of his own existence. The Novikov self-consistency principle, formalized by Friedman and colleagues (1990), answers that only self-consistent histories occur. Robert A. Heinlein's "—All You Zombies—" (1959) took the paradox to its limit with a protagonist who is his own mother and father, wearing a ring in the shape of the serpent that eats its tail.

The Elizabeths exist only because Booker exists, sold Anna, and failed to recover her. Drowning him would seem to annihilate the drowners. Three escapes are available. The first places Elizabeth's post-Siphon existence outside time, in something like the eternal present that Boethius ascribed to God, who sees all moments at once as a single now (*Consolation of Philosophy* V.6); her act would then not lie within the causal chain it severs. The

second is strictly Everettian: the drowning creates one more branch and leaves the Comstock branches intact, in which case nothing is annulled and the ending fails. Edge's review raised essentially this objection at release, finding the ending's finality inconsistent with the universe the game had built. The third is the game's own. The drowning is enforced as a new constant across every baptismal world by a convocation of Elizabeths, a collective that functions as a quasi-divine universal quantifier: *in all worlds in which the river exists, the man is drowned*.

That quantifier invites a final, mathematical objection. Georg Cantor proved in 1874, and more elegantly by the diagonal argument of 1891, that there are infinities of different sizes, and he associated the Absolute Infinite, which exceeds every determinate magnitude, with God. If the branches of the game's multiverse are uncountably many, can a gathering of Elizabeths reach each one? David Hilbert's parable of the infinite hotel, introduced in lectures of the 1920s and popularized by George Gamow (1947), shows that an infinite house of doors always has room for one more guest; so too, it seems, for one more Booker. The game's answer is not mathematical but theological. Elizabeth's omnipresence is a quantifier that ranges over all without counting, a Cantorian Absolute rather than a transfinite number. The ending is coherent only as theology. As physics or as set theory it is a prayer.

FIGURE 9



The Sea of Doors as a Proppian Table. *Rows are worlds and columns are functions; the ending deletes one function from every version at once (section 5.7).*

5.7

Propp's Constants and Lévi-Strauss's Versions

"Constants and variables" is not only the game's physics; it is the vocabulary of structural narratology. Vladimir Propp's *Morphology of the Folktale* (1928) argued that in the Russian wonder tale the functions of the dramatis personae—interdiction, violation, villainy, departure, struggle, rescue—are the constant elements, while the names and attributes of the characters who perform them are variable. The Sea of Doors is a Proppian table. Its rows are worlds, its columns are functions, and in every row there is a lighthouse (threshold), a man (hero and villain at once), and a city (the kingdom to be won or lost).

Claude Lévi-Strauss, in "The Structural Study of Myth" (1955), proposed that a myth consists of all its versions, and that its meaning lies in the relations among them rather than in any single telling. The multiverse is the totality of the Booker myth's versions, and Elizabeth, surveying them from the lighthouses, is the structural analyst who isolates the invariant. But she does what no analyst can: she performs an operation on the whole corpus, deleting a function from every version at once. The ending is structuralism converted from a method into a cosmology and then into an act.

Northrop Frye's *Anatomy of Criticism* (1957) identified the "point of epiphany," where the apocalyptic world above and the cyclical world of nature meet, and named its most common settings: the mountain-top, the island, the tower, the lighthouse, and the ladder or staircase. The same point, he added, is the top of the wheel of fortune from which the tragic hero falls; its ironic form in the Bible is the Tower of Babel; and modern literature often reverses it ironically, as in the central image of Virginia Woolf's *To the Lighthouse*. Mircea Eliade's *The Sacred and the Profane* (1957) described the *axis mundi*, the pillar that joins underworld, earth, and heaven. The lighthouse in *Infinite* is both. It stands on the sea that covers Rapture and points to the sky that holds Columbia, the threshold between the drowned city and the floating one, and the Sea of Doors multiplies it into a forest of world-axes.

5.8

The Lutece Androgyne

Rosalind and Robert Lutece present themselves as twins. They are in fact counterparts of different sex from adjacent worlds, one person divided by the multiverse and rejoined by physics. Their relation has an ancient model. In Plato's *Symposium* (189c–193d), Aristophanes tells how the first human beings were doubled creatures—male, female, and androgynous—until Zeus split them, so that each half now longs for its other. The andro-

gynous kind, he says, are those who seek the opposite sex. The Luteces are the Aristophanic androgyne reunited across worlds; their so-called death, when Comstock's sabotage scatters them across time, is less an ending than an apotheosis into the condition of the reunited whole, existing everywhere and nowhere.

Their manner of speech belongs to a second myth. Each completes the other's sentences, and their dialogue proceeds by stichomythic echo. In Ovid's *Metamorphoses* (III), Echo can only repeat the last words of others, and Narcissus loves his own reflection. The Luteces are Echo and Narcissus in a single couple: a self that speaks to itself in another voice and loves its image in another body.

Shakespeare supplies the third model. The heroine of *As You Like It* is Rosalind, who disguises herself as a young man, Ganymede, and is thus both woman and man within the play. The same play contains the most famous description of the world as theater: "All the world's a stage, / And all the men and women merely players" (II.vii). The Luteces are the stage-managers of a world whose men and women are players, and the pun on *player* is the game's own. *Twelfth Night*, with its opposite-sex twins mistaken for one another, completes the Shakespearean frame.

Tom Stoppard's *Rosencrantz and Guildenstern Are Dead*, already invoked for its ninety-two heads, adds the final inversion. Stoppard's pair are minor characters who suspect that their lives are scripted by an unseen author. The Luteces are the scriptwriters, minor characters who have become the authors of the plot that contains them.

Their name, finally, is a city. *Lutèce*, Latin *Lutetia*, is the ancient name of Paris. Elizabeth's longing throughout the game is to reach Paris, and the first tear she opens in her tower shows a Paris street whose cinema advertises *Revenge of the Jedi*, the working title of a film of 1983, the year to which an aged Elizabeth will later draw Booker to watch Columbia bombard New York. Paris is the name of elsewhere. To desire Paris is to desire the Luteces' condition: existence across worlds, freedom from any single history. Elizabeth attains it, and it kills her father.



VI

CHAPTER SIX

THE CAPTIVE DAUGHTER

Myth, Gender, and the Body of the Lamb

"I am half sick of shadows," said
The Lady of Shalott."

Alfred Tennyson, "The Lady of Shalott" (1842)

"Alas, my daughter! thou hast brought me very low."

Judges 11:35

ELIZABETH ENTERS THE GAME as one of the oldest figures in the Western imagination: a daughter confined in a tower by a father who fears what she will become. She leaves it as something the tradition has rarely permitted that figure to be, the agent who decides the fate of the father and of the world. This chapter reads her through the mythic archive of captive daughters and sacrificed children, and argues that the game inverts the archive's central transaction. The tradition is full of fathers who give daughters to discharge debts and vows. *Infinite* ends with a daughter who discharges a father.

6.1

The Tower of Prophecy: Danaë, Segismundo, Rapunzel

ACRISIUS OF ARGOS, WARNED by an oracle that his daughter's son would kill him, confined Danaë in a chamber of bronze. Zeus entered as a shower of gold; Perseus was born; mother and child were set adrift at sea in a chest; and years later Perseus killed Acrisius by accident with an errant discus. The myth establishes the structure that Columbia repeats: a patriarch imprisons a daughter to forestall a prophecy, and the imprisonment becomes the mechanism of its fulfillment.

Pedro Calderón de la Barca's *La vida es sueño* (1635) gives the structure its philosophical form. King Basilio, an astrologer, reads in the stars that his son Segismundo will be a tyrant, and raises him chained in a tower. Released as an experiment, Segismundo behaves with the violence the prophecy foretold, the violence his captivity bred; returned to the tower, he is told that his freedom was a dream, and in the end he chooses virtue under the permanent uncertainty that life itself may be one. His first soliloquy asks the heavens what crime he committed against them by being born, and concludes that he understands: the greatest crime of man is to have been born. Comstock's treatment of Elizabeth follows Basilio's logic. In Comstock House she is strapped into an apparatus and, on his orders, subjected by his staff to painful reconditioning meant to break her will, which the game stages as torture. The apparatus meant to make her a worthy heir manufactures the future Booker glimpses, in which a broken Elizabeth rains fire on New York. The prophecy is self-fulfilling because the tower is.

The fairy tale that supplies the closest prototype is "Rapunzel," collected by the Grimms in 1812 from a French literary tale, Charlotte-Rose de la Force's *Persinette* (1698). A man steals rampion from a sorceress's garden to satisfy his pregnant wife's craving; caught, he must surrender the child as payment. The girl is raised in a tower without stair or door, reached only by her hair; a prince climbs to her; the sorceress casts him down, and he wanders blind until he finds her again. Every element of the transaction recurs in *Infin-*

ite: a father's transgression, a debt paid with a daughter, a tower without exit, a rescuer who arrives from below, and a reunion that costs the rescuer his sight, or in Booker's case his life.

6.2

The Lady of Shalott and the Tear as Mirror

Tennyson's Lady of Shalott (1832; revised 1842) lives in a tower on an island near Camelot, weaving the world she sees reflected in a mirror; a curse will fall if she looks at Camelot directly. Half sick of shadows, she looks at last when Lancelot rides by; the mirror cracks; she leaves the tower, writes her name on a boat, and floats down the river toward Camelot, dying as she arrives.

Elizabeth, too, sees the world only by reflection, through tears that show Paris without admitting her to it. Her departure from the tower begins a passage that ends in her dissolution, and it is bracketed by boats and rivers: the boat that brings Booker to the lighthouse, and the river where she will perform the final rite. Shalott's mirror and Elizabeth's tear are the same device: a window that is also a prison, a vision of the world that substitutes for the world.

Plato's allegory of the cave (*Republic* 514a–520a) lies behind both. Elizabeth has been educated by books in her tower; she has read physics and learned to pick locks; she has never seen the sun on open water. Her first afternoon of freedom, at the beach of Battleship Bay, where she dances among the bathers, is the prisoner's ascent rendered as joy. Luce Irigaray's reading of the cave in *Speculum of the Other Woman* (1974), under the title "Plato's Hystera," treats the cavern as a figure of the womb from which philosophy imagines its second birth. Elizabeth's tower is a hystera in this sense, a womb built by a father, and her emergence is a second birth that he did not authorize.

6.3

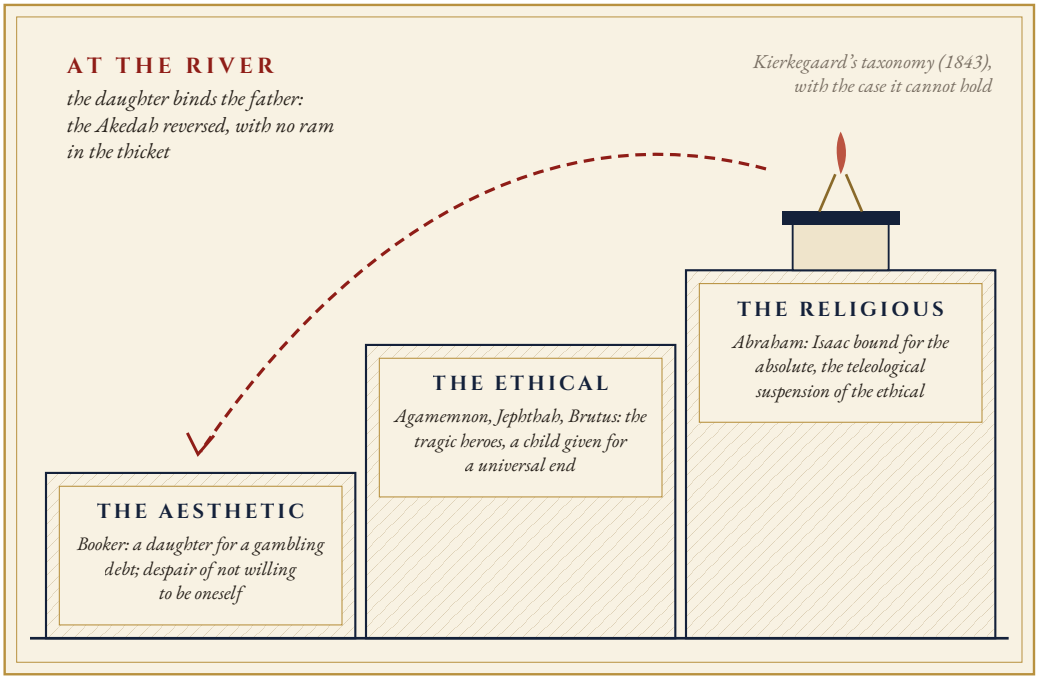
Jephthah, Iphigenia, Isaac: Kierkegaard's Taxonomy of Sacrificed Children

In Judges 11, Jephthah vows that if the Lord grants him victory over the Ammonites, he will offer up whatever first comes out of his house to meet him. It is his only daughter, coming out with timbrels and dances. "Alas, my daughter!" he cries, "thou hast brought me very low." She asks only two months to go upon the mountains and bewail her virginity with her companions, and afterward he does "according to his vow." The daughters of Israel went yearly, the text records, to lament her four days in the year. A father's vow, a debt contracted in triumph, is paid with a daughter's life.

Euripides' *Iphigenia at Aulis* gives the Greek form. Agamemnon summons his daughter to the becalmed fleet on the pretext of marriage to Achilles, intending to sacrifice her to Artemis so that the winds will carry the army to Troy. In the transmitted ending the goddess substitutes a deer at the altar.

Søren Kierkegaard's *Fear and Trembling* (1843) built a taxonomy from these cases. In Problema I, Agamemnon, Jephthah, and Brutus are "tragic heroes": each sacrifices a child for a universal end—the nation, the vow before the people, the law—and therefore remains within the ethical, where his anguish can be understood and mourned. Abraham is different. He sacrifices Isaac for no universal end but for his private relation to God, in what Kierkegaard calls a teleological suspension of the ethical, and so cannot explain himself to anyone.

FIGURE 10



Kierkegaard's Taxonomy, Extended. *The tragic heroes, Abraham, and Booker's sale set on the three stages; at the river the Akedah runs in reverse (section 6.3).*

Booker's sale of Anna fits neither category. He surrendered his daughter neither for the universal nor for the absolute but for a gambling debt. In the terms of *Either/Or* (1843) his act belongs to the aesthetic stage, the life of immediate gratification and its despair; in the terms of *The Sickness unto Death* (1849) it expresses the despair of not willing to be oneself, which in Booker takes the form of drink, cynicism, and flight. Comstock embodies the complementary despair, defiantly willing to be a self of his own making, a self that answers

to no one because it has named itself God's prophet. Kierkegaard's two forms of despair divide between the two men like the branches of the river.

The final scene reverses the Akedah. In Genesis 22 the father binds the son; at the river the daughter binds the father. Jewish tradition had already taken a step in this direction. Midrashic interpretation, preserved in collections such as *Genesis Rabbah*, made Isaac a grown man who consented to the binding, and even asked to be bound tightly so that he would not flinch. Booker plays this consenting Isaac, and the Elizabeths play Abraham's knife. But no ram appears in the thicket. Catabaptism is the Akedah without substitution.

Jacques Derrida's *The Gift of Death* (1992), a reading of *Fear and Trembling*, argues that Abraham's responsibility is absolute precisely because it is secret and incommunicable, and condenses the point in the formula *tout autre est tout autre*, every other is wholly other. Elizabeth, at the river, has the knowledge that Booker lacks until the last moment, and her act, like Abraham's, cannot be justified in the language of the community. It is justified only within the singular relation between this daughter and this father, and between both and the totality of worlds they alone can see.

6.4

Ariadne's Thread and Apotheosis

Ariadne, daughter of Minos, gave Theseus the thread that led him through the labyrinth to the Minotaur, her half-brother, whom he killed; she fled with Theseus and was abandoned by him on Naxos, where Dionysus found her and made her his bride, setting her crown among the stars as the Corona Borealis.

Elizabeth guides Booker through Columbia's labyrinth with her own thread, the tears through which she leads him from world to world. She helps him destroy the monstrous guardian who was her only companion in captivity: Songbird, a creature that was both her jailer and, in its terrible way, her kin. Levine has said that Elizabeth's relationship with Songbird drew on a friend's experience of an abusive relationship, and in the demonstration Irrational showed in 2011, Elizabeth placed Booker's hands at her throat and made him promise not to let the creature take her back. The plea anticipates the ending in reverse: the daughter who once asked for death rather than the tower finally gives her father death so that there will be no tower. Then comes her apotheosis, when the Siphon falls and she becomes a being of the starry vault, among the lighthouses. And then the abandonment, inverted: it is not the hero who leaves the heroine on the island, but the heroine who leaves the hero in the river. The Luteces play Daedalus, the exiled artificers who built the labyrinth and the means of flight for a tyrant they came to regret serving; Columbia plays Icarus, the city that flew too near the sun.

6.5

The Siphon, the Gaze, and the Boundary Creature

The Siphon is the game's most direct image of patriarchal extraction: an apparatus, built into the architecture of Elizabeth's tower, that drains and suppresses her power so that she can be kept. The father's state does not merely confine the daughter; it siphons her.

Laura Mulvey's "Visual Pleasure and Narrative Cinema" (1975) named the "to-be-looked-at-ness" assigned to women by the classical camera. Booker first sees Elizabeth through one-way glass from an observation chamber; she does not see him. The tower is a panopticon inverted. Bentham's design (1791), which Michel Foucault made the emblem of disciplinary power in *Discipline and Punish* (1975), placed a single watcher at the center of many cells; Monument Island places a single prisoner at the center of many watchers. The game's own regime of looking is not innocent of what it depicts. Elizabeth's design, corseted and décolleté, has been read by critics as conceding to the gaze that the narrative elsewhere indicts, and the work never quite resolves the contradiction.

Donna Haraway's "Cyborg Manifesto" (1985) proposed the cyborg as a creature of boundaries, a being without an origin story in the Western sense, which would not recognize the Garden of Eden and could not dream of returning to dust. Elizabeth is such a boundary creature conscripted into an Edenic plot. Her body is divided across worlds: the tip of her smallest finger, severed by the closing tear, remains in the world of her birth, and this division is the source of her power. She covers the wound with a thimble, a domestic prosthesis that marks the site of her doubleness. Columbia calls itself a New Eden, and it needs her as its Eve and its Lamb; but she belongs, structurally, to no single world, and the end of the game is the end of her captivity in origin.

Aristotle's *Poetics* (ch. 16) catalogues the forms of recognition, the least artful of which proceeds by tokens: scars, necklaces, marks on the body, as when Odysseus is recognized by his scar. Oedipus is identified by his pierced feet. *Infinite* stakes its anagnorisis on two bodily tokens. The father's hand bears the initials of the child he sold; the daughter's hand lacks the finger that the sale cost her. The tokens meet at the river, where the man with the marked hand is drowned by the woman with the missing finger.

6.6

Omelas in the Air

Ursula K. Le Guin's "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas" (1973) describes a city of radiant happiness whose joy depends upon a single child kept in filth and darkness

in a basement room. Every citizen learns of the child; most, after anguish, accept the bargain; a few walk away from Omelas and do not return.

Le Guin credited her source. It is a passage in William James's "The Moral Philosopher and the Moral Life" (1891), which imagines a world in which the utopias of Fourier, Bellamy, and Morris should all be outdone, and "millions kept permanently happy on the one simple condition that a certain lost soul on the far-off edge of things should lead a life of lonely torture." James asked what, except a specifically moral emotion, could make us feel at once how hideous the enjoyment of such happiness would be. The same philosopher who supplied the ethics of Omelas in 1891 coined the word *multiverse* in 1895 and described the twice-born soul in 1902. James is the unacknowledged constant of *Infinite*, the philosopher whose three American texts of the 1890s contain the game's ethics, its cosmology, and its psychology of conversion.

Le Guin made the debt explicit in the story's subtitle, "Variations on a Theme by William James," and in her headnote she named the tale's central idea the scapegoat, acknowledging that she had first met it in Dostoevsky and forgotten it. The Dostoevskian source sharpens the game's vocabulary to a point. In *The Brothers Karamazov* (1879–80), Ivan refuses any final harmony purchased with a child's suffering—it is, in Constance Garnett's translation, "not worth the tears of that one tortured child"—and announces that he returns his ticket. Columbia's harmony is purchased with a child's tears in both senses: the girl's suffering and the rifts her divided body opens. Ivan returns his ticket to the world; Elizabeth returns the world's.

Columbia is Omelas in the air. Its future rests on the child in the tower, the purchased Seed who will inherit the throne, and its present prosperity rests on the underclass of Shantytown and the bodies in Finkton's machines. Le Guin offered two responses: to stay, accepting the bargain, or to walk away, refusing it without undoing it. *Infinite* invents a third: to drown the founder so that the city never was. The ones who walk away leave the child in the basement; the ones who drown the founder free the child by unmaking the city and the child's own possibility together. Le Guin's story forbids this solution by its form, since Omelas has no founder whose unbirth would dissolve it. The bargain is structural. Columbia, by contrast, is given a founder, and that gift is the condition of the game's solution and, as Chapter Nine argues, the source of its evasion.

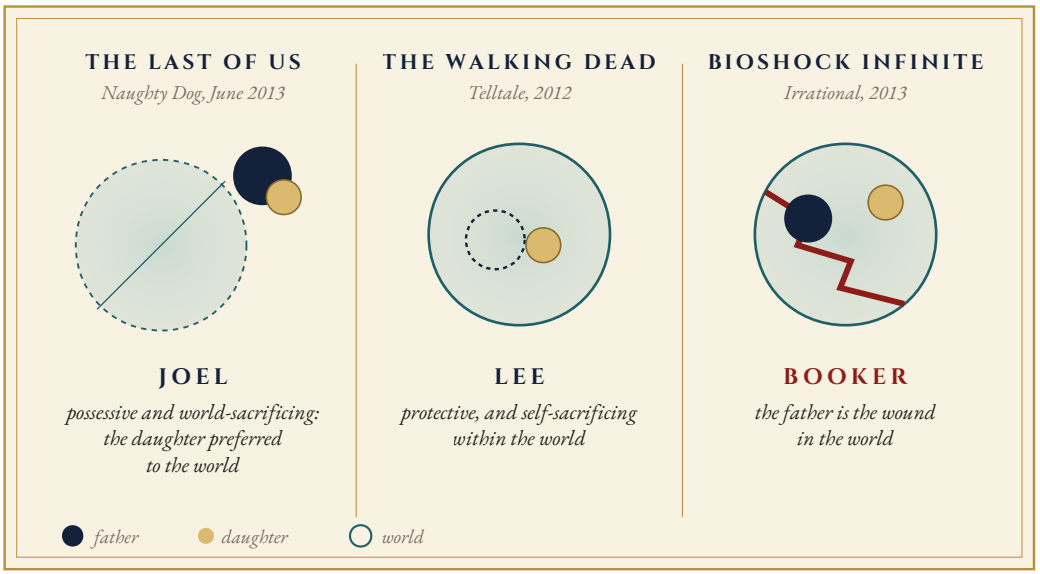
6.7

The Paternal Turn of 2013

Infinite appeared within months of Naughty Dog's *The Last of Us* (June 2013) and a year after Telltale's *The Walking Dead* (2012), and critics of the period spoke of a "dadification" of the medium: a turn toward narratives in which a male player-character protects a girl.

The first scholarly collection on the series devotes a part to the theme, with essays on "post-feminist fatherhood" and on the series as an "infinite parent" (Parker and Aldred 2018). The three works articulate three answers to the same question.

FIGURE 11



Three Fathers, 2012–2013. *The paternal turn in three works: the daughter preferred to the world, the father spent within it, and the father as the world's wound (section 6.7).*

In *The Last of Us*, Joel saves Ellie by destroying the possibility of a vaccine that would have required her death, and then lies to her about it. Paternal love is possessive and world-sacrificing: the daughter is preferred to the world. In *The Walking Dead*, Lee Everett guards Clementine, teaches her to survive, and dies, leaving her the skills he could not use for himself. Paternal love is protective and self-sacrificing within the world. In *Infinite*, the father is the wound in the world. He sold the daughter; in another branch he imprisoned her; he must be unmade by her so that neither branch can occur. Paternal love is not asserted or sacrificed but atoned, and the daughter is the executor of the atonement.

Of the three, only *Infinite* makes paternity itself the sin. Its predecessors in the series had approached the theme. In *BioShock 2* (2010) the player is Subject Delta, a Big Daddy bonded to Eleanor Lamb, whose mother has engineered her as the vessel of a collectivist utopia; the father protects, and the daughter may, at the end, choose mercy. *Infinite* removes the protective alibi. Its father is the reason the daughter needs protection, and its daughter must choose not mercy but judgment.

6.8

Beatrice Inverted: Dante at the Lighthouses

Dante's *Commedia* supplies the last and highest model for Elizabeth's office. Ferried across the river at the threshold of the dead by Charon (*Inferno* III), led through Hell and Purgatory by Virgil, Dante is guided through the heavenly spheres by Beatrice, whose gaze lifts him from sphere to sphere until he can look into the eternal light himself. At the summit of the vision he sees, in Longfellow's translation (1867), "Bound up with love together in one volume, / What through the universe in leaves is scattered" (*Paradiso* 33.86–87), and the poem ends on "The Love which moves the sun and the other stars" (33.145).

Infinite follows the Dantean itinerary and inverts it at each station. Booker, too, is ferried across water at the threshold of another world, by two pale rowers. Elizabeth, too, leads him upward through the strata of a heavenly city and then beyond it, until he can see what she sees. And what they see among the lighthouses is precisely the scattered leaves of the universe, every world a page, bound into one volume by one structure. But the binding force is not love; it is the constant, the decree, the debt. The vision ends not in a light that moves the stars but in a river that unmakes a man. Beatrice brings her poet to the source of being; Elizabeth brings her father to the source of his possibility, and closes it. The *Commedia* is the great poem of a soul saved by a woman's guidance; *Infinite* rewrites it as the salvation of every world by a woman's judgment upon the soul she guides.



VII

CHAPTER SEVEN

FORKING PATHS AND FLOATING CITIES

Infinite *in the Speculative Archive*

"For thou hast said in thine heart, I will ascend into heaven, I will exalt my throne above the stars of God ... Yet thou shalt be brought down to hell, to the sides of the pit."

Isaiah 14:13–15

Infinite belongs to an archive that is older than its medium: floating cities that threaten the earth, sunken cities that mirror them, gardens of forking paths, investigators who discover that they are the culprits, and songs that arrive before they are written. This chapter assembles that archive constellationally. Its purpose is not to establish influence but to show that the game's constants recur across a long history of speculative imagination, and that the game's particular variables—American, theological, paternal—are what make it new.

7.1

Laputa, Propeller Island, and the War in the Air

The third voyage of Jonathan Swift's *Gulliver's Travels* (1726) introduced the flying island of Laputa, moved by a giant lodestone and inhabited by mathematicians and musicians so lost in speculation that servants must strike them with bladders to recall them to conversation. The island governs the continent of Balnibarbi below by aerial terror. A rebellious town may be deprived of sun and rain by the island hovering above it, pelted with stones, or, in extremity, crushed by the island's descent. Laputa is the first floating city whose sovereignty consists in the threat to fall on the earth, and its projectors in the Academy of Lagado, who extract sunbeams from cucumbers, are the Luteces' satirical ancestors. Swift also wrote an episode in which the town of Lindalino, oppressed by the island's exactions, raises a tower at each of its four corners and crowns each with a lodestone, so that the descending island is dragged violently toward the town and the king must grant its conditions. Lindalino is Dublin, and the episode allegorizes the Irish revolt against Wood's halfpence, a coinage imposed on Ireland from London: the first floating city of English fiction is humbled by a town that refuses an imposed currency, a debt-economy resisted from below. The passage was so politically pointed that both Motte's first edition of 1726 and Faulkner's of 1735 omitted it, and it was first printed in 1899. Laputa's overthrow was censored; Columbia's is the game's climax.

Jules Verne returned to the floating city twice. *Robur le Conquérant* (1886) gave the world the airship *Albatross* and its master's contempt for the earthbound. *L'Île à hélice* (1895), published two years after the Chicago Exposition, imagined Standard Island, a propeller-driven artificial island whose capital, Milliard City, carries some ten thousand American millionaires across the Pacific; the story is told by a French string quartet hired to play for them. The island is divided between two rival dynasties, and the division is confessional as well as commercial: the Protestant Jem Tankerdon leads the larboard half, the Catholic Nat Coverley the starboard. Their quarrel ends with each faction turning its propellers in opposite directions, and the island breaks apart under the strain and sinks. A floating city of American plutocrats, split along a sectarian line and destroyed by the split, is Columbia's most exact nineteenth-century precursor.

H. G. Wells supplied the bombardment. In *The War in the Air* (1908), a German air fleet attacks New York and the world's financial and political order collapses under aerial war. Four years before the game's present, then, fiction had already imagined the prophecy of Columbia fulfilled: airships raining fire on the city Comstock calls Sodom. Wells's *The Time Machine* (1895) had earlier divided humanity vertically into the Eloi, idle and beautiful above ground, and the Morlocks, laboring in the dark below. Columbia's promenades and Finkton's furnaces reproduce the Wellsian section through class.

The archetypes beneath all of these are scriptural. At Babel the builders resolve: "let us build us a city and a tower, whose top may reach unto heaven; and let us make us a name" (Genesis 11:4). The tower's purpose is the making of a name, and Comstock's city is the monument of a man who named himself. Isaiah's taunt over the king of Babylon, the morning star who said in his heart that he would ascend into heaven and exalt his throne above the stars of God, ends in the pit. And Italo Calvino's *Invisible Cities* (1972) adds a modern emblem: Octavia, the spider-web city suspended by ropes over an abyss, whose inhabitants know that the net will last only so long.

7.2

Donnelly's Hinge

One nineteenth-century imagination contained both of the *BioShock* series' cities. Ignatius Donnelly, the Minnesota congressman who drafted the Populist preamble of 1892, published *Atlantis: The Antediluvian World* (1882), which argued that a sunken Atlantic civilization was the source of all others; *Ragnarok: The Age of Fire and Gravel* (1883), which ascribed geological history to a cometary catastrophe; *The Great Cryptogram* (1888), which claimed to find Francis Bacon's cipher in Shakespeare; and *Caesar's Column* (1890), whose plutocratic dystopia ends in revolutionary massacre and escape by airship.

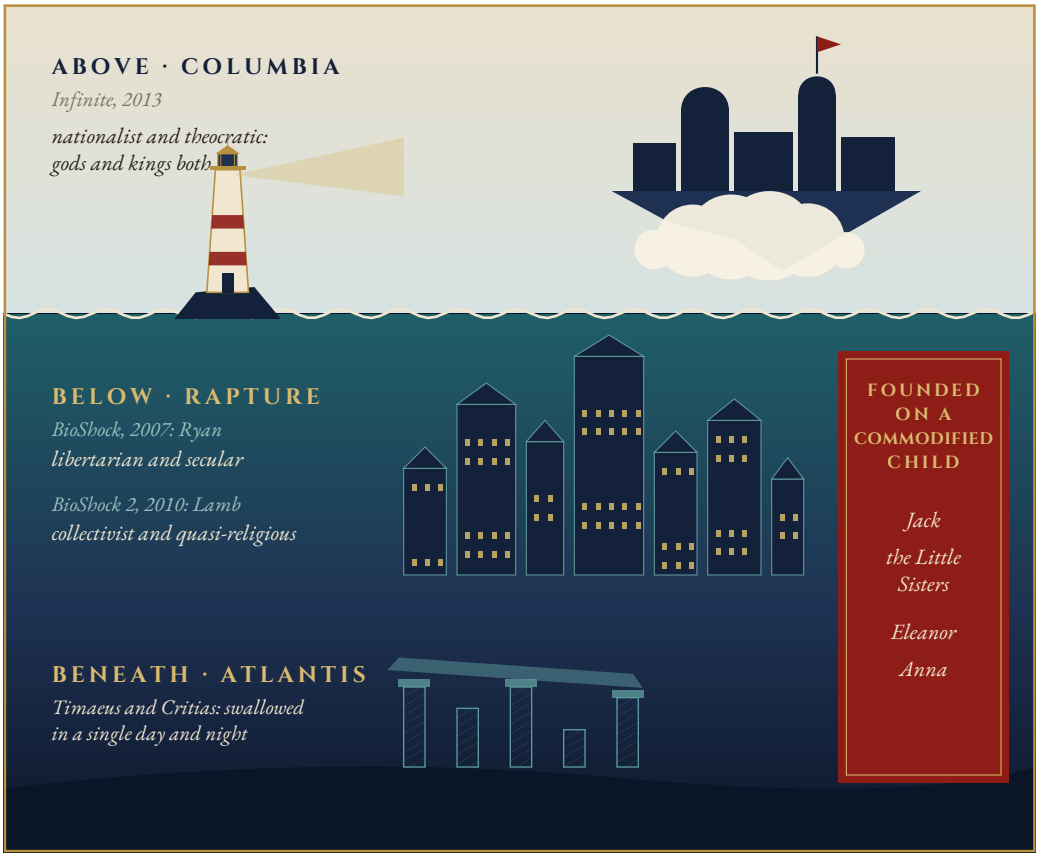
The sunken utopia and the airborne flight from revolution, the Rapture and the Columbia of the series, were thus assembled in a single Populist mind of the 1880s. No claim of influence is made here. Donnelly is a *hinge*: a figure in whom the two halves of the series' imagination are already joined, and in whom the American nineteenth century reveals that its utopias of the deep and the sky were always two faces of one anxiety. It is fitting, too, that Donnelly was the century's great over-reader, the man who found ciphers in Shakespeare. A thesis that finds Lucan names in a shooter must acknowledge its patron.

7.3

Plato's Atlantis and Rand's Rapture: The Dialectic of Utopias

Plato's Atlantis, described in the *Timaeus* (24e–25d) and the unfinished *Critias*, was a maritime empire of divine descent that grew arrogant as its divine nature thinned, and was swallowed by the sea "in a single day and night of misfortune." The myth joined utopia, hubris, and drowning at the origin of Western political fiction.

FIGURE 12



A Dialectic of Utopias. *Columbia above, Rapture below, Atlantis beneath: the series' utopias and the commodified child on which each is founded (section 7.3).*

The *BioShock* series restaged that union in three modes. *BioShock* (2007) built Rapture beneath the Atlantic as Andrew Ryan's refuge from state and church, the Galt's Gulch of Ayn Rand's *Atlas Shrugged* (1957) submerged, under the motto "No gods or kings. Only man." *BioShock 2* (2010) returned to Rapture under Sofia Lamb, a collectivist who engineered her daughter Eleanor as the vessel of a utopian "Family." *Infinite* raised the third uto-

pia into the sky: not individualist or collectivist but theocratic-nationalist, with gods and kings both. The series is a dialectic of utopias: libertarian and secular below, collectivist and quasi-religious below, nationalist and theocratic above.

Beneath the dialectic runs a constant that the lighthouse formula does not name. Every utopia in the series is founded on a commodified child. Jack, the protagonist of *BioShock*, is Andrew Ryan's son, conceived with a dancer and sold as an embryo to his father's rival. The Little Sisters are girls converted into harvesters of the substance on which Rapture runs. Eleanor Lamb is engineered by her mother as an instrument of the collective. Anna DeWitt is sold for a debt. The name "Lamb" itself migrates from the collectivist mother of *BioShock 2* to the sacrificial daughter of *Infinite*. There is always a lighthouse, a man, and a city; and there is always a child who has been sold to found the city.

7.4

Borges: Gardens, Alephs, and Hrönir

Jorge Luis Borges supplied the modern literature of the multiverse with its master images. In "The Garden of Forking Paths" (1941), the sinologist Stephen Albert explains that the labyrinth of Ts'ui Pên is a novel in which every alternative is chosen simultaneously, so that time forks perpetually toward innumerable futures. The story's plot is as pertinent as its theory. Yu Tsun, a spy for Germany, murders Albert so that newspaper reports of the crime will transmit to Berlin the name of the town, Albert, that must be bombed. A man is killed so that the name of a city may be spoken. *Infinite* inverts the device: a man is killed so that the name of a city will never be spoken.

"The Aleph" (1945) describes a point in a Buenos Aires cellar that contains all points of the universe seen from every angle at once; Elizabeth's vantage among the lighthouses is an Aleph. "The Library of Babel" (1941) describes a universe consisting of every possible book; the tower library in which Elizabeth was educated is its finite shadow. "Tlön, Uqbar, Orbis Tertius" (1940) imagines a fictional world whose idealist metaphysics begins to produce objects in ours, among them the *hrönir*, things brought into being by expectation. The turrets, medicines, and cover that Elizabeth summons through tears in combat are *hrönir*: objects produced at need from the space of possibility.

"The Secret Miracle" (1943) grants the condemned playwright Jaromir Hladík a year of subjective time, frozen in the instant before the firing squad's volley, to complete his drama in his mind. The final scene of *Infinite* occupies such an interval, the suspended moment between immersion and extinction, in which a man completes the drama of his life by recognizing it.

7.5

Recurrence and Alternate History: Dick, Vonnegut, Moorcock, King, Kelly

Philip K. Dick's *The Man in the High Castle* (1962) imagines an America partitioned after an Axis victory, in which a novel circulating underground, *The Grasshopper Lies Heavy*, describes an alternative history closer to ours, and in which characters consult the I Ching to navigate between possibilities. Dick's *Ubik* (1969) dissolves the boundary between worlds into decaying objects and contradictory messages. Columbia is an alternate America, and its tears function like Dick's novel-within-the-novel: windows onto histories that the characters slowly suspect are more real than their own.

Kurt Vonnegut's *Slaughterhouse-Five* (1969) sets its hero "unstuck in time," shuttling among the moments of his life, and introduces the Tralfamadorians, who see all moments at once and regard every event as permanently structured. Its central atrocity is the firebombing of Dresden by British and American bombers on 13–15 February 1945, which killed some twenty-five thousand people (Taylor 2004): the aerial annihilation of a city. Elizabeth after the Siphon is Tralfamadorian in perception; Columbia's prophecy is Dresden extended to New York.

Michael Moorcock, who had given the word its science-fictional sense in "The Blood Red Game" (1963), built on it the Eternal Champion sequence, which distributes a single doomed hero across innumerable incarnations—Elric, Corum, Hawkmoon, Erekosë—in a multiverse where some of them dimly remember the others. *There's always a man* is Moorcock's premise. Stephen King's *The Dark Tower* (1982–2004) brings its gunslinger at last to the Tower at the nexus of all worlds, only to return him to the desert where the saga began, with a single variable altered: he now carries the Horn of Eld. The loop with variation is the structure of the Lutece tally.

Richard Kelly's *Donnie Darko* (2001) offers the closest cinematic analogue to *Infinite*'s ending. An unstable tangent universe, which threatens to destroy the primary one, can be closed only if its protagonist accepts the death that the original timeline had assigned him; he does, laughing, in his bed, as the jet engine falls.

Three further works complete the archive of recurrence. In Alan Moore and Dave Gibbons's *Watchmen* (1986–87), Dr. Manhattan perceives all the moments of his life at once and describes himself as a puppet who can see the strings, while Adrian Veidt kills some three million people in New York with a fabricated alien attack in order to frighten the superpowers into peace: Omelas at metropolitan scale, an atrocity committed to found a utopia, which the novel declines to undo. Gene Wolfe's *The Book of the New Sun* (1980–83) follows a torturer with perfect memory who becomes the ruler of his world and the bringer of its renewal, and who discovers that the redeemer venerated in his world's past was him-

self, a savior who is his own cause. Harold Ramis's *Groundhog Day* (1993) offers the loop's gentlest resolution: its hero escapes the repeated day not by dying but by becoming good. Against these, *Infinite*'s choice is legible. It refuses Veidt's bargain, declines Ramis's reform, and repeats Wolfe's bootstrap only in its downloadable epilogue.

7.6

Possibility Mining and the Castle in the Sky: Miéville and Miyazaki

China Miéville's *The Scar* (2002) is set largely on Armada, a floating pirate city lashed together from captured ships, and turns on the Scar, a wound in reality where the probable and the possible leak into the actual. Its swordsman Uther Doul wields the Possible Sword, which realizes the possible strikes of his blade as well as the actual one, by an art the novel calls "possibility mining." No closer prior analogue exists for the tears: a technology that extracts actuality from possibility, and a city that exploits it.

Hayao Miyazaki's *Laputa: Castle in the Sky* (1986), which takes its name from Swift, centers on Sheeta, a girl whose crystal levitates and whose lineage gives her command over a deserted floating city. Muska, who claims the same royal blood, wishes to rule the world from Laputa with its ancient weapon. Sheeta and the boy Pazu speak together the spell of destruction, and the city's weapon and its lower structures fall away while its great tree carries the rest into the sky. A girl with hereditary power over a sky-city unmakes it rather than let a would-be king possess it: this is Elizabeth's choice, rendered without a drowning.

7.7

Noir Ontologies: Oedipus, Angel Heart, Shutter Island

Booker is a detective. He was a Pinkerton and is a private investigator, and the game's plot is an investigation whose solution is the investigator. The archetype is Sophocles' *Oedipus Tyrannus*, in which a king hunts the killer of his predecessor and discovers himself. The structural resemblance is exact: an infant given away by his father because of a prophecy and passed between shepherds; a recognition secured by bodily tokens, the scarred feet; a culprit who is the detective. Aristotle praised the play because its recognition coincides with its reversal (*Poetics*, ch. 11). *Infinite*'s "False Shepherd" discovers himself at the moment his fortunes reverse; the coincidence is Sophoclean.

Alan Parker's *Angel Heart* (1987), adapted from William Hjortsberg's *Falling Angel* (1978), transposed the structure into American noir. The detective Harry Angel is hired by a mysterious Louis Cyphre to find a missing crooner, Johnny Favorite, and discovers that he is Favorite, who sold his soul and tried to escape the debt by stealing another man's identity. The discovery has a further term. Epiphany Proudfoot, the young woman with whom Angel has had sex during the investigation, is his own daughter, and she is found shot dead,

the last of the killings he has been committing without knowing it. The father's debt destroys the daughter he did not know he had. A detective, a debt to the devil, a lost identity, a client who is the creditor, and a daughter destroyed by her father's debt: *Infinite* rewrites the plot with the Luteces as Cyphre and the debt payable in a daughter.

Martin Scorsese's *Shutter Island* (2010), adapted from Dennis Lehane's novel (2003), offers the most uncanny parallel. A federal marshal investigating a disappearance carries the memory of an atrocity at the liberation of Dachau, where American soldiers, he among them, shot surrendering SS guards; he discovers that he is a patient, that his wife drowned their children in a lake, and that his investigation is a fiction he constructed to avoid the truth. At the end, apparently lucid, he chooses lobotomy, framing the choice as whether it would be worse to live as a monster or to die as a good man. A war atrocity, drowned children, a constructed identity, and a final consent to self-annulment: the film appeared during *Infinite*'s development, and whether or not it was consulted, it marks the same cultural nerve. Christopher Nolan's *Memento* (2000), in which an investigator unknowingly authors the crime he pursues by manufacturing his own memories, completes the set; the game's epigraph on the mind that struggles to create memories where none exist could serve as its motto.

7.8

Excursus: The Hauntology of the Cover Song

Columbia hums with songs that have not yet been written. A barbershop quartet on a floating barge sings the Beach Boys' "God Only Knows"; a fairground arrangement of Cyndi Lauper's "Girls Just Want to Have Fun" drifts over the beach on the day Elizabeth first walks it; a woman sings Creedence Clearwater Revival's "Fortunate Son"; and period-style arrangements render "Everybody Wants to Rule the World" and "Tainted Love" (Kohler 2012). Scott Bradlee arranged four of the numbers: a piano-and-voice "Everybody Wants to Rule the World," a ragtime "Tainted Love" after Gloria Jones's original rather than Soft Cell's hit, R.E.M.'s "Shiny Happy People," and "After You've Gone," a standard of 1918 that is itself six years ahead of Columbia's calendar. The conceit outlived the game. Bradlee's Postmodern Jukebox, formed the same year, made a commercial genre of dressing contemporary pop in the styles of earlier decades: Albert Fink's trade, conducted in the open. The game supplies a diegetic author for these anachronisms: Albert Fink, the industrialist's brother, a composer who listens through tears and publishes what he hears as his own.

Walter Benjamin's "Work of Art in the Age of Its Technological Reproducibility" (1935–36) defined the aura of an artwork as its unique presence in time and space, which mechanical reproduction withers. Albert Fink's covers possess no here-and-now at all. They are copies whose originals do not yet exist, reproductions that precede their mod-

els. Jean Baudrillard (1981) called this the precession of simulacra, the condition in which the copy comes before the real it supposedly imitates; Columbia is its acoustic laboratory.

Jacques Derrida's *Specters of Marx* (1993) coined *hauntology* for the persistence of what is neither present nor absent, and Mark Fisher's *Ghosts of My Life* (2014), borrowing Franco Berardi's phrase, described twenty-first-century culture as haunted by "the slow cancellation of the future." *Infinite* inverts Fisher's diagnosis. Its past is haunted not by lost futures but by futures that have not yet arrived, and those futures are cancelled by the ending. When Columbia is unmade, Albert Fink's plagiarisms are unmade with it, and the songs return to the decades that will write them.

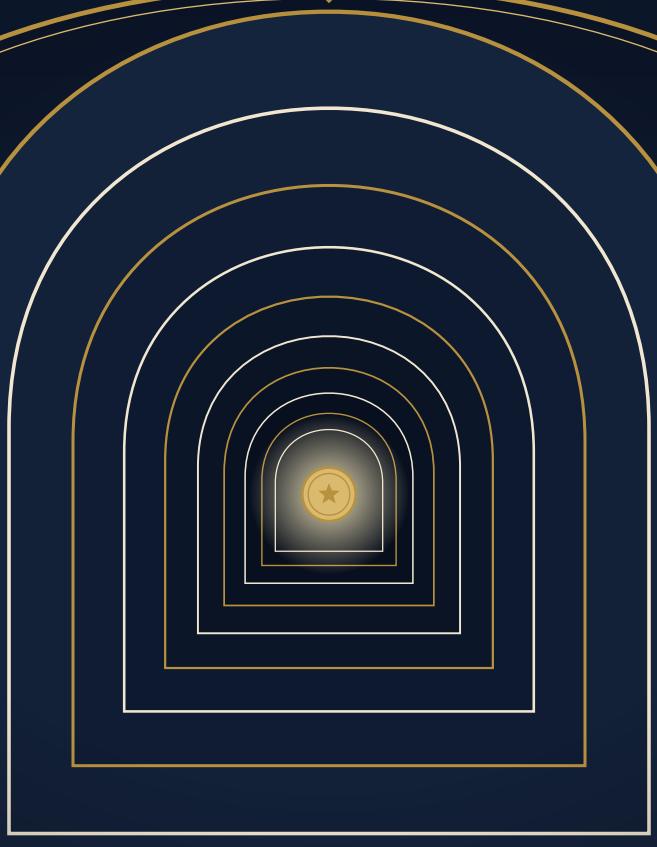
One song in Columbia is not stolen from the future. "Will the Circle Be Unbroken?", a hymn of 1907 by Ada R. Habershon and Charles H. Gabriel, is sung by Elizabeth while Booker plays guitar (a performance by Courtnee Draper and Troy Baker that won the award for best song in a game at the 2013 VGX ceremony), and its refrain asks: "Will the circle be unbroken / By and by, by and by? / Is a better home awaiting / In the sky, in the sky?" The hymn names Columbia's promise exactly, a better home awaiting in the sky, and asks the game's structural question: whether the loop can ever be broken. A second circle stands behind the hymn. In *Black Elk Speaks* (1932), the Oglala holy man, who was at Wounded Knee in its aftermath, mourns the sacred hoop of his nation, broken and scattered there, its center gone and its holy tree dead. The founding atrocity of Booker's life broke one circle; the hymn he plays asks whether another can hold. At the river the answer is enacted. A circle of Elizabeths closes around him, and then, one by one, it breaks.

7.9

After Infinite

Later works have taken up the game's constants under new variables. The German series *Dark* (2017–2020) concludes by unmaking the two knotted worlds of its plot at their common origin: its lovers prevent the accident from which both worlds descend, and cease to have existed, leaving a single world that never needed them. The ending is *Infinite*'s finale distributed between two people and stripped of baptism.

Everything Everywhere All at Once (2022) answers it. Its daughter, Joy, has acquired access to every universe at once and has concluded from that totality that nothing matters; she has built a black "everything bagel" into which she intends to vanish. Her mother, who might have chosen erasure or force, chooses instead attention and kindness in each of the worlds where they meet. The film is a counter-catabaptism: confronted with the full multiverse of a family's failures, it chooses to stay in the water together rather than to drown anyone in it.



VIII

CHAPTER EIGHT

REGENERATION THROUGH RESPAWN

Ludic Form as Theology

"A man chooses; a slave obeys."

Andrew Ryan, *BioShock* (2007)

A GAME ARGUES WITH its rules before it argues with its words. This chapter reads the mechanics of *Infinite*—its deaths and revivals, its choices, its economy of gear and Vigors, its relation to its predecessor and its downloadable sequels—as theological propositions. It contends that the game's form is the most consistent statement of its theme. The first-person shooter is a machine of regeneration through violence, and *Infinite* is the first major work in the form to make that machine the object of its own salvation history.

8.1

Ludonarrative Dissonance Revisited

CLINT HOCKING'S 2007 ESSAY on *BioShock* identified a contradiction between what the game made the player do and what it asked the player to think. The post, published on his blog *Click Nothing* on 7 October 2007, never uses its famous phrase in the body: "ludonarrative dissonance" appears only in the title, the argument sets what *BioShock* is about as a game against what it is about as a story, and the term acquired its definition in the criticism that followed. *Infinite* reproduced the contradiction on a larger scale. A narrative of extraordinary reflective ambition is delivered through a campaign of near-continuous killing, much of it intimate: the Skyhook, Booker's rail-riding tool, doubles as an instrument of grisly close-quarters execution. Critics at release judged the body count incompatible with the work's claims to moral seriousness: Polygon's Chris Plante argued that the game never rationalizes the scale and efficiency of its killing, Kotaku's Kirk Hamilton found the executions gratuitous, and Cliff Bleszinski, lead designer of the deliberately violent Gears of War, said the violence detracted from the experience. Others, among them Destructoid's James Stephanie Sterling, replied that a story about violence could not be told without it, and Levine defended violence as one of the oldest tools of storytelling.

The objection is correct, and the game has an answer that is also an alibi. Its metaphysics declares violence a constant. There is always a man, and the man is always this man: the trooper of Wounded Knee, the Pinkerton, the mercenary sent to fetch a girl. The combat is not an intrusion of genre into story but the story's premise rendered as procedure, the endless rehearsal of the disposition that the ending must annul. To that extent the dissonance is designed. But the claim that violence is constant is also the genre's oldest excuse: the player kills because that is what the form requires, and the form is then promoted to a cosmology. The game's insight and its evasion share a single sentence. The body count is a liturgy, the litany of a man who cannot stop, recited by a medium that does not wish to.

8.2

The Diegetic Respawn

When Booker dies in combat, the game does not simply reload. It shows him, briefly, in his New York office of 1893, the room in which the Luteces came for the child, with a door he must open to return. When he returns, a fee in Silver Eagles has been deducted from his purse, and the enemies he was fighting have partially recovered. When Elizabeth is at his side, she can revive him directly. Reviewers at release complained that the penalty for dying was too light, a complaint that is theological as well as ludic: in Columbia resurrection is cheap.

The design converts the genre's most artificial convention into doctrine. Death is a return to the site of the original sin, and resurrection is a transaction. The respawn costs money: each revival is charged to Booker's account like interest on a loan. Paul's maxim that "the wages of sin is death" (Romans 6:23) is inverted into an economic law of the medium: the wages of death is coin. The office door through which Booker passes to live again recalls Kafka's parable "Before the Law" (1915), in which a man waits his whole life at a door that, the doorkeeper reveals at the end, was meant only for him. Booker passes through his door every time he dies, and each time it leads him back into the same life.

Jesper Juul's *The Art of Failure* (2013) describes the paradox of failure in games: players seek out an activity that is guaranteed to make them fail repeatedly, and the repetition is the source of the pleasure. *Infinite* gives the paradox a cosmological alibi. The Luteces' tally board, covered with heads, is a counter of attempts, the visible record of a hundred iterations of this protagonist arriving at this city. The game's most demanding difficulty setting, named *1999 Mode* after the year of *System Shock 2*, Levine's earlier work, makes failure more frequent and more costly. Within the fiction and outside it, the man keeps trying, and the trying is recorded in chalk.

8.3

The Illusion of Choice as Liturgy

Infinite offers its player a handful of explicit choices. At the Raffle, Booker may throw the ball at the bound couple or at the announcer. Elizabeth asks him to choose between a bird and a cage. In the Hall of Heroes, the defeated Cornelius Slate may be spared or killed. A ticket clerk who recognizes Booker may be attacked first or allowed to strike. Robert Lutece invites him to flip a coin. In each case the choice produces, at most, a local variation, while the outcome is invariant: Booker is unmasked, the brooch is worn, Slate's fate is decided elsewhere, the fight occurs, the coin lands heads.

Janet Murray's *Hamlet on the Holodeck* (1997) defined agency as the satisfying power to take meaningful action and see its results. By that standard *Infinite*'s choices are failures, and many players received them so. Ian Bogost's concept of procedural rhetoric (2007), the persuasive force of rules, suggests a different reading. The choices are not failed agency but doctrine: they teach, through the player's own hand, the structure of the cosmos. Variables vary; constants hold. The player is invited to exercise exactly the freedom that the game's metaphysics allows, which is the freedom of the creature under the decree. The result is a Calvinist ludology, in which the experience of choosing is real and its insufficiency is the lesson.

Rowan Tulloch (2010) had already read *BioShock*'s twist as a pedagogy that trains the player's subjectivity, and reviewers of *Infinite* made the corresponding observation at release: its constants and variables describe its own playthroughs, which differ in detail and converge on one ending (Kohler 2013; Phillips 2013). Elizabeth supplies the formula when she says that we swim in different oceans but land on the same shore. The choices are a catechism, and the ending is its creed.

Miguel Sicart's *The Ethics of Computer Games* (2009) argues that players are ethical agents who bring values to the systems they inhabit. *Infinite* tests the claim by placing an ethical choice, whether to cast the first stone at the couple, at the very gate of the city, and then demonstrating that the city will cast it anyway. The player's refusal is honored as a gesture and nullified as an outcome. That is the game's first sermon, and it is preached by the controller.

8.4

Vampire's Embrace: Slotkin in the Gear System

The player's body in *Infinite* regenerates. Booker's shield recharges after combat; he restores health by eating food found in barrels and bins; and he equips pieces of gear that modify his capacities, some of which convert killing directly into renewal. The aptly named *Vampire's Embrace* and *Blood to Salt* convert killing into renewal: with the first, melee kills restore health; with the second, slain enemies yield Salts four times in ten, as the Scavenger's Vest makes them yield ammunition. Another item, Sheltered Life, grants brief invulnerability whenever Booker heals—a mechanical echo of the ritual invulnerability that the Hall of Heroes mocks in the Ghost Dance and the Boxers. What Richard Slotkin described as the mythic structure of the American frontier, regeneration through violence, is here a numerical system. Each kill restores the killer. The frontier myth is mechanized.

The Vigors that Booker drinks from bottles are sold in vending machines with carnival names—*Veni! Vidi! Vigor!* for the potions, *Dollar Bill* for supplies, *Minuteman's Armory* for weapons—and advertised in the manner of nineteenth-century patent medicines, the

elixirs whose fraudulent claims led Congress to pass the Pure Food and Drug Act in 1906. Their names compose a lexicon of the American imagination. *Possession* names both property and demonic seizure. *Devil's Kiss* is fire. *Murder of Crows* borrows the zealots' birds. *Bucking Bronco* is the rodeo; *Charge* is the cavalry; *Shock Jockey* yokes the dynamo to horse racing, the gambler's sport. *Undertow* is drowning, a Vigor of grasping water. *Return to Sender* is the postal economy of the returned gift. Property, demonism, the frontier, the cavalry, the racetrack, the drowning, and the debt that comes back: the Vigors recapitulate, in a single menu, the themes of the whole work.

Alexander Galloway (2006) and McKenzie Wark (2007) read the shooter as an allegory of control and of the "military entertainment complex." *Infinite* specifies the allegory historically. Its shooter is the frontier myth in playable form, and its upgrades are the conversion of violence into vitality that Slotkin found at the root of the national imagination. The player regenerates through violence for twelve hours so that, at the end, the game can ask whether regeneration is possible at all.

8.5

"Would You Kindly" and "Bring Us the Girl"

BioShock (2007) built its reputation on a revelation about its own form. The player learns, two-thirds of the way through, that the phrase "would you kindly," which has preceded every instruction given by his guide, is a conditioning trigger; the protagonist, Jack, has been obeying, not choosing. In the scene that delivers the revelation, Andrew Ryan, who is Jack's father, commands his son to kill him, repeating the phrase himself: a man chooses, a slave obeys. Ryan's death at his son's hand, ordered by Ryan, is the father's final assertion of choice in a world of programmed obedience.

Infinite rhymes its ending with its predecessor's climax. Booker dies at his daughter's hands by his own consent. Both games culminate in a father's death by his child's hand at the father's will; both make that death the father's last act of freedom. The commission *bring us the girl, and wipe away the debt* is *Infinite*'s "would you kindly": a phrase that the protagonist repeats as his own motive and that turns out to have been placed in his mind by others, with his memories overwritten to match.

The parallel reveals a signature of Levine's authorship. In *System Shock 2* (1999), the voice guiding the player, ostensibly a surviving officer, is revealed as the rogue intelligence SHODAN. In *BioShock*, the friendly Atlas is revealed as the gangster Fontaine. In *Infinite*, the guides are the Luteces, who have engineered the whole expedition, and Elizabeth, who leads Booker to the river. In each work the companion who guides you is the author of your end. The series' true constants are therefore more numerous than the lighthouse for-

mula admits: a lighthouse, a man, a city; a guiding voice that is also a manipulator; a child sold; and a father killed by the child.

8.6

The Franchise as Causal Loop: Burial at Sea

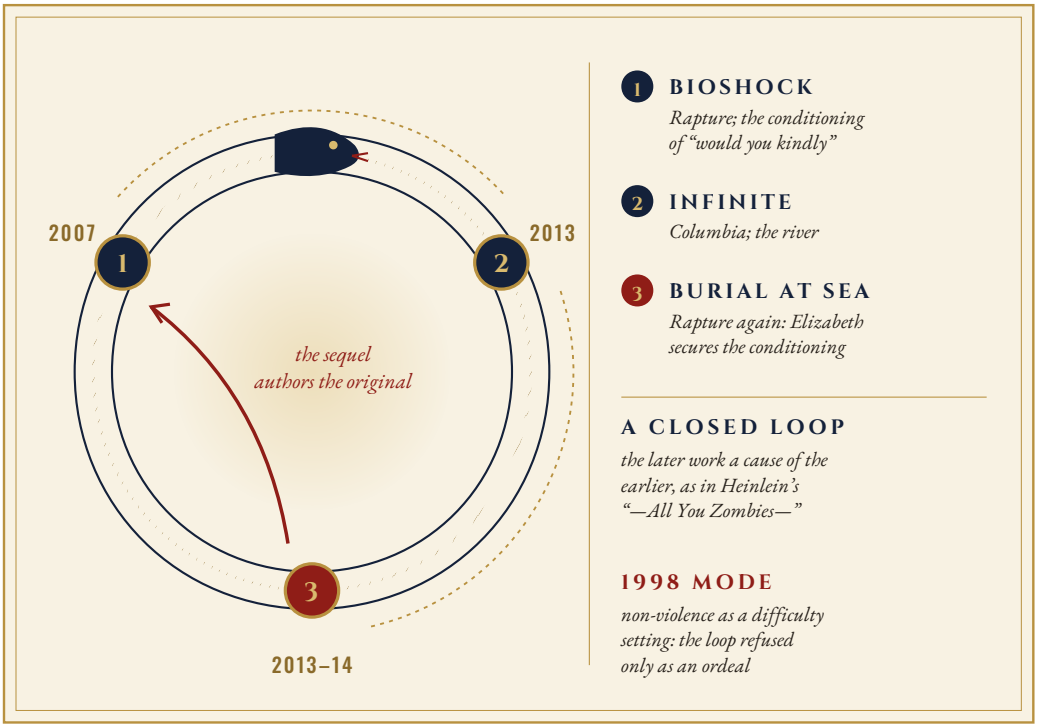
The two episodes of *Burial at Sea* (2013–14) carried *Infinite* back into Rapture and, in doing so, closed the series into a loop. In the first episode, set in Rapture on the eve of its civil war, the private investigator who calls himself Booker is revealed to be a Comstock: one who, after the child's death in his own world, fled to the undersea city and erased himself into a new identity. Elizabeth, who has pursued him across worlds, watches him die.

In the second, Elizabeth, stripped of her powers and bound to the fate of a single Little Sister, works through Rapture's factions and, after Atlas threatens to torture the child Sally to compel her, secures for Atlas the means by which the protagonist of *BioShock* will be brought to the city and controlled: the conditioning that the phrase "would you kindly" will trigger. Atlas beats her to death with a wrench, the signature weapon of the first game. In her last vision she sees the consequences of what she has done, the arrival of Jack and the eventual rescue of the Little Sisters, and accepts them.

The later work thereby authors the earlier. Elizabeth, a character from the 2013 game, becomes a cause of the 2007 game's central mechanism. The franchise acquires the structure of Heinlein's "—All You Zombies—": a closed causal loop in which the sequel engenders its own original. Mircea Eliade's *The Myth of the Eternal Return* (1949) argued that archaic societies abolished profane time by ritually repeating the cosmogony, and that modern historical consciousness suffers instead the "terror of history," the exposure to irreversible events without archetypal meaning. The franchise is an apparatus of eternal return. Each sequel ritually repeats the lighthouse, the man, and the city, abolishing the irreversibility of the previous ending; and *Burial at Sea* sacralizes the repetition by making the latest return the origin of the first. Reviewers registered the compulsion: Wired's Chris Kohler found the first episode to be fan service, Polygon's Justin McElroy judged that the second's effort to tie everything together too often resembled accomplished fan fiction, and The A.V. Club's Sam Barsanti argued that it rescued Elizabeth by returning her from godhood to personhood.

The title is itself a drowning: a burial at sea. The episodes that follow the river take their name from the immersion of the dead. After the catabaptism that was meant to end the series' loop, the series buries its heroine in the sea of its first city and makes her the author of the loop's beginning. Chapter Nine will argue that this is the most honest thing the franchise ever did: it admitted, in narrative form, that the medium cannot drown its player.

FIGURE 13



The Franchise as Causal Loop. *Burial at Sea makes the 2013 work a cause of the 2007 one and closes the series into a loop (section 8.6).*

One more design decision completes the confession. The second episode added a "1998 Mode," which challenges the player to finish without killing, named for Looking Glass's stealth game *Thief: The Dark Project* (1998), as *Infinite*'s hardest setting had recalled 1999. At the close of Irrational's work on the series, non-violence entered it as a difficulty setting: the shooter's regenerative loop could be refused, but only as an ordeal.



IX

CHAPTER NINE

CATABAPTISM

Toward a Theology of the Possible

"Know ye not, that so many of us as were baptized into Jesus Christ were baptized into his death? Therefore we are buried with him by baptism into death: that like as Christ was raised up from the dead by the glory of the Father, even so we also should walk in newness of life."

Romans 6:3–4

"And it repented the LORD that he had made man on the earth, and it grieved him at his heart."

Genesis 6:6

THE PRECEDING CHAPTERS HAVE assembled the materials: a theology of debt that ends in a creditor's self-sacrifice; an American theology of regeneration that ends in a city of the twice-born; a metaphysics in which names are contingent and origins necessary; a mythology of captive daughters; a ludic form that resurrects its hero for a fee. This chapter gives the name *catabaptism* to the rite in which these materials converge, defines it, situates it within the typology of sacred waters, and submits it to critique. The thesis is double. Catabaptism is the most original theological idea a video game has produced; it is also the precise form in which *Infinite* reproduces the American evasion it set out to expose.

9.1

Four Waters

ERICH AUERBACH'S ESSAY "FIGURA" (1938) reconstructed the figural interpretation by which early Christian readers understood an event in scripture as both real in itself and prefiguring a later event that fulfills it. Sacred water is the richest field of such figures, and four of them govern *Infinite*.

The first is the Jordan. John baptizes Jesus; the heavens open; the Spirit descends "like a dove"; a voice declares, "This is my beloved Son, in whom I am well pleased" (Matthew 3:13–17). Baptism is immersion followed by descent from above and naming from above.

The second is the Flood. God, repenting that he had made man, drowns the earth, saving eight souls in the ark; afterward he covenants that "neither shall there any more be a flood to destroy the earth" (Genesis 9:11). The First Epistle of Peter makes the Flood a figure of baptism: the eight were "saved by water," and "the like figure whereunto even baptism doth also now save us" (1 Peter 3:20–21). The Flood is creation's un-making by water, a catastrophe that the sacrament later typologically inherits. The Hebrew verb of that resolution, māḥâ, "to wipe out," is the verb the Septuagint characteristically renders with exaleiphō, so that the Flood belongs philologically to the same family as the wiping away of debts, sins, names, and tears (section 1.1).

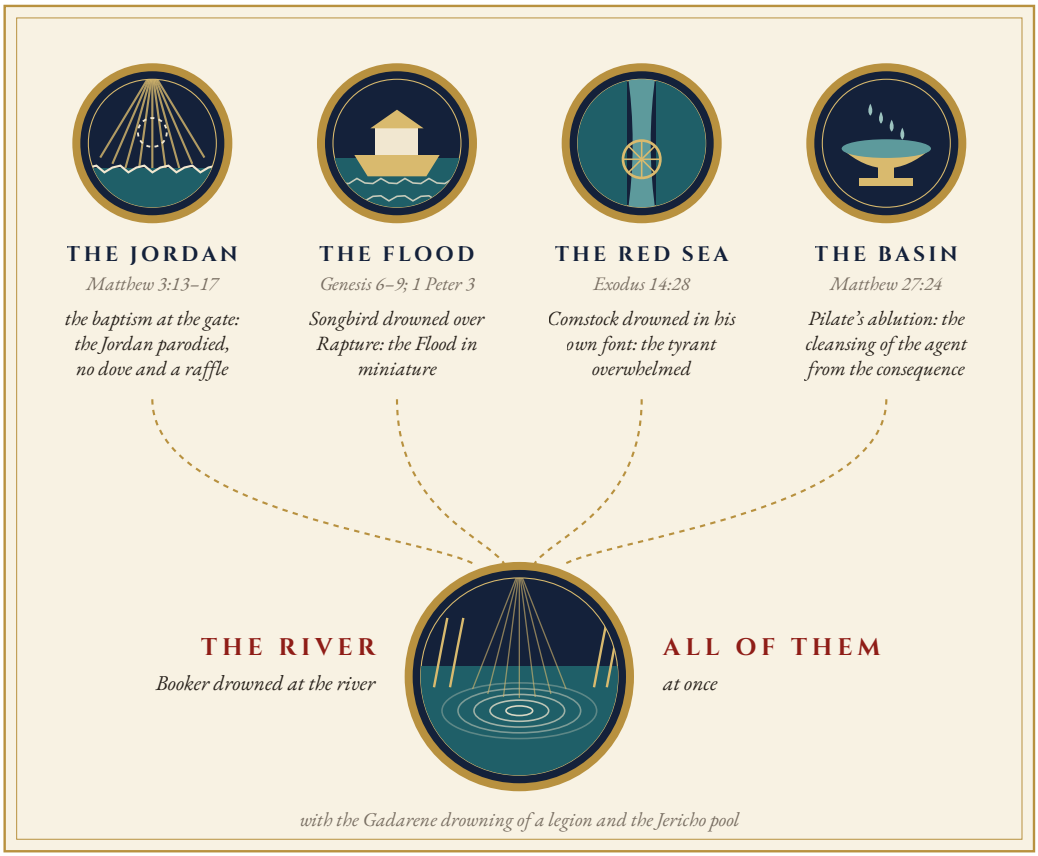
The third is the Red Sea. The waters part for Israel and return upon the pursuing army: "And the waters returned, and covered the chariots, and the horsemen, and all the host of Pharaoh that came into the sea after them; there remained not so much as one of them" (Exodus 14:28). Here water is judgment on the oppressor.

The fourth is the basin. Pilate washes his hands before the multitude and declares himself innocent of the blood he is about to permit (Matthew 27:24). Water is dissociation: the cleansing of the agent from the consequence of his act.

Two lesser waters complete the typology. The Gadarene swine, possessed by the demons who are "Legion, for we are many," rush into the sea and drown together (Mark 5:9–13).

And Josephus recounts how Aristobulus III, the last of the Hasmonean line, made high priest at seventeen and too warmly acclaimed by the crowd at the feast, was drowned within the year in the fish-ponds at Jericho: companions appointed by Herod held him under at dusk, "as if it had been done in sport only" (*Jewish Antiquities* XV.3.3, §§53–56; cf. *Jewish War* I.22.2). It was a political murder disguised as a game in the water, and the victim was a priest whose popularity was his offense.

FIGURE 14



FOUR WATERS. *The figural waters of scripture and the immersions that answer to them; the river is all of them at once (section 9.1).*

Infinite's four immersions answer to these figures. Booker's baptism at the gate of Columbia is the Jordan parodied: an immersion without a dove, followed not by a voice from heaven but by a raffle. Comstock drowned in his own font aboard the *Hand of the Prophet* is the Red Sea: the tyrant overwhelmed by the water he made sacred. Songbird drowned in the depths over Rapture is the Flood in miniature: the guardian of the old covenant, the cherub who kept the garden's gate, swallowed by the abyss. And Booker drowned at the river is all of them at once. It has the Jordan's form, the Flood's power of

un-making, the Red Sea's character of judgment, the Gadarene drowning of a many-bodied legion, the Jericho pool's intimacy of companions holding a man under—and, as section 9.8 will argue, the basin's ablution.

Gaston Bachelard's poetics of the elements gives this typology a psychology. *L'Eau et les rêves* (1942) identified a "Charon complex," the reverie of the ferryman who bears the dead across water, and an "Ophelia complex," the reverie of water as the element of a gentle, consenting, and characteristically feminine death. *Infinite* opens inside the first complex: Booker is rowed across dark water by two pale ferrymen to the threshold of another world, a soul in transit from the opening frame. It closes by inverting the second: not a woman given to the water but a man held under it by women. *L'Air et les songes* (1943) described the ascensional imagination, the dream of flight in which the psyche rises toward lightness; Columbia is that dream built in steel. The work's elemental argument can then be stated plainly. Air is the medium of Columbia's hubris, fire the medium of its prophecy, and water the medium of every judgment; and at the end water defeats air.

9.2

The Rite Defined

Catabaptism, as *Infinite* stages it, has four moments.

The first is *immersion*: a return to the water at the branch-point, the precise place and time at which the subject's possibilities divide. The second is *recognition*: an anagnorisis in which the subject recognizes himself in his counterpart, the hero in the villain, the detective in the culprit. The third is *consent*: the subject wills his own un-actualization, as Isaac in the midrash consents to the knife and Andrew Ryan commands his son to strike. The fourth is *un-actualization*: the rite removes not the subject's future, as an execution does, but his possibility, pruning the whole class of his counterparts at their common root.

The rite can be defined by its differences from its neighbors. Baptism regenerates: the old self dies so that a new self may live. Anabaptism, the re-baptism of the elect, regenerates a second time, and at Münster it founded a New Jerusalem on that second birth. Ablution dissociates: the hands are cleansed of a consequence they caused. The Flood exterminates but saves a remnant. Catabaptism does none of these. It neither regenerates nor dissociates nor preserves. It un-makes the possibility of the one immersed, so that the evil he would have done in some world is done in none.

A formula may be offered. Paul writes that "our old man is crucified with him" so that "the body of sin might be destroyed" (Romans 6:6): *the old man is buried that the new may live.* The catabaptismal formula is: *the possible man is buried that the actual city may never be.*

The game's title invites one further gloss. Emmanuel Levinas's *Totality and Infinity* (1961) opposed the totality of systems, which absorb every other into the same, to the infinity disclosed in the face of the other person, which commands a responsibility without limit. Modal debt is a perverse Levinasian infinity: a responsibility without limit, owed not to the face of another but to every face that one's own possibilities have harmed. Catabaptism discharges it by abolishing the possibilities, and in that sense it is a return to totality disguised as infinite responsibility.

FIGURE 15



The Rite Defined. *The four moments of catabaptism, its differences from neighboring rites, and the catabaptismal formula (section 9.2).*

9.3

Romans 6 without Easter

Paul's theology of baptism is a theology of death and resurrection compressed into immersion: the believer is "buried with him by baptism into death" in order to rise and "walk in newness of life." *Infinite* preserves the first clause and withholds the second.

Booker is buried with his counterpart in the water, and the work refuses to show him rising, exiling any resurrection beyond the credits into an ambiguous room.

A second subtraction is equally exact. At the Jordan the Spirit descends as a dove upon the one baptized. In *Infinite*, the bird that should descend at the baptism has already been drowned. Songbird, the mechanical bird whose bond to Elizabeth is the game's figure for both care and captivity, perished in the abyss over Rapture before the final immersion. No bird descends at the river; no voice names Booker beloved. Instead, his daughter un-names him. Catabaptism is baptism minus the dove: immersion without descent, death without the voice from heaven.

9.4

El delito mayor: *The Crime of Having Been Born*

Calderón's Segismundo asks the heavens what crime he committed by being born, and answers that the greatest crime of man is to have been born. Schopenhauer quoted the lines in *The World as Will and Representation* (1819, I §51) to state what he took to be the true sense of tragedy: that the hero atones not for his particular sins but for original sin, the guilt of existence itself. The chorus of Sophocles' *Oedipus at Colonus* (1224–27) had already declared that not to be born surpasses every reckoning, and that the next best thing is to return as swiftly as possible whence one came; Nietzsche's *Birth of Tragedy* (1872, §3) gave the same wisdom to Silenus. David Benatar's *Better Never to Have Been* (2006) offered a contemporary argument for the asymmetry between the harms of existence and the absence of goods in non-existence.

Infinite's ending is a local antinatalism. It does not judge all existence a crime, only one possibility: the man who would accept the baptism must never have been available to accept it. The maxim of the crib returns at the end in literal form. The coda opens on a nursery, and the viewer is not shown whether the crib is full or empty. Whether the crime of having been born has been undone, or merely transferred from father to daughter, the game declines to say.

9.5

The Creditor Who Sacrifices Himself: Nietzsche, Jung, Derrida

Chapter One traced Nietzsche's account of Christianity's paradox, in which the creditor sacrifices himself for his debtor out of love. C. G. Jung's *Answer to Job* (1952) offered a psychological version of the same structure. Confronted with the injustice of his own treatment of Job, Yahweh, in Jung's reading, must become man and suffer, so that the

incarnation is God's answer to the wrong he did his creature. The divine creator atones for his own sin against the creature by undergoing the creature's death.

Booker is a Jungian god in this precise sense. He is the author of Elizabeth's condition: her father, her seller, and, as Comstock, her jailer. He atones by suffering death at his creature's hands, and the creature, become divine, administers it.

Derrida's *The Gift of Death* (1992) adds a final complication. The French idiom *donner la mort*, "to give death," means to kill, and *se donner la mort* means to take one's own life. Booker gives himself death, and Elizabeth gives it to him; the gift is mutual. But Derrida's analysis of the gift, developed in *Given Time*, holds that a gift recognized as such re-enters the circle of exchange and is annulled as a gift. The Elizabeths witness the death; they receive it; they are, for a moment, its beneficiaries. The sacrifice returns to the ledger it was meant to close. Catabaptism cannot escape economy, because there is always someone at the river to see it.

The Easter liturgy of the Western church contains the most famous sentence in the theology of the fortunate fall: *O felix culpa, quae talem ac tantum meruit habere Redemptorem*, "O happy fault, that merited so great and such a Redeemer." The *felix culpa* justifies the fall by the redemption it occasions. *Infinite* refuses it. Elizabeth's power, and thus her capacity to redeem, exists only because of Booker's sin: the sale and the severed finger. A theodicy of the fortunate fall would accept the sin for the sake of the redeemer. The game annuls the sin and, with it, the redeemer, who fades at the river with the man she saved.

Milton gave the doctrine its English poetry at the close of *Paradise Lost*, where Adam, shown the redemption to come, confesses: "full of doubt I stand, / Whether I should repent me now of sin / By me done and occasioned, or rejoice / Much more, that much more good thereof shall spring" (XII.473–76). Comstock is the Adam who chose to rejoice: his baptism treats Wounded Knee as the occasion of his election, the fault that merited a prophet. Booker is the Adam who could only repent. The river answers Milton's Adam by refusing both of his options.

9.6

The Circle of Elizabeths: Girard and the Pharmakos

René Girard argued that archaic communities, threatened by the crisis of undifferentiation that mimetic rivalry produces, restore their unity through the unanimous killing of a single victim, who is then sacralized as the cause both of the crisis and of the peace that follows (*Violence and the Sacred*, 1972; *The Scapegoat*, 1982). The Gospels, in his later account, break the mechanism by revealing the victim's innocence (*I See Satan Fall Like Lightning*, 1999).

The scene at the river is a Girardian rite of rare purity. The Elizabeths form a circle around Booker, a crowd that is perfectly unanimous because it is composed of one person. Mimetic rivalry is abolished not by sacrifice but by identity: every member of the crowd is the same woman. The victim is one man who is also many. And the game does not reveal his innocence. On the contrary, it affirms his guilt, for Wounded Knee and for the sale, and it extends that guilt to the crimes of his counterparts. In Girard's terms the ending is a re-mystification: the victim's guilt is asserted so that the community of worlds may be purified.

Derrida's "Plato's Pharmacy" (1968) traced the double sense of the Greek *pharmakon*, at once poison and remedy, to the *pharmakos*, the human scapegoat expelled from the Athenian city in times of crisis. Booker is the pharmakos in a new key. He is not expelled from a city but from possibility, and his expulsion is both the poison that kills him and the remedy that saves every world from Columbia.

The circle, finally, is the figure in which the work's many circles meet. The hymn Booker played asked whether the circle would be unbroken. Black Elk mourned the broken hoop of his nation. The Ghost Dance itself was danced in a circle, men and women holding hands and facing the center, and it ended in a river. Heinlein's ring showed the serpent devouring its tail; the Lutece tally recorded a loop that would not close. At the river a circle of Elizabeths closes around the man and then breaks, one figure at a time, until the screen goes dark.

FIGURE 16



The Circle, Breaking. *The work's circles, from the hymn to the Elizabeths at the river (section 9.6).*

9.7

The Sovereign of the Multiverse: Schmitt and Benjamin

Carl Schmitt's *Political Theology* (1922) defined the sovereign as he who decides on the exception, and compared the exception in jurisprudence to the miracle in theology. Chapter Three described Comstock's sovereignty as a monopoly of the miracle. At the river that sovereignty passes to Elizabeth, and it becomes absolute. She decides on the exception to existence itself: which worlds shall have been. No sovereign in Schmitt's imagination ever possessed such a power. It is the exception raised from law to being.

The game prepares this transfer of sovereignty in a single exchange. Late in the game, as her power grows, Elizabeth asks Booker whether he is afraid of God. He answers that he is not; he is afraid of her. The line is the work's political theology in miniature: the fear once owed to the prophet's God has passed to the daughter who can decide which worlds shall have been.

Walter Benjamin's "Critique of Violence" (1921), written in implicit argument with Schmitt, distinguished two kinds of violence. Mythic violence makes law; it is bloody; and it imposes guilt, in Benjamin's word *verschuldend*, making its subjects debtors. Divine violence destroys law; it is expiatory, *entsühnend*; and it is lethal without spilling blood. Benjamin's example was the company of Korah, swallowed by the earth in the wilderness (Numbers 16): struck without warning, without bloodshed, and without remainder.

The distinction illuminates the ending with startling exactness. Columbia's founding violence is mythic. It is bloody, from Wounded Knee to Peking; it makes the law of the city; and it imposes *Schuld* on all who live under it. Booker's drowning is bloodless, expiatory, and law-annihilating: it destroys the law of Columbia at its origin and expiates the guilt the city imposed. It is divine violence in Benjamin's sense. The genealogy of *Schuld* traced in Chapter One closes here, in Benjamin's own vocabulary: mythic violence makes debtors, and divine violence wipes away the debt.

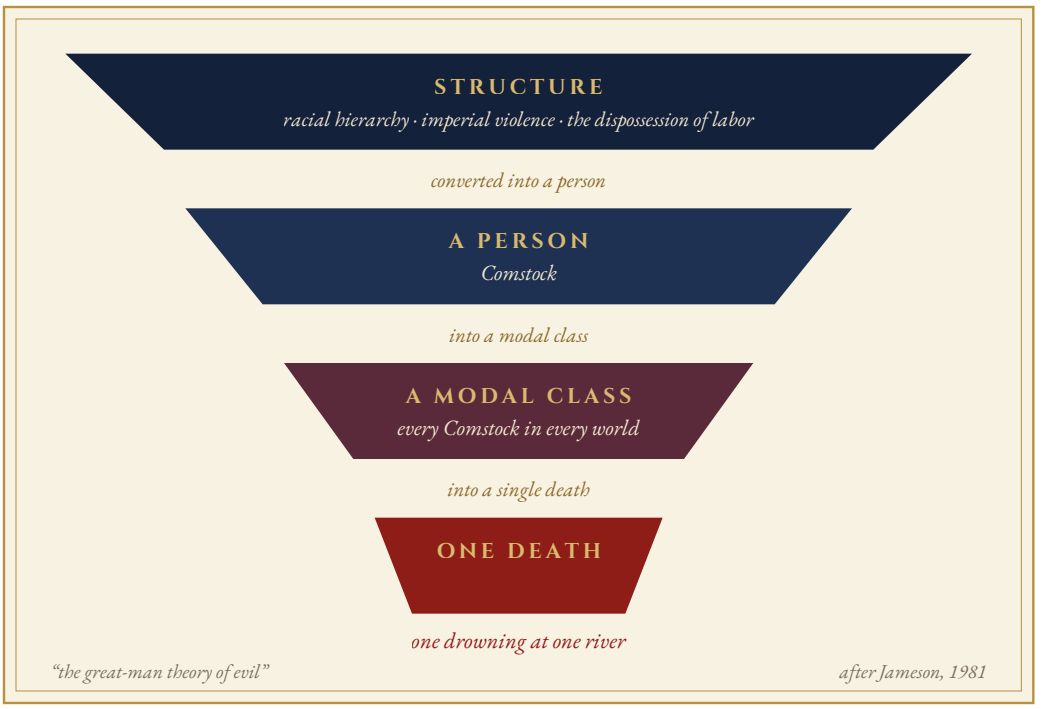
Benjamin, however, insisted that divine violence cannot be recognized with certainty by those who witness it; its criteria are inaccessible to human judgment. Elizabeth's certainty, the calm with which she leads her father into the water, is exactly what the essay forbids. The game grants its heroine a knowledge of the exception that Benjamin denied to anyone, and in that grant lies the danger of the whole construction.

9.8

The Privatization of Guilt

Fredric Jameson's *The Political Unconscious* (1981) proposed that narratives offer imaginary resolutions to real social contradictions. The contradiction that *Infinite* confronts is that structural evil—racial hierarchy, imperial violence, the dispossession of labor—cannot be undone by any individual act. The game resolves the contradiction by a three-stage operation. First, it converts a structure into a person: Columbia's racism, imperialism, and exploitation are made to emanate from Comstock. Second, it converts the person into a modal class: every Comstock in every world is a possibility of Booker. Third, it converts the class into a single death: one drowning at one river prunes the class at its root. Structural sin becomes personal sin, personal sin becomes modal debt, and modal debt is paid in full by one man. This is the great-man theory of evil, raised to metaphysical form.

FIGURE 17



The Privatization of Guilt. *The three-stage operation by which structural evil becomes a person, a modal class, and a single death (section 9.8).*

History refutes it. None of the conditions that produced Columbia required Comstock. Wounded Knee occurred, and twenty Medals of Honor for it remain on the nation's

roll; the White City excluded Black Americans; the Chinese Exclusion Act of 1882 was law; a Memphis mob had lynched three Black men of the People's Grocery, Thomas Moss, Calvin McDowell, and Will Stewart, in March 1892, and when Ida B. Wells denounced the killings another mob destroyed her newspaper's offices (Wells 1970), so that she documented the lynching system from exile in *Southern Horrors* (1892); the Supreme Court would ratify segregation in *Plessy v. Ferguson* (1896); American troops would march on Peking. All of this happened in the world the game calls the Sodom below, without a prophet, without a floating city, and without a baptism at a river. The coda returns Booker to New York in 1893, to a city whose Exposition was excluding Black Americans as he slept. The drowning saves Columbia's victims from Columbia. It does not save them from America.

The game knows this, in the way that works know what they cannot say. Its own chronology places the branch-point after the massacre, so that the rite cannot touch the founding atrocity; Elizabeth, the angel of history, can prevent the city but cannot awaken the dead. Reinhold Niebuhr's *Moral Man and Immoral Society* (1932) argued that individuals may achieve moral conduct but that collectives are governed by power and interest, so that social injustice yields only to political struggle, never to individual virtue alone. *Infinite*'s ending is a pre-Niebuhrian fantasy: an immoral society cured by one moral man's self-sacrifice. It belongs to a long American habit, nourished by revivalism, of imagining social evil as an aggregate of individual sins, curable by individual conversion. The game critiques rebirth while keeping the individual as the sole locus of salvation. Catabaptism is the negative form of the same individualism: where the revival says *be born again*, the river says *be unborn*, and neither says *organize*.

Here the argument of Chapter Four completes itself. Pilate's basin and John's river are one water. The political ablution that rendered the Vox and the Founders equally disposable was the precondition of the metaphysical drowning, because only a crisis with no political solution can require a sacramental one. And the metaphysical drowning is the political ablution raised to the absolute: the work washes its hands of the structure by drowning the person.

9.9

The Affirmers' Objection: Zarathustra and Sisyphus

The strongest objection to catabaptism comes not from theology but from the two modern philosophers who made the loop itself the test of a life.

In *The Gay Science* (1882, §341), Nietzsche imagines a demon who steals into one's loneliest loneliness and announces that this life, exactly as lived, must be lived again innumerable times, every pain and every joy returning in the same sequence; would one curse

the demon, or answer that one had never heard anything more divine? *Thus Spoke Zarathustra* (1883–85) dramatizes the thought at a gateway named Moment, where two eternal lanes, one running back and one forward, meet. A dwarf mutters that time itself is a circle, and Zarathustra sees a young shepherd choking on a black snake that has crawled into his throat. Told to bite, the shepherd bites off the snake's head, spits it away, and rises transformed and laughing ("On the Vision and the Riddle"). Nietzsche's name for the affirmation is *amor fati* (*The Gay Science*, §276), and in *Ecce Homo* (written 1888) he called it his formula for greatness in a human being: to want nothing to be different, not forward, not backward, not in all eternity.

The Lutece tally is the demon's ledger, and the river is the gateway named Moment. *Infinite* places the greatest weight on Booker and has him answer no. He does not bite the snake; he is held under. Measured by Nietzsche, catabaptism is the most complete refusal of recurrence imaginable: not the affirmation of the loop but its annulment at the root, a theology of ressentiment directed against one's own possibilities.

Albert Camus's *The Myth of Sisyphus* (1942) opens by declaring that there is but one truly serious philosophical problem, suicide, and devotes its critical chapters to what it calls philosophical suicide, the leap by which thinkers from Kierkegaard to Chestov escape the absurd into faith. Booker's consent at the river is both at once: a literal self-annulment and a leap into a sacrament. Camus's alternative is revolt, the lucid refusal either to hope or to die, embodied in Sisyphus walking back down the mountain to his stone; and the book ends by asking that we imagine Sisyphus happy, *il faut imaginer Sisyphe heureux*. Schopenhauer had counseled the opposite, the denial of the will to live that culminates in the saint's resignation (*The World as Will and Representation* I, §68). Booker at the river is Schopenhauer's saint, not Camus's rebel.

The objection lands, and the game partly concedes it. The coda is legible as Sisyphus at the foot of the mountain: a man back in his room, the burden of his life waiting beyond the next door, his single word a resumption rather than an ending. Read this way, the post-credits scene is not a resurrection but the absurd hero's return to his stone, and the game's last image corrects its rite. The drowning says that a self whose possibilities include Comstock must not have been. The door says that the self is still there, and must live.

9.10

The Remnant

After the credits, Booker wakes in his lodgings on 8 October 1893. He calls his daughter's name and opens the door to the nursery. The screen cuts to black.

The coda admits several readings, and the game is constructed to sustain them all. It may show a world in which Booker refused the baptism and Comstock never existed, so

that no one came to buy the child and the father keeps his daughter. It may show the drowned man's dream, the last image of a mind going under. It may show the loop beginning again, the first room of the next iteration. And it may show, in the idiom of the franchise, the next door: the place where a sequel will begin.

Giorgio Agamben's *The Time That Remains* (2000), a commentary on Paul's Letter to the Romans, gives the scene its theological name. Paul speaks of "a remnant according to the election of grace" (Romans 11:5), and Agamben argues that the messianic remnant is not a surviving portion of a whole but what exceeds every division, the part that cannot be counted on either side. Booker in the room of 1893 is such a remnant. He is not Booker before the river, nor Booker after it, nor Comstock; he is what remains when the possibilities have been divided and one class of them unmade. His single word, a question, holds the remnant open. Voltaire's Candide, after the catastrophes of the best of all possible worlds, retreats to a garden. Booker retreats to a nursery.

The remnant has a medial meaning as well. The save directory of a game is a Palace of the Fates: a set of possible worlds, each preserved at a moment of decision, from which the player chooses one to actualize. The player's *continue* is Leibniz's apex world, chosen from the infinite pyramid of saves. *Infinite* tries, at its river, to drown the player-character in every save at once, to end the franchise's loop by a rite that leaves no world to continue. It cannot. The coda reopens a door; *Burial at Sea* makes the heroine the author of the series' beginning; the medium resurrects its hero for a fee.

Catabaptism therefore fails as a solution and succeeds as a revelation. It fails because the medium cannot drown its player, and because the nation cannot be absolved by the death of a man. It succeeds because the failure is staged with such precision that the impossibility becomes visible. *Infinite* brought the American theology of regeneration to the water and held it under, and when it surfaced, still breathing, the game recorded the fact. There is always a lighthouse. There is always a man. There is always a city. And there is always, after the credits, a door.



CONCLUSION

THERE IS ALWAYS A LIGHTHOUSE

THIS THESIS HAS ARGUED that *BioShock Infinite* is a speculative theology whose central sacrament, catabaptism, absolves by un-actualization: it discharges a debt owed by every possible version of a man by drowning him at the point where his possibilities divide. The argument has proceeded through nine chapters, and its findings can now be stated together.

Findings

THE GAME'S MASTER IDIOM is debt. Its commission, *bring us the girl, and wipe away the debt*, renders the verb and object of Colossians 2:14, and the same Greek verb wipes away the tears of Revelation 21:4, so that the two nouns on which the game turns are, in its scriptural substrate, objects of a single erasure—a verb that also blots sins away and names out of the book of life, and whose Hebrew counterpart wipes out humankind in the Flood. Because Comstock is Booker, the sale of Anna is a transaction within one trans-world self, and the ending literalizes the paradox Nietzsche found at the heart of Christianity: the creditor who sacrifices himself for his debtor. From these materials the thesis derived the concept of *modal debt*, a liability owed by a class of counterparts to the totality of worlds, payable only by altering what is possible.

Columbia is the diagnosis of a precise historical conjuncture, 1890 to 1893, when the frontier was declared closed, the Ghost Dance was massacred at Wounded Knee, and the White City rose in Chicago. The city is a *vertical frontier*, the continental drive rotated into the sky and then into possibility, and a *White Ghost Dance*, a millenarian movement of the white faithful lifted aloft, mirroring the movements whose destruction it enshrines. Its prophet composes Smith, Dowie, and Teed; its emblems repeat the font and the cages of Anabaptist Münster; its protagonist's name, *Booker DeWitt*, carries the color line within it.

The theology of Columbia is a misreading of physics, and its scriptural texture is a second plot. The principal names reproduce the cast of Luke's infancy narrative, Zacharias, Elisabeth, and Anna, whose child is the Baptist; and the child of these names becomes the one who baptizes. *Infinite* is Revelation 21 in reverse: the holy city in the sky is unmade rather than descended, and the one who wipes away every tear is a daughter drowning a father.

The politics of equivalence, which equates the Vox Populi with the Founders, is not a lapse but a structural requirement. Only a crisis with no political solution can require a sacramental one. Pilate's basin is the precondition of John's river.

The game's metaphysics is Kripkean. Names are fixed by initial baptisms and are contingent; origins are necessary. *Comstock* is a name a man received in a river, and the only way to prevent that dubbing in every world is to drown its necessary bearer. Against Lewis's coun-

terparts and Parfit's fission, the game insists that identity fixed by origin is what matters, because only such identity can carry a debt across worlds. It converts William James's "moral multiverse" from an image of indifference into a tribunal, and turns Zimmerman's thesis of counterfactual culpability from a paradox into a fact.

Elizabeth inverts the archive of captive daughters. Where Jephthah, Agamemnon, Lot, and the father of Rapunzel give daughters to discharge vows and debts, Elizabeth discharges the father. Her story stages a third answer to Le Guin's Omelas, whose source in James's essay of 1891 reveals the same philosopher behind the game's ethics, its cosmology, and its psychology of conversion.

The game's form is its theology. The respawn returns Booker to the scene of his sin and charges him for resurrection; its choices teach the decree; its gear mechanizes Slotkin's regeneration through violence; and its franchise, through *Burial at Sea*, becomes a causal loop in which the sequel authors the original.

Catabaptism, finally, is both the game's most original idea and its most revealing evasion. As Benjamin's divine violence, bloodless and expiatory, it wipes away the *Schuld* that Columbia's mythic violence imposed. As a Girardian rite, it re-mystifies the scapegoat. As an imaginary resolution in Jameson's sense, it privatizes structural guilt, converting a nation's sin into one man's modal debt and paying it with one drowning. The coda's open door confesses what the rite could not achieve: neither the medium nor the nation can be absolved by the death of a man.

Contributions

For game studies, the thesis proposes a method that may be called *procedural soteriology*: the reading of mechanics as doctrines of salvation, in which respawn is an economy of resurrection, choice is a theory of grace and decree, and seriality is a ritual of return. The method extends Bogost's procedural rhetoric from persuasion to theology and suggests that the medium's most persistent conventions encode a metaphysics that individual works may expose, exploit, or, as *Infinite* attempts, try to abolish.

For American studies, the thesis offers Columbia as a precise instrument for diagnosing the 1890s, and identifies what may be called the *Jamesian triangle*: "The Moral Philosopher and the Moral Life" (1891), with its lost soul on the far edge of things; "Is Life Worth Living?" (1895), with its moral multiverse; and *The Varieties of Religious Experience* (1902), with its twice-born soul. William James is the unacknowledged philosopher of *Infinite*, and the game is, among other things, an unwitting commentary on the decade in which American philosophy imagined the multiverse.

For the philosophy of fiction, the thesis argues that fictions can serve as laboratories of modal ethics, testing concepts that analytic philosophy entertains only as thought experiments. *Modal debt* has a significance beyond the game. Contemporary societies increasingly assign consequences to dispositions and probabilities rather than acts, through risk assessment, predictive policing, and actuarial governance. Philip K. Dick's "The Minority Report" (1956) named the logic "precrime." *Infinite* is a fable of precrime administered not by the state but by a daughter with perfect knowledge, and even there it cannot conceal the violence of punishing the possible. Its central concept also has an independent analogue in recent philosophy of religion, where Zimmerman's counterfactual account of culpability has been proposed as a model of original sin (Anderson 2021; 2026).

For theology, catabaptism is offered as a limit-concept of sacramental thought: the sacrament of un-becoming. It may be compared with *kenosis*, the self-emptying of Philippians 2:7, in which the divine "made himself of no reputation." Kenosis empties a self into the form of a servant; catabaptism empties a self of its possibilities. It is, in this sense, a modal kenosis, and its theological legitimacy, or its impossibility, is a question that the game poses more sharply than any treatise.

Limitations

The thesis has not claimed authorial design for most of the resonances it assembles. The Lucan names, Kripke's Elizabeth, the Dutch meaning of *DeWitt*, Donnelly's two cities, and Mooney's lifted dancers are offered as constellations in Benjamin's sense, configurations that illuminate the work whether or not its makers intended them. The danger of such a method is the over-reading that Ignatius Donnelly practiced on Shakespeare; the thesis has tried to mark each such resonance as resonance and to rest its central argument on the work's explicit structure. A verification pass on 28 October 2026 checked the work's factual and bibliographic claims against live sources; its corrections, and the items it could not re-check, are recorded at the end of the Works Cited.

Infinite was a large commercial production, developed over years by a studio under heavy constraints, and many of its features reflect design compromises rather than authorial vision. The thesis has read it as a total discourse without pretending that every element was chosen. Its reception has also been considered chiefly through Anglophone criticism; the experiences of Indigenous and Black players and critics, whose histories the game appropriates, deserve study on their own terms.

Future Research

Several lines of inquiry follow. A comparative study of "unbirth" endings, from *Donnie Darko* to *Dark*, could determine whether catabaptism is a genre convention emerging in the multiverse fictions of the twenty-first century. A history of the respawn across the shooter and its neighbors could test the thesis that the medium's resurrection economy encodes a theology. A reception history of *Infinite* among the communities it represents could correct the limits noted above. And the ethics of modal debt could be carried into the philosophy of algorithmic governance, where the question the game asks—may a person be held liable for what he would have done—has ceased to be speculative.

Final Meditation

A lighthouse is an instrument of repetition. It sends the same signal into the dark at the same interval, night after night, and its repetition is its mercy: it warns ships away from rocks that do not move. Virginia Woolf's *To the Lighthouse* (1927) built a novel around a voyage deferred for a decade and completed only after a death, in which a son who had resented his father's tyranny arrives at the lighthouse beside him and finds the resentment dissolving into recognition. *Infinite* takes its father and its daughter to the lighthouse too, and there it finds not recognition alone but judgment.

The game's most famous sentence—there is always a lighthouse, there is always a man, there is always a city—is usually read as a statement of fate. It can also be read as a statement of warning. There is always a lighthouse because the rocks are always there: the debt, the massacre, the color line, the child sold for a city. The proper response to a lighthouse is not to drown its keeper but to steer. *Infinite* chose to drown the keeper, and in doing so it asked, with greater seriousness than any work in its medium had before, whether a self that is the sum of its possibilities can be forgiven. Its answer, unbirth, is the answer of a theology of debt. The hymn its characters sang proposed another: a circle that holds rather than drowns, a hoop mended rather than broken. The game did not choose that answer. It left the door open.

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Note on sources. Citations were compiled from the author's knowledge and then checked on 28 October 2026 against the live sources listed in the verification record below; a second pass the same day checked every item the first had left unconfirmed.

VERIFICATION RECORD

On Oct 28, 2026 the thesis's factual and bibliographic claims were checked against live sources; the table records each claim, the result, and the pages consulted. The Wikipedia articles on *BioShock Infinite* and *Burial at Sea* and the *Encyclopedia of the Great Plains* entry were read in full; other items were checked against the published text of the cited pages as returned by search.

CLAIM (SECTION)	RESULT	SOURCES CONSULTED
July 1912 setting; Columbia as a federally funded floating world's fair; secession after the Boxer intervention (Intro, 2)	Confirmed	Wikipedia: BioShock Infinite · en.wikipedia.org
Comstock House torture; the 1983 future; coda dated 8 October 1893 (Intro, 6, 9)	Confirmed; dates added	Wikipedia: BioShock Infinite · en.wikipedia.org
Robert Lutece acquired Anna and persuaded Rosalind (Intro)	Corrected from "the Luteces"	Wikipedia: BioShock Infinite · en.wikipedia.org
Larson's book reached Levine through Irrational's artists (Intro)	Corrected from "Levine acknowledged"	Wikipedia: BioShock Infinite · en.wikipedia.org
Developer's threat to quit and the forgiveness theme; refund over the baptism; Levine on a single point of view and on racism; Tea Party mural; news logo; the violence debate; Edge on the ending (Intro, 3, 4, 5, 8)	Confirmed; added or made precise	Wikipedia: BioShock Infinite · en.wikipedia.org
Death costs money and partly heals enemies; the office-door sequence (8.2)	Confirmed; door sequence from player documentation	Wikipedia · en.wikipedia.org; Steam discussion · steamcommunity.com
Gear effects, including Sheltered Life (8.4)	Confirmed; exact effects added	Prima Games guide · primagames.com
Booker at Wounded Knee: age sixteen, a sergeant's accusation, scalping, burning occupied lodges (2.4, 2.6)	Confirmed as game lore compiled by fans; hedge kept	BioShock Wiki: Wounded Knee · bioshock.fandom.com; BioShock Wiki: Booker · bioshock.fandom.com
Seven-day gestation; Lady Comstock's rejection; tower built for the child; Comstock's line on forgiveness (3.4, 3.6)	Confirmed; Genesis 21:10 reading added	BioShock Wiki, as quoted · steamcommunity.com; BioShock Wiki: Comstock · bioshock.fandom.com
Finkton auction (4.2)	Corrected: a shortest-time auction for repair jobs, not a wage auction	BioShock Wiki: Finkton · bioshock.fandom.com
Daisy retcon in Burial at Sea Episode 2 (4.5)	Confirmed; detail added	BioShock Wiki · bioshock.fandom.com; GamerHorizon · gamerhorizon.com
Burial at Sea: threat to Sally, the wrench, 1998 Mode, Fink and Suchong's co-development of Songbird (4.2, 8.6)	Confirmed; added	Wikipedia: Burial at Sea · en.wikipedia.org
"Are you afraid of God?" exchange (9.7)	Confirmed; timing claim softened	GameStar · gamestar.de; trailer report · godisageek.com

CLAIM (SECTION)	RESULT	SOURCES CONSULTED
Elizabeth's plea in the 2011 demo; Songbird and an abusive relationship (6.4)	Confirmed; added	Game Informer · gameinformer.com; Wikipedia · en.wikipedia.org
exaleiphō in Colossians 2:14 and Revelation 7:17, 21:4; also Revelation 3:5 and Acts 3:19; Septuagint rendering of *māḥâ* (1.1, 3.3, 9.1)	Confirmed; extended	Blue Letter Bible · blueletterbible.org; Mounce · billmounce.com
Zwingli coined "catabaptists"; Elenchus, Zurich 1527; baptism as sacramentum (Note, 2.6)	Confirmed; refined	Dixon and Greengrass glossary · albany.edu; catalogue record · sclib.svkk.sk; synopsis · heidelblog.net
Ghost Dance: believers "taken up, as by wings"; circle dance; river bath (2.4)	Corrected ("sacred feathers" removed); extended	Mooney 1909 · newadvent.org; Messiah Letter · teachingamericanhistory.org; Sword's account · sites.miamioh.edu
Wounded Knee: Forsyth, Ghost Dance songs, Black Coyote, Hotchkiss guns, three miles, 146 buried on 3 January 1891, photographs, Medals of Honor, Miles, rescission bills (2.4, 9.8)	Confirmed; "blizzard" corrected; details added	Encyclopedia of the Great Plains · plainshumanities.unl.edu; Senate bill text · warren.senate.gov; We're History · werehistory.org
Boxer Uprising figures; Taiyuan (2.4)	Confirmed; Taiyuan responsibility marked as disputed	Wikipedia: Boxer Rebellion · en.wikipedia.org; Wikipedia: Taiyuan massacre · en.wikipedia.org; MIT Visualizing Cultures · visualizingcultures.mit.edu
Dunbar and Douglass at the Haitian pavilion; Wells's desk there; Colored American Day (2.3)	Confirmed; extended	Poets.org · poets.org; University of Dayton · ecommons.udayton.edu; Hyde Park Herald · hpherald.com; Black America Web · blackamericaweb.com
James's 1895 "moral multiverse"; the 1873 precedent; Moorcock 1963 (5.1, 7.5)	Confirmed; qualified	SF Encyclopedia · sf-encyclopedia.com; Lapham's Quarterly · laphamsquarterly.org
Le Guin's debt to James; subtitle; scapegoat; Dostoevsky (6.6)	Confirmed; extended	Wikipedia: Omelas · en.wikipedia.org; Le Guin's headnote · utilitarianism.com
Packer 2010; Aldred and Greenspan 2011 (Intro, Works Cited)	Confirmed; page ranges added	Intellect · doi.org; KB catalogue · ibl.kb.nl
Tulloch 2010; Parker and Aldred 2018 (Intro, 6.7, 8.3)	Confirmed; added	Macquarie University · researchers.mq.edu.au; 49th Shelf · 49thshelf.com; contents · lib-cat.mcphs.edu
Zimmerman's counterfactual view; Anderson 2021 and 2026 (1.7, 5.5)	Confirmed; added	PhilArchive · philarchive.org; publisher listing · jpc.de
Tavinor 2009: issue and pages (Intro, Works Cited)	Confirmed; pages added; argument extended	Project MUSE · muse.jhu.edu
Baehr 2001: issue and pages (1.5, Works Cited)	Volume and pages confirmed; issue number not separately confirmed	AGGB catalogue · neu.aggb-katalog.de
Hocking 2007: date and title; the term only in the title (8.1, Works Cited)	Confirmed; subtitle added; extended	Wikipedia: Ludonarrative dissonance · en.wikipedia.org; Games and Culture · doi.org; Seraphine · academia.edu

CLAIM (SECTION)	RESULT	SOURCES CONSULTED
Swift's Lindalino episode (7.1)	Confirmed; extended (Dublin, Wood's halfpence; omitted by Motte and Faulkner; printed 1899)	Wikipedia: Lindalino · en.wikipedia.org; Cambridge edition · assets.cambridge.org
Verne's *L'Île à hélice* (7.1)	Confirmed; extended (Milliard City; Protestant and Catholic dynasties)	Wikipedia: Propeller Island · en.wikipedia.org; Goodreads · goodreads.com
Donnelly's *Caesar's Column* (4.3)	Corrected ("Christian-socialist colony" to an agrarian republic in Uganda); extended	Wikipedia: Caesar's Column · en.wikipedia.org; American Studies · journals.ku.edu; Wesleyan edition · gallerybookshop.com
Kripke's Elizabeth example (5.3)	Confirmed; the Trumans and p. 113 added; extended	Argumenta · argumenta.org; SuperSummary · supersummary.com
Frye's settings for the point of epiphany (5.7)	Confirmed; extended (wheel of fortune, Babel, Woolf)	Anatomy of Criticism, excerpt · literarism.blogspot.com; Frye's glossary · northropfrye-theanatomyofcriticism.blogspot.com
Josephus on Aristobulus III (9.1)	Confirmed; sections and details added	Whiston translation · lexundria.com; Jewish Encyclopedia · jewishencyclopedia.com; Smith's Dictionary · cts.perseids.org
Dostoevsky's *The Gambler* (1.3)	Confirmed; contract terms added; extended	Wikipedia: The Gambler · en.wikipedia.org); Literary Hub · lithub.com
Fink and *Pinkerton* (4.2)	Corrected: recorded from 1902; Pinkerton derivation unsupported; German *Fink* likelier; extended	Etymonline · etymonline.com; World Wide Words · worldwidewords.org
Schreber's "miracled birds" (3.4)	Confirmed; refined; onset of 1893 added	Memoirs, excerpt (Jacket2) · jacket2.org; BAMPFA · calisphere.org; case summary · alamrafiul.com
Booker cut the *AD* mark himself (3.3)	Fan-compiled lore only; hedged in the text; argument extended	Heroes Wiki (mirror) · breezewiki.discard.no; Inconsistently Admirable Wiki · inconsistently-admirable.fandom.com
The anachronistic covers (7.8)	Corrected ("Girls Just Want to Have Fun" is a fairground, not ragtime, arrangement); Bradlee's four arrangements added	Game Developer · gamedeveloper.com; Museum of Play · museumofplay.org; Gamer Guides · gamerguides.com; Scott Bradlee (Wikipedia copy) · chise.org
The killing of Sitting Bull (2.4)	Confirmed; agents named; extended	McLaughlin's report, National Archives · docsteach.org; Smithsonian · smithsonianmag.com; Wikipedia: Sitting Bull · en.wikipedia.org

CLAIM (SECTION)	RESULT	SOURCES CONSULTED
Nancy Green at the 1893 fair (2.3)	Confirmed; extended	Wikipedia: Nancy Green · en.wikipedia.org; History News Network · historynewsnetwork.org; Kentucky Historical Society · apps.legislature.ky.gov
Molina's *Concordia* (5.5, Works Cited)	Confirmed; full title, Antwerp edition, and papal commission added	Freddoso, Notre Dame · www3.nd.edu; Catholic Encyclopedia · newadvent.org

Second pass, 28 October 2026: every item the first pass listed as not re-checked was checked against the sources in the last seventeen rows of the table. Three corrections followed: the ending of *Caesar's Column*, the arrangement of "Girls Just Want to Have Fun," and the history of the word *fink*. Two details rest on weaker ground than the rest and are marked as such: the self-inflicted origin of the *AD* mark is attested only in fan-compiled lore, and the issue number given for Baehr (2001) was not separately confirmed.

KEYWORDS

BioShock Infinite · Ken Levine · Irrational Games · catabaptism · modal debt · speculative theology · procedural soteriology · game studies · ludonarrative dissonance · procedural rhetoric · respawn · seriality and franchise · metafiction · American exceptionalism · civil religion · city upon a hill · Manifest Destiny · frontier thesis · vertical frontier · regeneration through violence · American Adam · twice-born soul · William James · moral multiverse · millenarianism · Ghost Dance · Wounded Knee · Boxer Uprising · World's Columbian Exposition · White City · color line · whiteness studies · Africanist presence · Populism · revolutionary violence · false equivalence · theology of debt · *Schuld* · atonement · satisfaction theory · Colossians 2:14 · Revelation 21 · baptism · typology and *figura* · Anabaptism and Münster · scapegoat mechanism · *pharmakos* · divine violence · political theology · sovereignty and the exception · messianism · angel of history · many-worlds interpretation · modal realism · counterpart theory · rigid designation · initial baptism · necessity of origin · personal identity and fission · moral luck · counterfactual culpability · theodicy · Palace of the Fates · *felix culpa* · antinatalism · kenosis · structural narratology · constants and variables · captive daughter · Akedah · Jephthah's daughter · Omelas · hauntology · anachronism · floating city · Laputa · Atlantis · Rapture · Borges · Le Guin · Calderón · Kierkegaard · Nietzsche · Leibniz · Kripke · Benjamin · Girard · Freud · Dante · Camus · eternal recurrence · amor fati · the absurd · death drive · the double · Molinism · middle knowledge · exaleiphō